crowned in flowers

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by Irrwisch

Summary

“What does dying feel like?”
Mydei stills. He could tell him of different sensations of death. He could tell him what it feels like when life ebbs out of your veins, and you can only watch it happen. He could tell him how the swift stab of a blade snuffs life out like a wayward candle. He could tell him that the River of Souls is a cold climb, with sweet voices whispering from beyond the shore, beckoning him to join them, relish in their touches yet again, after all the time that has passed.
Mydei gathers Phainon in his arms, burying his head in the Deliverer’s neck. Phainon is limp enough that it might be concerning, so Mydei just holds him tighter.
“You will find no comfort there.”
“No,” Phainon agrees, “such things are long beyond me.”
|
"May the Son of Gorgo be crowned in flowers."

Notes

Hello! Thanks for clicking on this! I hope you'll enjoy it~
It's my first "shippy" fic for this fandom uwu Second (and probably last) chapter will come soon! (Unless this tanks, then it'll take longer. Haha!)
Let me know if you liked it~

See the end of the work for more notes

Chapter 1: for the flowers in your hair

“What does dying feel like?”

It’s a shame that it never gets dark in Okhema. Mydei truly misses the blanket of the night, but they make do. If he truly desires the dark, he can always travel outside of Okhema and spend a few days somewhere else – it’s not like he’s chained down. They have the window open with the blinds down, because Mydei likes to at *least* remember what darkness looks like. There’s a soft breeze coming in, and he can feel it brush past his nose. He’s not cold, though, and it’s a pleasant thing.

They lie naked under the covers, blue with sunflower motif, and Phainon’s cheek is mushed into Mydei’s collarbone. Neither of them has moved for a long time, and were he not so attuned to the other man’s breathing, one could’ve believed the Deliverer fell asleep. But so, Phainon suddenly speaking doesn’t startle him much. His hand lies lazily on the man’s waist, caressing the skin with his thumb. Phainon’s hand is planted squarely on Mydei’s chest and he’s surprised the man hasn’t started tapping his fingers yet.

“Why do you ask?”

Maybe he should be more concerned. He doesn’t like discussing the topic of death with Phainon, because – the thought of it alone terrifies him. It’s why he’s so adamant about charging into the fray first every time – not only because he knows he can trust Phainon with his back, but also because it’ll mean he’ll face the front of their assault on his own. More enemies on him mean fewer enemies on Phainon, which, in turn, translates into less chance for Phainon to die. Mydeimos has watched too many of his loved ones perish before him, and if Phainon were ever to join their ranks... he’s not sure what he’d do. Maybe he’d go as mad as Nikador has.

“I don’t know,” Phainon replies and that’s a lie, “I guess I’m just curious.”

Mydei breathes out and lifts Phainon's hand with his own, kissing the fingertips gently. Phainon always has ridiculous short nails, even for a warrior – they're cut down until the very flesh and at times Mydei worries if it hurts. He never asks, though, because Phainon never seems to care about it. In lieu of answering, he starts to suckle on the fingers, pressing them down on his tongue. Phainon lets him, but he can feel Phainon pouting against his skin. That's good. He likes it whenever Phainon pouts – it means he's still here. Because sometimes – sometimes, Phainon just goes away. Not physically, no, but – mentally. They can sit somewhere together, or lie somewhere and anything, and sometimes, sometimes, Phainon just wanders off. It rarely happens when he's keeping busy, and he would never dare to zone out even in the slightest in front of any citizen. So, in a way, Mydei should be honoured that Phainon keeps drifting away in his presence, shouldn't he? He thought about asking Castorice and Hyacine, if they had similar experiences, but on the off-chance that they don't – Mydei wouldn't want to be the one to expose his friend like that.

"Don't think I've forgotten that you're avoiding my question."

Mydei moves Phainon's hand up, so he can press his lips against the man's palm. Phainon, in turn, taps his fingers against Mydei's forehead in annoyance. His hair tickles against Mydei's neck as Phainon shifts, and he lifts himself up so he can look Mydei in the eyes. He's not removing his hand, though, so Mydei keeps holding it.

"It's unpleasant. Don't try."

Phainon blinks, then he sighs big, involving his whole body.

"You're so eloquent, Mydei... I wasn't going to, you know. I was just – curious."

"If you die before I do, I'll kill you. And after that, I'll rip the whole River of Souls apart to get you back."

Phainon blushes, and then he ducks down, hiding his burning face in Mydei's chest. He just smiles in sweet victory. It's too easy, really, to get the Deliverer to blush like a virgin maiden.

“I don’t know how you can just say stuff like that... you have no shame, truly! What am I even supposed to answer to that?!”

“Nothing,” Mydei tells him, “just let me kiss you.”

“Ugh, you never stop, do you...? Do you even hear yourself when you talk?”

Softly, Mydei cups his cheek and pulls his face closer, kissing him gently. Phainon’s lips are always somewhat dry, no matter what kind of salve he tries out. Mydei would know, he’s helped the man test them out – they all failed the taste test, he had to admit. But it’s alright; it just means that Mydei has to kiss him more often to soften his lips up. Phainon lets out a little sigh and gives up the remaining tension in his body, lowering himself fully down on Mydei’s body. He enjoys the weight of the Deliverer, and he’s sure Phainon knows it too, even though he’s never actually said so. Mydei flips them over carefully; supporting Phainon’s head with his hand so he doesn’t accidentally gets hit by something. Not that Phainon would be a stranger to hitting his head on things, it *can* be avoided. Phainon’s fingers trail carefully over Mydei’s sides, always just the ghost of a touch. Most times, Mydei wishes the man would mark him somehow. Bite him, scratch him, leave hickeys all over, but Phainon never does. His excuse is that Mydei shows off his *ridiculous* body at every opportunity and he wouldn’t want to cause questions to occur, even though Mydei wouldn’t care about that. He knows how to handle people. (By staring at them, maybe offering a one-syllable answer, and then walking away to let Phainon handle the rest. It’s worked flawlessly so far.)

At any rate, Mydeimos tends to walk away from their trysts spot-free. Phainon, on the other hand, is free game. Mydei makes sure that by the time they’re done, Phainon is covered in all sorts of marks. Except – except for one spot. His neck. His beautiful, perfect neck that he carries for the world to see. The fact that Kephale got to Phainon first, and marked him as theirs, has always irked Mydei far more than it had any right. Phainon would look good with the Kremnoan Sigil on his neck, he’s sure of it. Krateros would probably suffer an instant heart attack, but that’s what they have Hyacine for, right?

He leaves Phainon's mouth to hear the man take in deep breaths, while Mydei wanders down, almost sucking a bruise on the unblemished side of his neck before refraining, moving to his chest. His nipples are pink and pretty, still perked up from before. Mydei likes biting them, and he likes seeing Phainon wince the day after when his clothes brush over his nipples wrong. He leans down, giving a long lick over one nub while pressing the pad of his finger down on the other. Phainon wiggles underneath him, putting his hands on Mydei's shoulders.

"Don't tease," he reprimands as Mydei starts to bite down.

"You like it," Mydeimos counters and Phainon softly bonks his fist on his head. But as per his Deliverer's wishes, he moves on, peppering soft kisses over the man's belly, sucking another mark on his hips before ghosting his lips over Phainon's half-hard cock. The man lets out a soft gasp, evolving into a moan when Mydei wraps his lips around him, sucking gently. Phainon pulls at Mydei's hair, still so sensitive from earlier, but he doesn't relent, only letting go once Phainon has grown hard again. The man's body twitches and Mydei watches him for a moment. His skin is flushed, pale as he is, and he's biting his lip.

He's beautiful. Like this, everyday, everywhere. Mydei wishes he had the words to articulate that, but he's not good saying things like that – he always comes across as too brash and too rude. But Phainon knows, surely? He has to. With a final kiss to the leaking tip of his dick, Mydei pushes Phainon's legs up and apart and settles himself between.

The Deliverer's hole is still partly stretched, worked and fucked open just a few hours ago. Mydei circles the rim with his finger and Phainon kicks his leg out. Mydei chuckles before he pushes his finger in, going easily.

"Mydei, you brute...!"

"You take me so well, Deliverer," he murmurs, "I suppose you missed me?"

"Fuck you!"

Mydei laughs. That's a *Yes,* if he's ever heard one. He moves his finger in and out, crooking it at the right spot, making Phainon arch his back and moan. He never tires of looking at Phainon when he makes those sounds and those faces. Only he gets to see this. Only him, and nobody else. He'll kill anyone else. Only *he* gets to see their precious Deliverer like that.

"Please... Mydeimos, quit teasing me...!"

"Alright, alright."

He pushes himself up slightly and he allows himself one moment to look at Phainon from above. His cock is still hard, twitching and leaking onto his taut stomach. His body is dusted by a pretty blush and he looks up at Mydei with hooded eyes and parted lips. He feels his own dick give a very interested twitch at the picture before him.

Breathing out, he grabs the base and slowly presses his cockhead against Phainon's hole, gently pressing in. There's little resistance and the man takes him easily. Phainon gasps loudly, arching his back higher until Mydei is all bottomed out. They both breathe for a moment before Mydei leans down and catches Phainon's parted lips in a soft kiss. He moans against it, swinging his arms around Mydei's neck, pulling him deeper. He goes easily, starting to move his hips slowly. Phainon wraps his legs loosely around him, making sure he can't go too far.

They part, breathing into each other's mouth. He knows neither of them is going to last long, and they don't have to. Phainon is clenching hard around him already, and Mydei can feel his own orgasm rising up in his belly.

"Close," he murmurs against Phainon's nose and the man just nods in agreement. Mydei closes his eyes and concentrates on the feeling of Phainon's walls around him, how it keeps sucking him in, unwilling to let go. Phainon gasps and moans and he tightens around Mydei, pulling him flush against him and he can feel the man come undone; his spend spraying between their bellies and Mydeimos growls, moving a little faster; fucking Phainon through his orgasm until he, too, reaches his peak and releases deep inside Phainon's fucked-out hole.

They come down quietly, with soft kisses shared in-between.

“We gotta get clean again,” Phainon whines, “I woke up crusted *once* and had to suffer the entire day, *despite* numerous baths. Go fetch the basin, Mydeimos.”

“I remember, HKS,” he responds, slipping out of Phainon, “you would not shut up about it.”

Phainon pouts as Mydei gets up to retrieve some water and some cloth. He doesn’t mind, despite what he might make Phainon believe. And whatever mood his friend had been in earlier had seemed to have dissipated, so that’s good. He needs Phainon to stay away from his own death for as long as possible.

Mydeimos could not walk on this flame-chase journey without Phainon by his side.

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Despite what some might believe, Mydei and Phainon do have different day plans. They just happen to overlap on occasion – after all, there’s no one else to spar with for either of them. Castorice might be a worthy contender, but her curse makes that an impossibility. And throwing hands with Aglaea would possibly get him exiled. So, there really only is Phainon, and it’s not like they spar *all* day.

Now, Okhema is preparing for a festival and Phainon, ever-involved, is heavily participating in the preparations. One could think that he’s organising it all by himself, the way he talks. Not that Mydei asks, but something as trivial as questions have never stopped Phainon from yapping. He has, for his own defence, asked if he could help. So far, Phainon has declined, but Mydei remains on stand-by. The Deliverer might need last-minute help, and Mydei wants to be ready to carry chairs or tables. Also, it

would give him an excuse to flex to Phainon and have the Deliverer flex in return. It's the little things that keep them going, really.

Today, however, he is spending time with some of the Kremnoan children. They often ask him to play, much like he's instructed them, and he often agrees to their games. He doesn't always have the time, but he tries to carve some out regardless. He knows that whenever he is on a solo mission, the children haunt Phainon about it – they've reported back how willing the Deliverer was to make time for them. Mydei is glad to know that even in his absence; his people would have someone they could turn to – even though Phainon is probably one of the only people he knows that can never say *No*.

The children drag him by the hands and he puts up a token resistance. Even though they are still children, they are children of Kremnos, and as such, they must be taught how to fight. They'll win, of course, but still. It's mostly to appease Krateros who would rather see him battle-train these children. If they could grow up healthy and happy, with no blood coating their hands and minds, their world could be a gentler one. He alone cannot change it, but he can start, can't he? Maybe one of them will remember in the far future, and will choose to do the same, and so on and so on. He tells Phainon about it sometimes, and Phainon always nods solemnly, like he does when something is really important and he swore to him, by Kephale's name, that he would not forget this.

"Deli showed this to us," Elias says, as he tugs Mydei down onto the grass. There are not many wild-growing flowers in Okhema itself, but here blooms an entire field of them. Mydei wonders if Castorice has had her hand in this. Even if she cannot touch them, she likes sowing flowers. And come to think of it, Phainon's from a farm, isn't he? He would know how to grow plants. And adding Hyacine into the mix, he can see this field bloom in no time. Aglaea probably approved of it, as well.

"Deli? You mean the Deliverer?"

The children nod. Petra grins widely, showing off her tooth-gap: "Uh-hu! Deli's brought us here last time you were gone!"

Mydei frowns and looks around again. Honestly, he can picture it. Phainon doesn't like fighting, not in the way that Mydeimos does. He's a terrific fighter, and Mydei would not want to be on the oppose site of the Deliverer's blade – even though Mydeimos would win, obviously. He has far more in-battle experience than Phainon. Come to think of it, now that the kids said it – he's never seen Phainon in a place like this. The closest is probably the Garden of Life with the chimeras, but that's about it. Could it be that the Deliverer is embarrassed? No, that can't be right. *Shame* is a word that does not exist in the dictionary of Phainon.

"I see," he responds, "so what do you want to do today?"

In the end, they always arrive at the same game: a knight saves the princess from a ruthless dragon. Mydei has played all the roles before, even though he does very poorly as the princess. The children are very adamant about him saying his lines right, and so he messes up constantly. Being a damsel in distress is not exactly his forte – Phainon is much better at this. He has that instant dramatic flair he can put on and Mydei is almost sure the man can faint on command. Today, at least, he gets to be the scary dragon. Those lines aren't that hard. He's had an edgy phase before, he can do this.

So, as per the play dictates, he gets heroically defeated and the princess he so ruthlessly stole gets liberated.

"Has the ferocious beast already been felled? Shucks, I got here too late, didn't I?"

At Phainon's voice, Mydei peeks up from where he lies slain on the ground. The children who had been dancing around his dead body, have stopped and eagerly greeted the surprise guest.

"You are!" They shout and Mydei sits up. "The princess got the final hit in!"

"Oh, really? What a true Kremnoan princess that must've been! I have expected nothing less from noble Kremnoan knights and princesses! How about we reward our heroes?"

Mydei chuckles as the kids scream in agreement. Phainon claps his hands once and shoos them off while Mydei frowns. Their reward is running away? Then Phainon finally looks at him and grins brightly. It's always bright in Okhema, always illuminated by the eternal Dawn Device, but that damn smile makes every day shine ever brighter.

The Deliverer, child that he is, crawls over to Mydei. If Aglaea sees the grass stains on his pants, it won't be Mydei's problem.

"I didn't know dead dragons could sit upright. Is it a Kremnoan thing?"

"HKS, I will punch your nose. What's this *reward* that has the children fleeing the premises?"

"Their reward is the freedom to live the life they choose, far away from knightly regimes and courtly duties," Phainon replies without missing a beat, putting his hand over his heart for dramatic effect. He even shakes his head wistfully. Mydei wants to punch him.

"But no," Phainon then laughs, "we're going to make flower crowns. Don't think too little of me for that, okay?"

He pushes against Mydei's face as he stands up, while Mydei remains partly seated, confused. He doesn't understand. Why would he think less of Phainon for literally *any* reason? He's seen the guy ass-up in the air because he slipped on something. He's seen Phainon trying to look cool for points, just to topple over in the most crucial moment. He's seen the guy sweet-talk a man out of his last pair of pants, just to have him turn around and say the stupidest shit Mydei has ever been forced to hear. By Strife's name, he would not think any less of Phainon if the Deliverer turned against the flame-chase itself.

Phainon has sat down again a little while away and he accepts the flowers the children bring him with a wide smile. They excitedly gather around him as he, what Mydei presumes, starts to make the crowns. All the kids smile brightly, with sparks shining in their eyes – why in all the worlds would Mydei think less of Phainon for *that*?

If anything, it makes him think *more* of him. Carefully, he makes his way over to the group.

“...back home. Alright, now you give it a try! Don’t worry if it comes out crooked. Help each other, if you need it; and don’t be shy to offer your assistance! If you need any help, you can always come and ask me!”

The kids scatter again, ready to pick out more flowers. Mydei sits down next to Phainon, looking at the flower crown he’s made. They’re all different colours, and it looks well-made, just like he expected from Phainon.

“It looks good, Deliverer, well done,” he praises and Phainon jumps.

“Titans! Mydeimos, why are you sneaking around like that?! You scared the living daylights out of me! Warn a guy next time, would you?”

“I shall not,” Mydei counters, “a warrior should always be aware of his surroundings.”

Phainon pouts and he turns away, but at least he doesn’t get up. It seems like he didn’t hear or register the praise he’s been given, or he’s chosen to ignore it. Mydei believes in the first, because Phainon and praise have an interesting relationship with each other. He would not be able to ignore it.

“Show me,” he says then, poking the hand that holds the crown. Phainon makes a confused noise before he looks down.

“Oh,” he says, sighing, “it’s nothing special, really. Hyacine makes prettier ones.”

He lifts it up and shows it to Mydei. He doesn’t believe Phainon’s words – and he’s almost sure that, even if Hyacine’s flower crowns are prettier, he would always prefer the ones Phainon made.

“Don’t undermine yourself, Deliverer. It isn’t like you to concede defeat before the duel has even started.”

Phainon laughs and he casts his gaze over the flower-gathering children. “Yes, I suppose... it’s not like me at all.”

He stops and gets that wistful look in his eyes, the one that Mydei doesn’t like. As much as Phainon talks, he never *says* anything. Mydei knows *nothing* about Aedes Elysiae except that Phainon’s from there and that there are golden fields. But in the same note, he himself has not shared much of his own past. At times, Phainon reminds him of all his lost friends, but he’s almost certain if he were to say so – Phainon might take it the wrong way. He’s... delicate like that. Mydei doesn’t mind, but Phainon *would*. Some things are better left unsaid, no matter how true they are.

But then Phainon smiles again, and he turns back to him, wistfulness all forgotten. He lifts the flower crown and without much preamble, places it square on Mydei’s head.

“There,” he concludes, smiling softly, “a crown fit for a prince. Instead of blood, let the son of Gorgo be crowned in flowers on this day, and all days forth hence.”

He will never tell Phainon, not in this life or the next, but Mydeimos keeps coming here, to this little garden of flowers, and he spends many hours trying to learn how to weave a crown. His own will eventually wither and die, but he will never get rid of the petals, choosing to keep them close-by, pressed in a book, so that he will always remember, even should Strife’s madness one day claim him:

May the son of Gorgo be crowned in flowers.

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“Deliverer,” he calls Phainon when he finally locates him. The Deliverer is currently busy hanging up garlands all over the town square. Several people

are holding his ladder, staying close in case he falls and to give him directions on where to fasten the garland.

“What? Oh, Mydei! Just wait a moment! Is this good?”

Several people respond to him and Mydeimos stays a little afar, observing. He nearly has a heart attack when Phainon lets go of the ladder entirely to bind the garland tight, trusting only his legs to hold him. Now, his thighs are strong and sturdy, of course, but still... his Deliverer cannot be this stupid, right? What if he slips and breaks his neck? He, of all people, has to make it to the end of the road. Mydei closes his eyes and takes a couple deep, steadying breaths. It’s by miracle alone that he has no grey hair just yet. Maybe he was lucky with Phainon and Cipher hogging them all.

“Thanks, guys! I’ll join you in a moment, alright? Take a little break, I’ll be right back! So, Mydei, what’s up?”

Mydei re-opens his eyes to Phainon standing before him. His cheeks are a little flushed from the current heat spreading through Okhema. Honestly, with the man’s little tolerance for heat; Mydei wonders why he’s so insistent to dragging them to the hot baths for their competitions.

“You should wear less clothing if you heat so easily.”

Phainon pouts, and crosses his arms in defiance. “What, are you asking me to run around as indecently as you? You might have no quarrels showing off that indestructible body of yours, but some of us are not that free-going.”

Mydei frowns. “You are sweating, Deliverer.”

“What, I thought you liked that about me. Just last night, you –“

“Be that as it may,” he interrupts him quickly, because those things are *just* for him and him alone, “I am here to inform you that Aglaea has assigned me a mission.”

Phainon blinks in surprise. “Oh? A solo mission? Well, I guess I *am* busy... but so shortly before the festival? Will you even be back by then?”

Mydei nods while crossing his arms. In truth, he isn't sure. While the objective is not difficult – clear out Titankin and whatever black tide creatures they'd come across – one can never be too assured of victory, even when you are Mydeimos the Undying. He also will not go entirely alone, as he will be accompanied by a couple Kremnoan and Okheman guards. All in all, he has little reason to worry; he alone would be more than enough to deal with a threat this size.

"It is not far, and a couple guards will come with me. While I cannot guarantee I will be on time, you have my word that I shall dispose of the Titankin as hastily as I can."

Phainon chuckles, putting a hand on his hip. "I'd rather you stay safe than rush. The festival will last for a week, so there's no harm if you'd miss the opening ceremony. I'll make sure to order some pomegranate juice, regardless. I've already messaged the vendors to make sure that they'll be enough, so don't worry about it running out. I also made sure that there'll be some sweet wine, if you're feeling fancy."

Something tugs at Mydei's chest. Phainon doesn't even like pomegranate juice. He's not even fond of alcohol. And still, he made sure... Mydei lowers his eyes, hoping to hide the blush on his face. Quick, he has to think of something to say before he does something stupid, like kiss the Deliverer's dumb face in public.

"I appreciate it. Anyway, I just wanted to let you know, lest you go crazy from looking for me."

"Are you departing today?"

"Yes," he confirms, "I am in fact on my way right now. The sooner I depart, the sooner I will be able to return."

Phainon nods. "Let me see you to the gates, then. The others can surely use a longer break under this blazing heat."

Phainon, as per usual, doesn't wait, and strides towards the main city gates. Mydei sighs before he follows. He can find the way just fine on his own; he

didn’t just arrive here yesterday. But still... having Phainon there to see him off would be nice, even though – even though knowing that Phainon would watch him leave would tempt Mydeimos to look back; to make sure the Deliverer is still watching him.

They part at the gates without sharing many words between them. Phainon squeezes his hand for a moment, and Mydei squeezes back. The Deliverer isn’t too fond of true public affection – unless that affection means he throws himself all over Mydei’s back, but according to him, that’s a completely different thing. So, sure, whatever, if it lets Phainon sleep at night. It doesn’t, Mydei knows, but hey.

“Don’t die, will you?”

“It’s more likely you’ll break your neck hanging up garlands. See you tomorrow, Deliverer.”

Phainon smiles and waves as Mydei leaves. Despite his burning desire to turn around and have one last look, he doesn’t. He’s not alone, and he wishes to preserve his remaining dignity. He would’ve really liked to kiss Phainon good-bye.

They travel a day and night’s worth of distance before they spot their target in the distance. Mydei can’t see any obvious threats from afar, but caution is still advised. There might still be civilians hiding, as well, so they will need to account for that, as well.

“Come,” he tells his companions, “tread with care. Aglaea’s reports were unable to verify the status of any potential civilians, so you must watch out for them. Focus on the Titankin; and leave any black tide creatures to me. Don’t engage with them unless necessary.”

The men nod, and they all set out. Mydei barely knows these people, but they were hand-picked by someone who would know to choose the best. He trusts he won’t have to babysit them, and he already misses Phainon by his side. By now, the man would’ve suggested at least two different challenge

ideas, and Mydei would've agreed to all of them. Well, he can still count how many he kills, can't he? It's not much to brag about, not without hearing how many Phainon has felled, but it'll still be nice to bring home a big number to hold over Phainon's head.

In the meantime, he hopes the Deliverer eats enough. He has a tendency to forget simple things like that, and it's why he tends to live by a strict plan so that it'll be harder to slip his mind. It still happens, sometimes, and he's only reminded by his loudly grumbling stomach by the second time he drags Mydei off to the baths. At which, it's too late for him to properly eat anything, so Mydei usually just stuffs his throat with whatever fruit they have lying around.

"Lord Mydeimos!"

Ah, perhaps that's a good thing. He never stops thinking about Phainon once he really gets into it, and that's a terrible habit on the battlefield. He rushes over to his group who have located some monster prowling the premises. Mydei makes short work of them, and together, they stand against the enemies coming their way. They're hardly any trouble, and it's laughably easy to dispose of. Seriously, why did Aglaea send him? The guards could've handled this on their own, just as well. Well, perhaps it is better to be safe. She wouldn't have sent him on this mission if she didn't believe it was necessary; and she has never disappointed him so far.

Sadly, they can find no survivors. Corpses are plenty, but at least they haven't been corrupted by the black tide. They gather the bodies they can find and set the pile ablaze. Neither Kremnos nor Okhema burn their dead, but with the black tide claiming more and more ground, they cannot leave bodies out to rot. Phainon would've vowed to remember them, even if he never knew them, so in his absence, Mydei vows it instead silently to himself. He's not sure if he will tell Phainon of the dead or not, but maybe luck will be on his side this time: Phainon doesn't always ask, particular when he's busy with something else.

"Shall we head back straight away, Lord Mydeimos?"

He blinks back to his companions, and then he observes the sky. They are far ahead of schedule. Admittedly, they have pushed themselves a little getting here, and there's no big rush to return. So he shakes his head.

"No," he states, "make camp nearby. We won today, we can rest easy tonight. I will go procure game while you set up."

The men nod and Mydei turns around, staking out some animal nearby. The black tide hardly cares for the critters of the world and once more Mydei wonders how sentient it truly is. It surely stands in their way more often than not, but he's hesitant to call it a natural disaster. He's also loathe to pin it on the black-clad swordsman that Phainon has talked about. While it seems true that the tide follows to where the swordsmaster goes – if it were truly so, why would they not head into Okhema? Aglaea's threads cannot contain the black tide for all eternity, and Kephale has been silent ever since. Maybe he's overthinking it. Maybe it truly *is* a natural disaster, and they just have to live with long enough until the Deliverer can bring the new dawn. And yet, something about it – something about it sits wrong with him, like he *should* have some idea. He kills a rabbit instead, and another, and brings it back to the campfire.

It's hardly a feast, but it fills their bellies with some warm, fresh meat, and that has to be better than the dried rations that they've brought with them.

"Will you attend the festival when we return?"

Mydei nods. It's a given, isn't it? "The Deliverer will not let me sit it out."

The men laugh. It's common knowledge that Phainon drags Mydei all over Okhema without room to protest. Not that Mydei *would* protest – much – but nobody has to know that. It does his pride better if they think it's against his will.

"Leander, what will you get Helena as a gift?"

Mydei perks up. Gift? The festival requires gift-giving? Phainon hasn't mentioned anything about that.

“I commissioned her a necklace. You know she misses the sea, so the pendant’s gonna look like a seashell. I do hope it’ll be done by the time the festival rolls around, but if not, she’ll understand.”

“The festival includes gift-giving?”

The men turn to him. “Well, not officially, but it’s a nice tradition. I didn’t know you had a sweetheart, Lord Mydei! I’m sure she’ll forgive you, since you’re still kind of new to Okhem – hey!”

One of the others had boxed the man hard in the side, but Mydei hardly cared. A gift... would Phainon expect a gift? Perhaps he should’ve asked Aglaea or Tribbie more about that festival when Phainon brought it up first. But now, he won’t have enough time left to procure something. And even if he asked Chartonus to forge Phainon a sword – Phainon has to get new swords all the time because he *keeps* breaking them. Phainon might not even expect a gift... but he’d still be disappointed, such is human nature. Maybe he could give into Phainon’s whims more willingly... but he *always* indulges the man, so that’s hardly anything special.

They have not said *I love you* yet. It always felt too real, and some stupid, idiotic part of him gnarls at the thought. What would Hephaestion think? Would it be fair to him? But Hephaestion is dead, has been dead for many years. The dead should hold no grudges, and yet... and yet, if he would never say it to Phainon, would it be fair to *him*?

Ugh, there *is* a reason he prefers actions. Maybe he’ll just kiss Phainon in the way he likes. Mark his entire body in the way he aches for. It won’t be enough, but it’s all Mydei can offer.

“Don’t think so hard on it, Lord Mydei,” another of his companions says, away from the two that are still squabbling, “whoever your special someone is, I’m sure they’ll enjoy just having you by their side.”

“Even if I could gift them nothing?”

“Sometimes,” that companion says, smiling, “we ourselves are gift enough already.”

Chapter 2: blood on thy fingertips

Chapter Notes

> Hello, I am back again! On courtesy of having most of this written already pre-posting Chapter 1, haha! Meaning the wait time for the next one might be a little longer... but if all goes well, we'll have some sexy times. Yes, you and me.
> Also, I do really want to point at the tags. (If you feel like I missed any, don't hesitate to (kindly) inform me of it!)
> Without further ado, I hope you enjoy~

They return to Okhema the night before the festival. Most people are already asleep, and while Mydei is certain that Aglaea would still roam at this hour, he supposes his report can wait until tomorrow, at least – especially since nothing noteworthy had occurred. He bids his companions farewell and makes his way to his quarters. One would think, perhaps, that he should seek out Phainon's abode instead, but if he did, he'd find nothing but emptiness in there. Whenever they leave for solo missions, the one that stays behind just... gravitates towards the home of the other. After all, even if they did not live together officially, they – both lived in both places. Mydei's home was Phainon's, just as much as Phainon's was his. Normally, they stayed at Phainon's, when they were both in Okhema and Mydei has never really questioned why. Maybe it's because Phainon has stuffed his room full of bits and bobs, which makes the place feel strangely lived in. And maybe... maybe it's the smell. The place smells so strongly of Phainon – unsurprisingly – that Mydei just feels at comfort there. Not that he would ever admit that.

But now, he knows Phainon will likely snore against Mydei's pillows. Hopefully he didn't drool on them, silk is such a pain... Phainon will most likely be wrapped into one of Mydei's tunics and that – well, it does make Mydei a little bit possessive, he's not going to lie about that. It just *does* things to him.

He opens the door quietly, knowing how light Phainon rests, if he rests at all. He pushes the door back into the lock as slowly as he can, and he makes his way over to his bedchambers on quiet feet. He debates whether or not to wake Phainon so they can make out a little, but he quickly decides against it. Phainon will have been busy today, and Mydei himself is tired from the journey. He just wants to hold the man, and bury his nose in the silken, white hair and wake to Phainon papping his hands on his cheeks in an attempt to wake him up. It's such a childish notion that Mydei can't help but cherish it.

But Phainon is not in his bed. Now, of course, it's perhaps easiest to assume that Phainon is in his own home, asleep in his own bed in his own clothes. But Mydei knows better than that. He knows for a fact that Phainon has not seen the inside of his own place in the time Mydei has been gone, other than for absolute necessities, and even then, everything Phainon could need would already be here. Mydei squeezes the door handle a little, dreading the immediate future. He lets out a silent breath, steeling himself. For all his prowess, for all his strength, he is never strong enough for *this*, and yet he's left with no choice.

Silently, he turns to the right, to the adjacent washroom. He reaches for the handle, stops for a moment, and then grabs it, pulling it down to enter. Kephale's dawn lights everything in eternal brightness, so nothing can stay hidden. He indeed finds Phainon wrapped in one of his tunics that the man must've fished out of the closet. Red suits him, and Mydei wishes to see him in it more.

"Oh hey, Mydei... you're back earlier than I thought. Smooth sailing, I take it? That's good, that's good... and you're just in time for the opening ceremony, too. You'll like it. I got the juice, just like I promised. I sampled the sweet wine – Castorice helped me. She said it's grand, so I hope you'll like it. Hyacine even dropped by! Not Professor Anaxa though, but I wasn't expecting him. I've already organised a care package... I'm debating if I should take it to him or just hand it over to Hyacine. What do you think?"

Phainon is sitting in the small washing area, barely looking at him. He's smiling, but it's a practiced one, one that he almost never directs towards Mydei. Mydeimos steps into the room fully and slowly kneels down next to

Phainon, gently taking one of his arms. Phainon doesn't react, and lets him do as he pleases. The cuts aren't deep, but there are plenty of them. Some are scabbed over, and others look re-opened, while others yet look far too fresh. The puddle on the floor has not yet dried, but that means little in the grand scheme of things.

"It's been a while since you've visited him," Mydei answers as he reaches for the first aid kit. They have stashed several of those all over their place – both his and Phainon's. The ones in Phainon's home need replenishments far more often, and Mydei would rather not think of it.

Phainon simply nods as he lets Mydei handle his left arm first, then the right one.

"You're right. He should grill me again over my convictions. What a debate champion I am, huh? I can't even win one debate against my own professor – but to be fair, I keep thinking we're talking about different topics every time. I'm still not sure what a dromas has to do with the hypothesis of the cave's allegory, but whatever. Ah, that's too tight. Grab that gauze there, yeah? I did my thigh too – just the one this time, isn't that great?"

Mydei doesn't respond, and grabs the gauze. The gashes on Phainon's thigh are far longer and deeper than the ones on his arm, but he always avoids major arteries. Dutifully, Mydei wraps the wounds gently, just loose enough so Phainon won't complain.

"I had that dream again," Phainon says, absent-mindedly tapping his slender fingers on Mydei's shoulder. "At this point, it's driving me just a little mad. You reckon that's what Nikador feels like?"

"No," Mydei responds as he finishes up. Sometimes, Phainon says, he has dreams of killing himself. In his dream, he goes to challenge himself at the end of the world, and in turn, he is challenged by himself, and in the end, he kills himself and he is killed, and he lives and he dies, and he remains and he leaves. Mydei doesn't pretend to understand, even though Tribbie would have something to say about it. Dreams are often messages sent by the gods, after all, but whatever message this holds, Mydei would rather not know.

“Yeah, probably not, huh? Nice work as always, Mydeimos. I bleed through my own patch-work faster than a dog in heat. ...don’t think too hard on that. You’ll come to the festival with me today, won’t you? Even Castorice will show up, and I’ve already organised a table in the corner for everyone. I mentioned the juice, right? I didn’t taste-test that, but I got milk, too... ah, look at me, babbling. How was your campaign? Any difficulties?”

“No,” Mydei replies curtly and carefully gathers Phainon in his arms. He’s no idea how long Phainon’s been sitting here, or how long he’s kept this up. An ugly voice tells him that Phainon’s probably started again way before Mydei had left. He never promises that this time will be the last, because they both know it would be a lie. He never says he’s sorry either, because that would be yet another lie. In some way, Mydei can appreciate that.

“You look good in my clothes,” he says as he sets his lover on the bed.

“I know, I know. It’s a makeshift solution, you know? You never leave anything behind that smells like you do. So I put on this tunic of yours and strut about the room, proclaiming *I am Mydeimos the Undying, respect my name*, all in that huff-huff tone of yours. Sometimes I puff my chest, too. *There’s no word for anything in the Kremnoan language, hurr-hurr.”*

Mydei flicks his finger against Phainon’s forehead. He won’t say the man’s impression is spot-on, because it’s *not*, but he’s getting better at imitating Mydei’s cadence. Phainon pouts and rubs his forehead, as if it *hurt*.

“I don’t like seeing your blood,” Mydei says, settling into bed next to the man. Rationally, he should clean the washroom, but it’s tile, and it should be easy to wash off come tomorrow. Besides, he doesn’t want to leave Phainon out of his side right now.

“And I don’t like seeing you die, and yet you still do.”

“It’s different, Deliverer. I can’t die.”

“And *yet* you still do. You still fall, and each time I wonder if this is the last time. I can hardly accompany you everywhere, babysitting you.”

He’s not wrong. Despite what Mydei might claim, he *does* try to be more careful if Phainon is with him. He has no delusions that Phainon can handle whatever comes his way, but just the thought of leaving him to fend for himself, possibly with the useless notion of protecting Mydei’s dead body... it would always put him at a disadvantage.

The first time – the first time Mydeimos had fallen alongside Phainon, the Deliverer had almost pierced his throat again just after returning. He had been – angry would be too timid a word. These pretty blue eyes, bright and calm and beautiful had been anything but. All warmth had left them and there was *nothing* but fury blazing through, and in that moment, not even Nikador in all their madness could have rivalled Phainon. The Deliverer’s body had been shaking from rage alone, surrounded by all the titankin he’s slaughtered during Mydei’s absence. Still, what Mydei remembers most is the blazing sun shining so bright behind his head, blinding everything. For just a moment, still groggy from death, Mydeimos had believed he gazed upon a god.

And then, Phainon had stomped his stomach with his foot, and that moment had been over. He’s never seen Phainon like this ever since and some days, he asks himself if he maybe simply hallucinated that.

“...it’s still different, Deliverer. I won’t ask you to stop. All I ask – let me be here.”

“What does dying feel like?”

Mydei stills. He could tell him of different sensations of death. He could tell him what it feels like when life ebbs out of your veins, and you can only watch it happen. He could tell him what it feels like to get crushed to death. He could tell him how the swift stab of a blade snuffs life out like a wayward candle. He could tell him of suffocating; of drowning. He could tell him how poison will burn your insides again and again until it finally stops; until it finally loses its potency. He could tell him that the River of Souls is a cold climb, with sweet voices whispering from beyond the shore, beckoning him to join them, relish in their touches yet again, after all the time that has passed.

Mydei gathers Phainon in his arms, burying his head in the Deliverer's neck. Phainon is limp enough that it might be concerning, so Mydei just holds him tighter.

"You will find no comfort there."

"No," Phainon agrees, "such things are long beyond me."

When Mydei wakes at the next morn, he's alone. It takes him a solid second to panic, before he jumps up and tries scanning his surroundings for Phainon. He can't see him anywhere. Steeling his nerves, he jumps up and storms into the washroom to find nothing. Even the blood on the tiles is gone, and the first-aid kit has reappeared at its designated spot. If he were so inclined, he could simply lie to himself and say that last night hadn't happened.

He heads into the kitchen, and still finds nothing. It's not unusual for Phainon to wake earlier – a nasty side-effect of the man's everlasting insomnia – but for him to leave before Mydei even wakes? Perhaps Phainon left a note, so he goes look. And sure enough, he emerges victorious: Phainon left a note on the pillow that Mydei overlooked in his panic.

Hey sleepyhead~

I still have some preparations to complete before tonight, so I already left. I think there's some food, but I didn't look, sorry~ Oh, even though I'm sure Aglaea already knows, I let her know that you've returned and that everything went well. She'll probably still want your report, but I don't think you need to rush. I'll see you tonight at the venue, don't leave me hanging!

Phainon

Fucking asshole. What does he mean with "maybe there's food, I didn't look"?! If he skipped breakfast again... Mydei is going to throttle him and

then force the worst-cooked food known to mankind down his throat. He gently flattens the note, folds it, and puts it in his pant-pocket for safekeeping. He should go over to Phainon's place to grab a vase and then threaten to smash it into the Deliverer's thick skull.

Instead, he makes his way to Aglaea.

"Mydeimos," she greets him, "you've returned."

"So I have," he replies, "although this would be hardly a surprise to you."

"Of course not," she chuckles, "my threads have whispered of your late-night return. Even our dear Phainon dropped by earlier to report to me. How went the campaign?"

"Easy," Mydei replies, waving his hand, "your men could've accomplished it on their own, as well. So I assume you've sent me alongside them to pacify the Council – or make sure your people can return in time for the festival?"

She nods. "Why not both, I wonder? A swift victory will do wonders for morale, especially alongside the famed Crown Prince." She is quiet for a moment, weighing her words. Mydei knows what she'll ask before she does. "How is Phainon these days? He was so preoccupied with preparations; I scarcely had the opportunity to see him."

"You already know," he counters, because there are no secrets to Aglaea in this city, "so why waste your breath?"

"Perhaps I seek counsel, Mydeimos. Indulge me, please."

Mydei remains quiet, thinking. It's a breach of privacy, he knows, but – Aglaea already knows, and Phainon is neither stupid nor delusional enough to think otherwise.

"He hardly acknowledges it anymore. He must've picked up again before I had even left. Rest assured, he takes great care not to hinder your flame-chase."

It’s a rude thing to say, he knows, because despite her waning humanity, Aglaea *cares* about Phainon, but on the same hand, she just lets him do whatever he wants. He thinks that she *could* make him stop. She simply chooses not to, because of her own conflicting feelings. After all, without her threads, she would be none the wiser. Is it right of her to use her given divinity to interject into a human’s life, no matter how close they might be? But also – is it wrong if she doesn’t?

Aglaea sighs, lowering her head minutely.

“If this were all I cared about,” she says, “I would not have asked.”

“Then why do you ask *me*? I am not the one that bleeds onto Okhema’s tiles. I am not your precious Deliverer. All I do is pick up the pieces. *I* am doing my best to get the Deliverer to the final act. If there’s something you want to do, Aglaea, I suggest you *do* it without asking for permission.”

With this, he turns around and leaves her be. He can understand her indecisiveness, but he will not make the choice for her. If she needs pointers on how to approach Phainon – fine, he will help. But to ask if she *should* – that’s something she needs to figure out herself.

He runs into Castorice as he leaves.

“Lord Mydei,” she calls out to him, and he stops. “You’ve returned.”

“I did, indeed. Was there something you needed, Castorice? Aglaea is just inside, if you’re looking for her.”

She shakes her head. “Nothing that couldn’t wait. Do you want to accompany me, Lord Mydei? I was just heading down to help feed the dromases.”

He contemplates for a second, before he agrees. He doesn’t really have any plans for today, sans the festival later. He doesn’t think he’ll see Phainon again before the opening ceremony, so he might as well spend a little time

with Castorice. As they make their way down to the dromases, they engage in idle chatter. He spends far too little time with her – she doesn't make him lose his composure as easily as Phainon. It's good to sometimes have another adult to talk to.

"Have you spoken to the Deliverer recently?"

"Hm? Oh yes, a couple times, why? Did something happen?"

Mydei doesn't answer for a little. While he and Phainon aren't... official, or anything, Castorice has high stakes in their relationship. Trianne called it *fangirling* once and he doesn't want to know what means, at all.

"No, no," he lies quickly, "he's just been a little weird lately, but I suppose it might come from all the planning. He's told me you tasted the sweet wine?"

"Yes, I did. You know Lord Phainon doesn't hold his liquor well, so he's asked for my opinion. If you decide to indulge, Lord Mydei, the wine tastes excellent!"

She smiles softly and Mydei nods. Castorice is... Phainon's trusted friend, isn't she? They went to the Grove together. And maybe Hyacine were the better choice to talk to, seeing as she is a healer, but Hyacine hasn't arrived yet. And who would know more about death than Castorice?

"...something is still bothering you, Lord Mydei. Would you care to share the burden?"

Mydei averts his gaze. She's too perceptive for her own good. He's doing this out of concern. Because he cares. Because he knows that Castorice cares. And she — could give Phainon counsel whenever he was gone, couldn't she?

He breathes deep, and gestures her away from the crowd. He's already risking a lot with telling her, but a random stable-hand overhearing? No, that's the last thing they need. Dutifully, she follows him. She says nothing when he stops, just clasps her hands in front of her, waiting.

“I think — no. The Deliverer is trying to kill himself.”

He lifts his eyes and looks at her, not knowing what he’s expecting. Shock or terror, maybe? But what he finds is just quiet, pained understanding.

“I know,” she answers with a slight waiver in her voice, “Lord Phainon has never been very subtle.”

“You — you know?”

She nods. “And so do Hyacine and Professor Anaxa. Lord Phainon carries a heavy burden and I — I wish I could help. I wish *we* could help. We all hoped that, once he settled, it would get better. And then, foolishly, we believed he’d come to us when it would get worse. And yet, neither thing has happened. To this day, we keep hoping and believing that he would — come to us if he needs help. But that was foolish of us, wasn’t it?”

He can only stare at her. She knew. Aglaea knew. Hyacine and the Professor also knew. And yet, they never did anything? Phainon takes great care not to hurt himself to a point in where he wouldn’t be able to accomplish his daily tasks anymore. It’s easy to look away, he thinks. It’s easier than facing the truth.

“If one day,” his voice is raspy, “if one day you would have found him on the floor dead, drenched in his own accursed golden blood, then what would you have done?”

Castorice cannot answer him, and she bows her head in shame. He should rage — against her, against them all. They all knew of his pain, and his struggles, and yet they still took the easy smile as a fix-it-all. He balls his fists in anger, but he restrains himself. What’s the point?

“I should’ve done better. As Death’s Maiden, I should’ve done better. When I saw... when I realised, I should’ve gone to him; talked to him. But I don’t know what I should’ve said. I bring death to all I touch, so how could I tell Lord Phainon that life is worth living? So all I can do — all I did, was to ask him... that I would not lose him, too. That he, as my friend, is too important to me to lose. And yet, instead of soothing him, I fear I’ve

entrusted just another burden upon him. And I have promised him, despite the pain in my heart, that if it becomes too much — I would embrace him gently. I simply wish that this promise would've not been empty, because it is one I could never fulfil."

How can he blame her? He is hardly any different. He, too, simply witnesses Phainon's despair without being able to do any else but put yet another weight onto his shoulders.

"But you, Lord Mydei, ease him far better than all of us combined."

He blinks at that. Frowning, he looks her, and she is smiling that half-smile of hers. The wind gently brushes her hair, and she looks sincere and Castorice has never lied to him, anyway.

"I'm not — doing anything."

She shakes her head. "Perhaps that's all it needs. Someone important, doing nothing at all. Lord Phainon cares for you deeply, Lord Mydei. Losses are a constant on the flame-chase journey, so let us not squander what we can gain."

Sometimes, we ourselves are gift enough already.

Mydei doesn't see Phainon for the rest of the day, and he is pointedly *not* miffed about it, thank you very much. His days don't *revolve* around Phainon, and he's a perfectly capable human being with the Deliverer hot on his heels. But perhaps... if it's last-minute-preparations, maybe he could help. Maybe he should. He has nothing else to do, anyway. Making up his mind, he makes his way to the festival square — perhaps a little faster than need be, but who's to judge?

"Deliverer," he calls when he spots Phainon speeding about. Even from afar, he looks stressed. Upon hearing his voice, Phainon stops and looks around confused. He's carrying a large box so Mydei strides over quickly.

“Mydei!” Phainon calls out in surprise. “You’re too early, the ceremony is —“

“Shut up, HKS, I know. I came here asking if I could help. You look stressed.”

He doesn’t mention that he worries the cuts have started bleeding again. Even if they did, the blood is unlikely to seep through the thick cloth of the gold-woven threads, but still. Phainon looks down at the box in his hands, then back over his shoulder, to a large stack of boxes. He’s quiet for a moment, thinking.

“Yes,” he says then, nodding towards the boxes, “they all need to go into storage. And I still need to run a couple last-minute errands. Could you... carry the boxes? I’ll show you where they go.”

Is Phainon the sole organiser? Where the fuck is everyone else? Did they all just decide to lean the fuck back once the Deliverer joined them? No, knowing Phainon, it’s more likely that the man volunteered to take over absolutely every task.

Instead of cussing the Deliverer out, he forcefully takes the box from his arms — it’s surprisingly heavy for its size — and gestures Phainon to move. The Deliverer blinks up at him, puzzled, and then he frowns quickly, moving over into a pout, before he keeps moving. Behind him, Mydeimos smirks. He loves rattling the perfect Deliverer.

“Just put them all here — how you arrange them doesn’t matter. Just make sure they all fit inside; it’s leftover stuff from the decorations and the like, so we’re not going to suddenly need something from here. Make sure that you don’t take too long, because the Council is circling around the square, and there *are* fireworks in here, so I’m *certain* that they’d spin that to their liking again and I *already* have enough of a headache, and —“

He stops suddenly, probably realising he’s said too much in his babbling. He turns and looks Mydeimos in the eyes.

“Yeah,” he ends, “close the door.”

And then he’s off. Mydei feels his gut churn. Phainon isn’t *just* going to run some errands, is he? Perhaps tonight, he will try his utmost to hold the Deliverer gently. And tomorrow morning, he will personally carry him to the baths — Phainon doesn’t like being carried all that much, but Mydei knows he secretly enjoys it, too. If there aren’t too many people who would see them. Phainon does terrible at sitting idle, so Mydei won’t even bother asking Aglaea for a week off, but perhaps she could find a mission for them together; something simple maybe? As he mulls over his plans for the next week, he carries the boxes — and he notices that council snake Phainon mentioned. He and the council do not get along, and they keep trying their hardest to push his people outside the walls. They only don’t succeed because both Phainon and Aglaea very publicly oppose it; and because his people *are* on good behaviour.

“Is there a problem?” He decides to face the problem head-on. The snake shrivels at the sight of him, and Phainon has told him countless times that *a smile wouldn’t hurt* but Mydei knows what impression the people have of him, and he’s intending to use it.

“L-Lord Mydeimos... no, no, of course not, just making sure everything goes according to plan...”

“If you’re so concerned, then why not offer your assistance?”

“I-I could never, Lord Mydeimos, I, uh...”

Mydei’s expression doesn’t shift. He *knows* his face. He can stand here forever, staring this small man down. Perhaps it’s not the best thing to do, but at the end of the day he can’t completely deny his heritage. He *is* Kremnoan, and it’s hard to settle things with words. At least he’s not contemplating punching anyone, at least not yet.

“Mydei!” Phainon’s voice calls and his shoulders immediately relax; just a tiny bit. He can’t help it, that’s just the effect the Deliverer has on him. “And the... Councillor? Everything alright, I hope? Oh, did you want to help us? That’s great! I really appreciate it, you know? Us Chrysos Heirs and the Council of Elders really should work together more often. Let me

think for a moment — we'd need a task suitable for your honoured position, after all..."

Mydei stops listening. There's fresh blood on the Deliverer's fingertips. Against his skin, it's barely visible, but Mydei knows what he sees. It hadn't been there last night. It hadn't been there twenty minutes ago. His hold on the crate tightens and he hopes he would not break it. He closes his eyes, seemingly in disinterest, but he really is trying to calm himself down. He opens his eyes again to see that snake gone and Phainon studying him.

"All good there?"

Mydei grunts and returns to his task. He doesn't know what to *do*. He can't protect Phainon. Not from the world, not from the prophecy, not even from himself. But he wants to. Oh, by the titans, he so desperately wants to.

Phainon remains standing, watching him. Mydei doesn't turn, but he can feel those blue eyes burn into his back and he — grits his teeth and tries to keep moving.

"Mydeimos," Phainon calls and Mydei clenches his jaw. That's his full government name. If the Deliverer would ever tack *the Undying* on, he'd know his death is imminent.

"What," he balks back, like a street dog. Okhema really has changed him. Krateros was right.

"I got you a gift. It's not strictly part of the festival, but strangers in a strange land, right?"

Oh, right. It's easy to forget that Phainon, too, is an Outlander. He fits into the cityscape so seamlessly, as if he's always been here. Mydei sets the crate down carefully and remembers one of his erstwhile companions mention the gift-giving. If *Phainon* had the time to get him a gift, then what excuse is Mydeimos going to sputter? Krateros would die if Mydei called himself Phainon's boyfriend, but well, glory in death and all that.

He turns around to see Phainon having come after him, extending both his hands. In his palms sits a little soft-sewn chimera doll, decorated with flowers around its head. It's made with entirely warm colours: orange, red and yellow. The flowers, he recognises, symbolise the other flame-chasers, with the — perhaps he shouldn't be surprised that there's no flower for Phainon.

"Castorice helped me make it. Be lucky she did, because you do *not* want to see my other attempts. I wouldn't even give that to the rats, honestly, so you better appreciate this! And don't say you don't like it, because you know I see how you're hugging those pillows at night! And your first comment about my thighs was how plush they were. You're following almost every chimera channel on the Weave! You're rather looking at their videos than whatever pictures I post! I have to *force* you to leave me a needle and a re-thread! And here I am, always the first to needle any post you make!"

Mydei lets him talk. This sounds like Phainon really needs to get this off his chest. Mydei is barely checking his Weave, if he's being honest. And why should he bother needling Phainon's pictures if *he* himself was it that took these pictures? He had been *there*. Maybe it's — what does Cipher call it? Generation Zagreus? He's not sure if that's a real thing. Maybe she was mocking Phainon, too. He's not even attempting to keep with all of that. He just wants to watch his chimera videos and the occasional cooking video.

"Are you done, Deliverer?"

He's got to stop the man before Phainon talks himself into a frenzy. Phainon stands there, one hand still holding the chimera plush, while the other has its index finger raised, in mockery of a lecture he's giving to the air.

"...yes, thank you. Anyway, take it?"

He lifts his hand, as if to entice Mydei to take it. Like he'd need to do that — as if Mydei was ever going to refuse. He reaches out his hand and takes the little plush from Phainon's hand; and it's really soft. Immediately he wishes it were a little bigger, so he could hug it properly.

"I... I don't have anything for you, Deliverer."

Phainon smiles brightly. “That’s okay! I wasn’t expecting anything anyway. You’ll come to the festival, right? That’s all I need. Even if you’re just sitting in the corner, all old man-grump like. They’ll be serving honey roast! Although almost everyone vetoed me on the salads, I insisted on one at least. I’m sure it’ll be gone in no time, so you better be here early!”

Mydei suppresses a laugh. Phainon and his endless salads... Mydei has no idea how Phainon did any strength training on water and weeds alone without passing out.

“Then I shall be among the first to arrive.”

Phainon grins brightly, and then he rushes off again, no doubt looking to assist yet another citizen. Meanwhile, Mydei looks down at his little gift. Looking closer at it, he can see some botched seams; and patches where the thread had clearly been re-woven. It’s a far cry from perfect, and for that alone, it’s more precious than anything else.

“I love you,” he tells the little thing when he had lifted it to hold it against his face, “more than I know how to say.”

Chapter 3: petal dance

Chapter Notes

> I am TIRED as hell. It's. 4.30am. The sex was so hard. Why am I sexing. I'm sorry😭
> Despite that, I still hope you enjoy, I'll go sleep now~

Mydei takes great care placing the little plush. He was initially contemplating on *where* to put it, but ultimately did settle on Phainon's place. He needs to go to the market tomorrow — Phainon is basically out of food. Maybe he should get Hyacine and Aglaea to lecture Phainon about proper nourishment again. Well, he knows it'd be useless, but he can't always be here, hand-feeding the Deliverer. (He can. He is. He's saving face.)

He flexes his hand. He's decided to forgo the armour for tonight, and it feels weird, going outside like this. He's basically naked. Well, maybe it'll make Phainon look twice, at least. The man likes arms. Mydeimos flexes his muscles a little, scrutinising. He has more muscle mass than Phainon... He squeezes his bicep, assessing it. He looks good, right? He stands there a moment longer before he decides he looks stupid and pretends that this never happened. Little Pie-non has seen nothing. He's got to go, anyhow.

"Lord Mydei! I was just about to knock."

He blinks at Castorice. She stands in front of the door, smiling gently. His eyes shift from side to side. This... is Phainon's house. Hm. Perhaps it's perfectly reasonable to assume he's here. He... could've looked for Phainon, or something.

"Yes..."

"..."

They blink at each other.

“I mean,” she says stiffly, “this was the last place I thought to look, obviously.”

“Obviously,” he agrees. Castorice nods, blushing a little. Is this... her fangirling? He squints. He knows that they aren’t all that subtle, honestly. Phainon dragging him to the baths twice a day is kind of strange, isn’t it?

“I don’t like him,” he says, “his face is stupid.”

“Oh yes,” she agrees, “it’s very stupid. Shall we go? That stupid face might cry if we get there too late.”

He nods and steps fully outside, closing the door behind him.

“Did you like the gift Lord Phainon prepared for you? He stressed about it very much.”

“Yes, I did. Thank you for helping him.”

She waves her hands in dismissal. “Oh, I barely did anything. Lord Phainon is actually quite handy at sewing. But he’s never sewn a toy before, so I simply gave him some pointers.”

Mydei nods again. Phainon is naturally good at a lot of things. “By the way, I’m surprised you’re going to this festival. Aren’t you usually one to stay behind?”

She nods. “I actually planned on abstaining, but Lord Phainon and Lady Aglaea both asked me to attend. And even Hyacine joined in — so I felt bad for refusing. You tend to avoid festivities as well, Lord Mydei. I assume that Lord Phainon asked you to come.”

Sometimes he hates being known. “Yes. It’s hard to refuse my b – battle partner. He might spend his time with Zacharias, instead.”

Castorice snickers, and Mydei thinks about Zacharias. He’s a relatively new arrival in town, so of course Phainon’s offered to show him around; help him settle in. While he of course can’t hold a candle to Phainon’s looks, Zacharias is quite handsome. He doesn’t have their build, but Mydei can tell

that there is some strength hidden beneath these robes. Mydei has not interacted with that man, but he seems polite and soft-spoken. Mydei absolutely hates him.

Maybe Mydei should try to stake a claim tonight. Maybe he should ask Aglaea if she's capable of weaving something for Phainon to wear in traditional Kremnoan colours, or something. It's a shame that Phainon isn't wearing any jewellery... the rings and necklaces and earrings he could commission.

"For what it's worth, Lord Mydei," Castorice rips him out of his thoughts, "I don't think Lord Phainon has eyes for anyone but you."

"...on a scale from one to ten, how obvious are we?"

"Twelve."

Well, fuck this.

Kephale's eternal Dawn Device really doesn't help setting the mood. While they have spanned large, dark tapestries over the venue, it's still very bright. Well, one gets used to most things, even though he still misses the dark. Some things feel less daunting under the blanket of the night. Maybe he would've whispered his confession into the ear of a sleeping Phainon in the darkness, but as things stand, he hasn't dared yet. How could he confess anything under the blazing light of the sun?

"Mydei! Miss Castorice! You're actually early!"

"HKS, you essentially forced us to be on time."

Mydei grumbles but folds immediately when Phainon stands before them, bouncing on his heels. Fucking puppy, Mydei hates him.

"Nuh-uh! I asked politely, so I haven't forced you. Come on, that's our table over there! Castorice, I know you wouldn't want to sit on a bench, so I got a chair for you! I hope that's alright?"

Phainon grabs Mydei’s hand and starts pulling him along, followed closely by Castorice. She smiles.

“Yes, thank you, Lord Phainon. Can we still help you with something?”

“Hmm... thanks for asking, Castorice! But no, everything should be taken care of by now. The others will probably arrive soon, and I want to check on everyone one last time. So just sit back and relax, okay? I’ll be back in a moment!”

He squeezes Mydei’s hand for a second before he bolts off again. Wistfully, Mydei watches him leave, then he lets himself fall down on the bench. Just as Phainon’s said, their table is at the far end, to give Castorice solace of mind. As the de facto leader of Okhema, Aglaea should probably sit more towards the middle, but he’s sure the Council was all too happy to snatch that location. Not that he cares.

“How long do you think we’ll have to stay to not break the Deliverer’s spirit?”

Castorice leans on the table. “Hmm... for me, probably until everyone gets a little bit drunk. You, Lord Mydei, probably until it’s reasonably late enough and even then Lord Phainon will still guilt-trip you.”

He frowns. And then he scowls. “That’s Zacharias,” he tells Castorice then. Not that she asked, but maybe she can help him keep an eye on the guy.

“Oh, he’s quite handsome, isn’t he? I mean — no more than one of the top ten faces of Amphoreus.”

“Must you be so vain?”

Castorice just smiles, as if she were enjoying herself. Snake.

It doesn’t take long for the other Chrysos Heirs to arrive. The triplets come running, and Trianne jumps into his lap immediately in greeting. He simply lets her, knowing when to pick his battles.

“Cas! Little Dei! You’re already here!”

Castorice greets them all, while Mydei simply nods in acknowledgement. Hyacine slips onto the bench next to Castorice, while the triplets spill all over. Aglaea doesn't sit, yet, and Mydei thinks he remembers Phainon saying that she'll need to open the festival.

"Where is Phainon?" She asks and Mydei gestures into the direction Phainon ran off into.

"He wanted to check up on everyone one last time, he said."

"I see. And I see Zacharias is here, as well. I'm sure you must be delighted, Mydeimos?"

"Spare me, and find your precious Deliverer."

She chuckles only, and makes her way over to where Phainon might be.

"Who's Zacharias?" He can hear Hyacine whisper to Castorice.

"Nobody," he gnarls, just as Castorice replies: "He might be courting Lord Phainon."

"He is *not*!" Mydei turns around and slams the table. Both girls blink at him, and then they stick their heads as close together as they can considering Castorice's curse and start whispering like crazy.

"Don't worry, little Dei," Tribbie reassures him, "Snowy only cares about you."

Mydei lets out a huge sigh and moves his hand through his hair. Titans, he can't wait for the festival to be over so that they can return to normalcy. He can't wait to bash Phainon's head in again. It's been forever, and he's itching for a good spar. Phainon probably is, too, it's a great stress reliever. Also it's been a good while since they've had sex — not that Mydei was thinking about that. They haven't even kissed since before Mydei had left on his mission. He desperately needs some stress relief that doesn't rely on Phainon.

Out of the corner of his eye, he can see Aglaea step into the middle of the square, with Phainon off to her side. Good, that means they can finally start. Hopefully Phainon will stay by their table, because if he keeps running around, he won't eat anything *again*. And because Mydei has scarcely seen him, that means Phainon has likely only eaten whatever he could gulp down in one bite.

Aglaea summarises what the festival is about — mostly sentimental words about community, and sticking close together in crisis, supporting one another — she thanks everyone for coming and she praises Phainon and the staff for putting the event together without a hitch. Phainon blushes at that, obviously not expecting to be singled out like that and he rubs his hair, waving the praise off. No matter. Mydei will make sure to tell him later, when the Deliverer can't run away.

She then ends her rather short speech and spreads her arms, declaring the festival underfoot. Everyone claps, and people start looking for food. Phainon and Aglaea make their way towards their table under some difficulties. Aglaea gets stopped by a few people, and Phainon gets hounded as usual. At least they both waive these people off rather quickly and they finally arrive. Phainon plops down on the bench and sighs.

"Oh Kephale, it feels like I haven't sat down in *weeks*." He groans, and wipes his face. "What do you want to eat? I'll go grab us something. Salad for sure, right? I made it myself, it's great! Hmm, I'll just go get a little bit of everything, so we're not missing anything."

He looks to the side quickly before standing up again. "Gotta hurry, the line's getting long. Be back before you know it!"

He's gone again before Mydei can even say anything. So he just raises his hands in confusion, looking at the others. Aglaea has just sat down, and she is smoothening out her dress. Hyacine and Castorice shrug their shoulders. Useless bunch. He sighs, and gets up to go after Phainon. That HKS can't carry everything on his own, after all.

They eat in merry laughter. And if Mydei sneaks some pieces of meat onto Phainon's plate, who's to know? Aglaea smiles at him knowingly, but he

ignores her by stabbing some weed to death. He doesn't need *Aglaea* of all people point out that Mydei is mother henning.

"The band is great, Lord Phainon!"

"You think so, Miss Hyacine? There were quite a few contestants and it was really difficult choosing just one. I felt so bad for the ones I had to send away..."

"HKS, did you organise *everything*?"

"Hm? Oh, I dipped my fingers everywhere a little, yeah. Why? Something not to your liking?"

Mydei scowls and Phainon smiles, pushing two fingers on his face, attempting to smoothen the scowl out. The scowl simply deepens.

"You know, if you scowl too much, your face will get stuck like this..."

Mydei scoffs, as Hyacine reaches over to grab Phainon's attention. "Everyone is starting to dance," she points out. "Shall we join them?"

Phainon nods. "Yes! Mydei, you wanna come too? Oh, Ladies Oracle, how about you? We can all hold hands!"

"Yes!" The triplets shout while Mydei shoves Phainon off the bench.

"No," he says, "I'll stay with the adults. Do try not to embarrass yourself too much, Deliverer."

Phainon sticks his tongue out, and then runs off with Hyacine and the triplets in tow. They fit in seamlessly with the crowd, and Phainon lifts the triplets on his shoulders, with the third — Trinnon, he thinks — on his arm. His other hand holds onto Hyacine, and Little Ica is safely parked on Hyacine's head. They look ridiculous, Mydei wishes he had his teleslate with him.

"I'm taking pictures," Castorice says behind him, "I can send them to you later, Lord Mydei."

“No, why would I want that?” He responds, his ears burning.

“Oh, alright. Then I apologise in advance for my fingers slipping.”

Being known truly is a curse.

“Oh?” Aglaea interjects and oh no. “Mydeimos and Phainon are officially together, now? I must say –“

“No we are not, why would you even think that?”

“Yes, why would you think that, Lady Aglaea. The professor always told us it’s pointless to state the obvious.”

“I hate all of you. Being your ally was a mistake. I keep having severe lapses in judgement.”

“Most of those lapses are because of Phainon, aren’t they? I saw you debating recently how to measure who can hold his breath longer without dying. If I recall correctly, Phainon called you a cheater pre-emptively.”

“...it is purely the Deliverer’s fault. He was the one who proposed the challenge.”

“And yet, you two were seriously attempting to solve this critical issue.”

Titans, he needs some monsters to kill. “It keeps the mind sharp to debate impossible things,” he settles on and then downs the rest of his juice. He’s not in the mood for sweet wine, at least not yet, but Phainon brought two bottles to their table anyway. Mydei turns his attention back to the dance group. He immediately scowls again. Next to Phainon stands Zacharias. At least the Deliverer is still holding on to the triplets and Hyacine, but Mydei is still irked. How dare that man stand so close. He should leave space for whatever titan he believes in. At least it seems like Hyacine is butting into the conversation.

“Now, that wouldn’t have happened if you had simply joined Phainon.”

He glares back at Aglaea who has started throwing bits and pieces of food towards the rooftops. Honestly, Mydei doesn't understand why Cipher doesn't simply come down here.

"I do not concern myself with petty things like *jealousy*. This Zacharias is too soft a man, anyway."

"Maybe Lord Phainon likes soft things."

"Why don't you just keep holding that teleslate, Castorice."

After a while, the group stumbles back to the table, and Phainon deposits the triplets safely back onto the bench. They all reach for something to drink immediately; and Phainon downs two cups of wine in quick succession.

"Did you have fun, Lord Phainon?" Castorice asks, having already put her teleslate away before Phainon could see it.

"Yeah! It was a little crowded, so I kept bumping into everyone, and I hope I stepped on nobody's foot... do you want to dance, Miss Castorice?"

"Phainon," Aglaea starts but he waves her off. "No, no, I have an idea!" He exclaims and jumps sides, urging Castorice to get off her chair. She dutifully does so, keeping her distance. Phainon, meanwhile, takes the chair in his hands and rattles it a little. He ends up looking at the backrest, which has three pins. Then, with a rather impressive show of strength, he rips two of them out of the backrest, putting the chair back down. Holding the two sticks in his hands, he looks at Castorice, grinning wide.

"Here!" He states, holding the sticks out to her. "I hold onto one end, and I'll hold the other! Come on, let's give it a try!"

Hesitating, flitting her eyes between the wooden sticks and Phainon's face, she slowly reaches out her hands, wrapping them carefully around the wood. She's not holding on very tight, but as Phainon doesn't spontaneously combusts or dies, her grip becomes a little tighter.

“Are you sure, Lord Phainon?”

“Of course! You’re at a festival, so let’s dance!”

He doesn’t drag her back to the dance floor, obviously, and instead he starts swaying back and forth where he stands, clearly wanting Castorice to join. After a while of apparent internal turmoil, she gives in and sways to the beat as well. Slowly, she starts to smile and enjoy herself, joining in on Phainon’s enthusiasm. The triplets cheer them on, Aglaea watches them with a fond smile, and Hyacine has taken her teleslate out, leaning back to get a good angle.

Phainon spins her around a couple times — enough to get her laughing, but not enough to get her disorientated.

“Oh, I’m getting woozy,” Phainon says eventually and he lets go of the wooden sticks. “Let’s stop here, yeah? Keep those sticks, why don’t you? Oh wait... oh no, I murdered the poor chair...”

“The chair will survive, Phainon,” Aglaea soothes him, “it bled for a good cause. Now sit down and drink some water.”

“Okay,” he agrees and climbs over the table again like some overgrown monkey, and he plops down next to Mydei. He grabs Mydei’s cup unasked and sniffs it. There’s still pomegranate juice inside. Phainon then shrugs, apparently believing that this is water enough and downs whatever is left in it.

“Do you not have your own cup, Deliverer?”

“Yours was full,” and well that’s an immaculate argument really. Truly the debate champion of Okhema. Phainon leans a little on Mydei’s shoulder and he lowers his arm slightly, so that Phainon can be more comfortable.

“Come dance with me, Mydeimos.”

“There’s no word for *dancing* in the Kremnoan language.”

Phainon pouts, looking up at Mydei under his pretty, pretty eyelashes. Mydeimos stays strong, befitting of a prince. He almost gives in, but he is determined. Strong. Infallible. One pouty Deliverer is *not* enough to break his indomitable spirit.

“Fine,” Phainon sighs then, and he sits up straight. He turns half his body towards him, and smiles brightly, like the sun of distant lands: “Just gotta make sure I’ll dance even harder for you, then!”

His eyes catch the light like roughly cut gems, and Mydeimos is captivated. With a swing of his legs, Phainon gets up from the bench again and re-joins the dancing crowd. Mydei’s eyes follow him without really seeing anything and that smile — the smile stays in his mind. He thinks — he thinks, he’d lay waste to every city state in his path, if it only means he gets to keep that smile. When people had told him that for some ancient conquest, a pretty face had been all the reason, he had scoffed. Because why would you go to *war* for one single pretty face? But he thinks he understands now. In order to keep Phainon smiling, he would — titans, he’d conquer the entire world.

Mesmerised, he watches Phainon through the crowd and he thinks they don’t understand how lucky they all are; having the Deliverer smile and laugh like that in their midst. Mydei stands up abruptly when Zacharias approaches Phainon yet again, this time bolded by alcohol, and puts his hands on the Deliverer’s waist.

“Deliverer,” he says in a low tone after cutting through the crowd with practised ease, and he slides up behind Phainon.

“Oh, Mydei! Decided to join me after all?”

“I thought it’d be rude to have the Deliverer dance alone,” Mydei responds, wishing his looks could incinerate that Okheman before him. Zacharias shrinks, and wisely, slips away. Good.

“My hero,” Phainon swoons, entirely oblivious. He leans some of his weight against Mydei’s chest, and well, it does feel satisfying. It’s like sating a primal urge inside of him, and that’s something he needs to think

about later, when he's alone. And since he's barely ever alone, he will never have to think about it. Win-win.

"Let's dance then," Phainon says, like a threat, and he pushes himself upright again, smiling at Mydei, eyes glittering. "Don't worry, just follow my lead. You can't fail."

Mydei isn't terrified of failing; not like Phainon is. So, he supposes, this might as well be Phainon's way of soothing his nerves. Asshole. He wants to kiss him.

"Then show me what you can do, Deliverer. Impress me."

Phainon laughs, almost carefree, and then he adjusts to the movement of the crowd. Mydei, still a little unsure of himself, sways in place, thinking that surely this has to be enough. Phainon grabs his hands eventually, and dances with him, much like he did with Castorice before. He's bolder now, not having to worry about accidentally bumping into the dormant Hand of Shadow. Mydei has some trouble letting loose, despite Phainon's best attempts. He likes watching the Deliverer far more, anyway. And at least with him here means Zacharias will stay away. Phainon then spins Mydei around himself, coming up behind his back. His body is solid and warm against his back and — and only Phainon is allowed to get so close to his back. Only him, only ever him.

"Come on, you big brute. Just think of it like a spar, hm? I move, you move. Easy, right? Just focus on me, and me alone."

That's no challenge at all. Mydei twists back around and crowds against Phainon. "You're on, Deliverer," he says and Phainon grins, smug as a cat.

So he moves, and Mydei responds. At first, it's one slow move at a time, and then Phainon starts moving faster, and Mydei easily keeps up. It's like a fight, but it's also not; it's more the pre-battle circling they do sometimes, when they try to get a feeling for each other. Soon enough, Phainon doesn't wait for him at all, and simply moves in tandem with the music that's playing. Mydei does his best at trying to copy the man, but he just lacks the rhythm for it. Well. He figures he can't be the only person tone-deaf in the

crowd, so he just wings it. Eventually, Mydei reaches forward and grabs Phainon's waist, pulling him close; flush to his chest.

"Oof," Phainon says, laughing a little into Mydei's skin. His eyes have closed, and he breathes out slowly, and then opens his eyes. "Hi," he says, like a fool. He smiles like one, too.

Mydei doesn't care where they are. He knows Phainon always has eyes on him, because he's the Deliverer, because he is Okhema's Golden Boy. But right now, like this, Mydeimos doesn't give a damn. He cups Phainon's cheek in one hand, and leans in to kiss him. It's been so log; too long, and yet he hasn't forgotten the taste of his Deliverer's lips. He doubts he ever will. It's a chaste kiss, as far as they go, and Phainon is the first to push back, looking sheepish.

"Let's not," he starts to stammer, "let's not... not here."

"Why not?"

Phainon sighs deeply, as if he's forced to explain basic math to a child. However, he doesn't move further away, and Mydei's hand is holding on tightly to his waist.

"Mydei — Mydeimos, you're a *king*. This... this is just... look. Look, okay? I'm punching *so* far above my pay grade with, with all of you. I'm just — I'm just a farm boy, yeah? Just, just think: ***the*** leader of Okhema, not to mention the fucking *Goldweaver*; and two... four? More than one *Holy Maiden*, one of the *seven sages* of the *Grove*, the leading healer of the bloody Twilight Courtyard and like, one of the last descendant of the *Sky People*... and then, then there's *me*? I shouldn't—I shouldn't fucking *be* here. Deliverer, my ass."

"What about Cipher, then?"

"Oh, *Cipher*?" His voice grows a little shrill, like he's legit losing it. "What, just the fastest hands in the west? *The* greatest thief ever since Zagreus? Oh, and that Cipher that can't *stand* my fucking face because *she* thinks I'm stealing Aglaea from her; *that* Cipher? Yeah, sure, that really cements it,

doesn’t it. I should’ve died on the fucking road, they never should’ve found me—“

Mydei stops him by pressing his fingers over the never-stopping mouth. He likes Phainon’s voice, he just wishes it wouldn’t say so much shit.

“*This*,” Mydeimos starts, “this is everything to me. You are *it*, Deliverer. I don’t care about being king, and you know the others would never flaunt all their positions and titles either. If you want, I’ll kneel right here, right now, just for you. I’ll grovel in the dirt, I’ll kiss your feet, I’ll *devote* myself entirely. What I feel for you, I have—*never* felt for anyone. I love you. I love you, I love you, I love *you*.”

He cups Phainon’s face completely now, pressing their foreheads together. He has to admit, *this* isn’t exactly how he thought that confession would go. But he’s not sorry for it; and he will not take it back, not for anything in the world.

“With you, you stupid, dim-witted fool, I’m—I’m *alive*, perhaps for the first time in my life. You call me Mydei, like I’m just someone, and with you, all those kingly burdens are easier to bear because I’m just *Mydei*—not Mydeimos the Undying. I’ll do whatever you want, you *know* that. Tying our dominant hands together, just so we could see who does better at daily tasks? Sure, let’s go do it, even though I *know* you’re ambidextrous so you’ve already won. Or that time you challenged me to pluck the fruits in the Garden of Life with only our lips? It’s such a terrible idea, but yes let’s go do it immediately. Aglaea *chewed* us the fuck out, and I’d do it again in a heartbeat. There’s no one else like you. No other equal, in no way or form.”

He gently caresses Phainon’s face like a precious gem, and then he sinks down to his knees, softly holding Phainon’s hands in his own.

“Let me be yours,” he asks then, as the crowd still dances around them in a haze, “let me be yours. Let me be yours, and be mine in return. There’s just you, *only* you. Whatever you might tell yourself about *anything*, this is the truth I give you, and it will never, not once in a thousand years, change.”

Phainon stares down at him, mouth slightly agape. Mydei doesn't exactly expect a response—as witty as Phainon is, he's emotionally stunted when it comes to himself. He is slowly stroking his thumb over the hands, pressing quick kisses to the fingers; to the back of his hand. Some of his people might scorn him for it, and he *is* conflicted about it, but he would always swear fealty to the Deliverer.

"Mydei," the man gasps then, holding himself back from choking, "not. Not here, I—I can't—"

So Mydei stands up and takes the Deliverer in his arms. He doesn't look over to their table, where the others still sit, and he simply leaves the venue. With long strides, he walks away and just one alleyway over, he presses—slams, really—Phainon against the wall.

"I will bring you pleasure like none before me," he promises in a low voice, "if you'll let me."

Phainon chokes then, looking at him with big eyes. Mydei can see the numerous insecurities eating away at the Deliverer so he'll take point, as always. He crowds the man against the wall and kisses him. He doesn't kiss him like he just did among the crowd. No. He kisses him like he's trying to devour him; consume him whole. He cups Phainon's head in his hand so he doesn't press him too hard into the stone, and he slots one of his legs between the Deliverer's. Phainon, meanwhile, is grabbing onto Mydei's neck and side. If only his fingernails were longer; then he could leave proper marks. He shoves his tongue inside Phainon's mouth, claiming it as his own. Phainon lets him, for a moment, before he bites down. Mydei growls, deep in his chest, and he dives in deeper, roughly grabbing Phainon's jaw. The Deliverer responds by grabbing a fistful of Mydei's hair, yanking it. It feels good, and he presses their bodies closer. They are doing less kissing now, and more biting. Mydei can taste the tanginess of blood on his tongue, and it spurns him on even more. They moan and groan inside each other's mouth, and they both sporadically rut their hips against each other. Mydei contemplates sucking him off in the alleyway. They *have* had sex in a somewhat public environment before, and maybe, just maybe, that unlocked something inside Mydei. He *knew* that some part of Phainon had enjoyed it too—he's said that much eventually—but he understood that

there was a lot of risk involved, if they were to actually be discovered. It's just a shame that that's part of the thrill—and being alone on the battlefield with Phainon was also difficult. Mydei has scarcely seen a better sight than Phainon covered in blood and sweat, riding him, wringing orgasm after orgasm from both of them. Phainon, covered in blood, sweat, dirt and both their release on his pale skin almost made Mydei propose on the spot and it also made them late to return by two days.

Mydei wraps his hand around Phainon's throat and then he *squeezes* hard enough to break a lesser man's neck. As expected, the Deliverer simply moans, instinctively rutting against Mydei, before he breaks their kiss open-mouthed. Mydei watches him for a second; his bitten lips, gasping for air, dilated pupils. Then he lets go of his throat, and before Phainon can properly catch his breath, Mydei pushes two fingers inside his mouth. Phainon closes his lips around them immediately, sucking on them.

It's a picture for the titans, really. Phainon gags a little when Mydei presses down on his tongue at the back of his throat, but he keeps sucking dutifully. His cock is throbbing inside his pants, but he's rather good at ignoring it for a while. He lets his hand glide over Phainon's beautifully exposed throat, over his shamefully clothed chest and stomach, before he slips it inside the Deliverer's pants, wrapping his fingers around the hard length between his legs. Phainon moans around the fingers choking him and he ruts into Mydei's hand.

"So needy, Deliverer," he purrs into Phainon's ear as he gives him a good tug. Phainon's body shudders, and Mydei pulls the man's pants down, exposing him to the warm air around them. He wastes no time and falls down to his knees, and Phainon coughs as his mouth is finally free again. Mydei doesn't let him recover and instead takes all of Phainon's dick into his mouth at once. Phainon clamps his mouth shut immediately, trying to curb the moan trying to escape. His other hand grabs a fistful of Mydei's hair, trying to pull him away—to no avail, of course, but points are given for trying.

"Mydeimos," the Deliverer pants, in warning, but he moans while talking. "Don't—titans, not here—*fuck*."

Mydei has closed his eyes and he relishes in the feeling of Phainon's length filling his mouth. He can feel him hit the back of his throat, and he's quite fortunate not having much of a gag reflex. He thinks he could die like this, and not regret a thing. Phainon filling his throat, and his big thighs surrounding his face? There's no better way to go. He starts gently sucking then, swirling his tongue around the member in his mouth and he can feel Phainon's hips bucking. Phainon rarely lasts long, Mydei knows, because he is in a constant state of being pent-up. He does it to himself, and while Mydei would prefer for the man to relax from time to time, he's more than happy to fuck Phainon into exhaustion.

"M-Mydei!" Phainon's boots are scraping on the ground and Mydei sucks a little harder. He can feel the dick twitching rapidly, and he squeezes Phainon's thighs tight. Phainon's hip buck, stutter and then tense and Mydei represses a groan when he feels Phainon coming down his throat. He swallows it all up greedily, while Phainon is breathing hard through his note, having pressed his hand tightly against his mouth to prevent the loud noises he has a difficult time holding back.

Mydei slips off with a loud pop and it's a shame Phainon isn't naked so he can look his fill. Phainon is breathing heavy, and it's getting hard to hold himself back, but surely, a little more teasing won't hurt...? So, as Phainon slowly tries to calm down and reel himself back in, Mydei lets his hands roam over those pretty thighs. The things he likes to do to them... but not now. He reaches around, slowly, and he intends to simply press his fingertips into Phainon's hole, just to tease him, just to make him groan and double over and demand to be fucked, but—he meets resistance. Something's stopping him. His eyes widen and he is up into Phainon's face in an instant.

"Deliverer," he growls, "really? In front of *everyone*?"

Phainon blinks at him through the haze of post-orgasm. "It's been *weeks*, Mydeimos, and I can only jerk myself off so many times. A man's got needs, you know?"

Mydei presses against him, so that his lips curl over Phainon's ear. The man's hair is soft against his skin and Mydei sighs quietly.

“When did you put the plug in, anyway?”

“It’s not a plug,” Phainon replies, his own lips brushing past Mydei’s ear. His eyes widen. What...? But he definitely felt something, and—by Nikador’s greatest conquests. He leans back a little, staring at Phainon, whose eyes are half-lidded and who has a pretty blush covering his cheeks.

“I didn’t know you were that needy, Deliverer. But then I guess, you won’t need me tonight, right?”

Phainon grabs Mydei’s throat aggressively at that, his blunt fingernails burrowing into his skin. Yes. Yes, this is perfect. Aggression is a good look on Phainon. The Deliverer growls a little, but then he has an epiphany and he lets go of Mydei, suavely leaning back.

“Hmm, maybe you’re right. I could just go back and chat up Zacharias instead, right? I’m sure he’d be up for the—“

Mydei covers his mouth with his hand. “How *dare* you mention him—“

Phainon licks his hand, because he’s a freak, and then he bites it, too. He reaches out and tugs at Mydei’s hair, exposing his throat. Mydei growls, smirking, because he’s kind of a freak too. With Phainon, he can’t help it.

“Then maybe, Mydeimos,” Phainon purrs, “you should fuck me; so that I don’t need another man’s dick or that pretty, pretty dildo I have. Don’t I look good bouncing on your cock?”

Yes. Yes, he does. Mydei leans in and kisses him again, caging him between his arms. He’s thought about fucking Phainon with that dildo right here, but he doesn’t want to wait anymore—and the longer they stay here, the more likely exposure will become.

So he half-hazardously pulls the man’s pants up again and manhandles him into a pick-up; starting to sprint through the city. They don’t make very good progress, because Phainon is a little jerk and keeps rutting against Mydeimos which of course means they have to stop every so often to passionately make out.

Eventually they make it to Phainon's place and titans bless Mydei adopting the habit of not locking Phainon's door. He slams them inside and kicks the door shut, heading for the bedroom immediately. Phainon has wrapped his arms around Mydei's neck and is aggressively kissing his face.

Tossing the Deliverer on the bed, Mydei wastes little time undressing the man.

"Beautiful," he whisper as he finally gets him naked, pressing kisses on his shoulder.

"Save the flattery, Mydei! I've been waiting for *weeks*—"

They both have, Mydei doesn't say. But yes, the flattery can wait for later, when Phainon won't have the strength to argue against them anymore. Phainon is still half-hard when Mydei slides between his legs again, and he gently flips the man over. Briefly, he kneads the man's ass before pulling the cheeks apart, revealing the pretty stuffed hole between. His own cock gives a very interested twitch at that, and Mydei grabs the base of the dildo and slowly, ever so slowly, pulls it out. Phainon moans, arching his back. Before pulling it out completely, though, he pushes it back in, making Phainon whimper.

"Mydei," he whines as Mydei gently fucks him with the dildo. It's neither the longest nor thickest that Phainon owns, but it has a good girth and after having it sit inside his ass for so long; it must good to feel it finally fuck him, right?

"Shh," Mydei shushes him, "you look so good like this. I could do this to you all day, Deliverer."

"*No*," Phainon protests sharply and uprights himself, turning around and shoving Mydei onto the mattress. He bounces a little on it, smirking up at the Deliverer. Climbing on top of him, Phainon wrangles Mydei's pants from his hips and exposes his hard cock to the cool air of the room. Phainon bites his lips upon seeing it and Mydei rakes his eyes over the Deliverer's body. He flushes so easily; and so, so prettily as well. He never wants anybody else to see it.

Hovering over him still, Phainon reaches behind him and pulls the dildo out fully, moaning when he succeeds. He tosses the toy on the bed next to them, not caring about it one bit, and he scoots to position himself over Mydei's dick. He doesn't take his time at all, and essentially slams himself down, taking Mydei in one fell swoop, making both of them moan out loud.

Mydei's hands find Phainon's hips straight away, holding him steady, as the man rides out the aftershocks.

"Fuck," Phainon breathes, "*finally*."

"Move," Mydei commands and Phainon is obedient as always, and he starts to circle his hips slowly. His face is pinched and he's breathing hard; and he's a sight to behold.

"Feel so good," he pants, "feel so good in me. Mydei. Mydei Mydei *Mydei*."

Mydei tightens his grip on the man's hips, moving him a bit, urging him to go faster. And faster Phainon goes. He slams himself down, punching a moan out of himself with every thrust and fuck, Mydei's not gonna last long like this. So he slams Phainon over to the side, taking a hold of the man's legs, and he starts fucking into the man's hole like a man possessed. Phainon moans and cries, and Mydei bites deep into his shoulder to stifle his own sounds. Phainon's noises alone are enough to push him over the edge.

"Please, please, *please*," the Deliverer begs and Mydei is a gracious king, and he gives his subjects what they need. He thrusts in deep, hitting Phainon's sweet spot over and over until the man below him keens high-pitched and clenches so hard around him that Mydeimos has no choice but to follow him over the edge.

Breathing hard, Phainon continues to gently twitch around him, and Mydei kisses the bite marks he's left behind.

"Perfect," he whispers against heated skin, even though he knows Phainon can't hear him over his own laboured breathing. He pulls out carefully and

they both whine in discomfort. He quickly goes to get a washcloth to clean them both—Phainon is such a bitch when he wakes up sticky. After, he settles into bed and Phainon plants himself across Mydei's chest. He seldom has the desire to talk much after sex, and so if Phainon doesn't start, they often remain in comfortable silence.

This time, though, Phainon reaches over to toy with Mydei's braid. He twirls it between his fingers, twisting around and Mydei lets him until—until Phainon starts to try pushing his fingers inside the hair.

"Stop," he says, maybe a little rougher than he had wanted, "don't undo it."

"Why?"

"...Hephaestion braided it for me. I don't want to lose it, Deliverer."

"Oh," Phainon replies, strangely flat, "I understand. Good night, Mydeimos."

Mydei *knows* that it wasn't the right thing to say, but it is the *truth*. Hephaestion had braided his hair, for good luck and swift victory; and Mydei could never bear to part with it. Maybe he's sentimental about it, but it is proof beyond his own memories that his friends truly have existed.

"Deliverer," he starts and is secretly glad when Phainon presses his fingers against his lips.

"No, no, I understand. He was—your best friend, right? Of course you'd want to keep it."

"I... yes. Yes, he was. I think—I think you would've liked him. He was magnificent on the battlefield. He could even keep up with me."

"Hmm," Phainon replies, "I see. Good night, Mydei. See you tomorrow."

Tomorrow, Phainon is gone.

Mydei knows that he's gone to help clean up the venue from last night, but it still sits wrong in his belly. He toys with the braid absent-mindedly and

wonders if he could have said something different. The tiles are clean, at least, and maybe that has to be enough mercy.

“Hephaestion,” he asks the empty room, “how do I make it better?”

The silence does not answer him.

Chapter 4: to know you, i must meet you first

Chapter Notes

> I'm hungry.... it's 4.30am AGAIN. But good news, I have left my massively depressive episode behind (for now) so yay? If you find any typos, they're all yours. You get my stuff RAW, like god intended. One or two chapters left, I think. I forget more than I write, I swear.
>
> Let me know how you liked it, yeah?

“You have everything?”

“For the hundredth time, *yes*. You’re worse than my mother.”

“Oh, *excuse* me that you *accidentally* forget to eat lunch for two weeks in a row. Show me the provisions again.”

“I’ll kill myself right here, I swear it. Mydeimos, I have enough provisions to last me *five* months. The Grove isn’t *that* far away.”

“Show. Me. The. Provisions.”

“How about I shove them down your throat if they’re so important to you?!”

“I’m not afraid to spank you right here and now.”

“Are you fucking kidding me?”

Mydei is undeterred. He stands before the Deliverer, at the City Gates of Okhema, with his arms crossed. Phainon breathes so hard his nostrils flare. No matter. Mydei has stared down worse beasts, and he truly has no qualms about hitting Phainon hard on his ass if it means he gets to see the provisions again. He has packed them himself, but he would trust Phainon to have lost half of it on the way here. Maybe he had given the food away telepathically or something, he’s not sure how the Deliverance works.

“Fine,” Phainon gives up and slams his satchel into Mydei’s face. “Here. Look. Do you want to fasten my shoelaces too, you brute?”

“You don’t have shoelaces,” Mydei responds dryly and looks inside the bag. Rummaging around a little, he finds everything still intact. Impressive. He’s almost proud. And on the road, he has Hyacine and Castorice to keep an eye out for him. He has instructed them both to use force, if necessary. Castorice is to use a large wooden pestle, as if she were to try feed a very stubborn over-grown baby bird.

That’s never happened in my fanfic, she had replied and Mydei deigned to ignore it. She has studied with Phainon, he couldn’t expect her to have retained all of her senses. Hyacine, at least, he can count on. He hopes, because she’s not here in Okhema often enough to show off how deranged she is. This flame-chase group is a mess all around.

“Is everything to your liking, *Your Highness*?”

“Yes,” Mydei responds and shoves the satchel back into Phainon’s chest. “Switch during night-watch. If I hear the girls say you insisted on it, I will make sure your dinner will not be fit for dogs.”

Phainon blanches. He’s already complaining about the food Mydei cooks him for dinner, so for it to get even worse? Oh, Phainon has not seen the *half* of it. Worse is always an option.

“You’re all ready to go?”

“Oh, Lady Aglaea! You didn’t need to see us off, you know.”

That’s true—they’re just heading to the Grove on personal business. They will hardly be gone for a week; and Aglaea barely sees anyone off before missions, either. In fact, Castorice and Hyacine are already waiting further out ahead, waiting for Phainon to shake Mydei off.

Aglaea lets her eyes wander over Phainon, assessing him before pulling a face. “You will go like that?”

Stumped, Phainon looks down slowly, as if he's expecting some weird tentacle sticking out of him.

"...yes?" He then tries and Mydei squints. Phainon's got all his clothes on. Shirt, coat, pants, shoes. He even has his stupid little cape attached. Aglaea reaches out, face still drawn, and grabs Phainon's arm, dusting some invisible dust off. She then man-handles him into turning around, yanking at his cape, even though it sits like it always does. Then she fruitlessly tries to adjust his coat, as if it were askew. Phainon throws him a helpless look, but Mydei doesn't know either.

"Ugh, I will hear no end from that man if I let you go meet him in such disarray. Phainon, tell him I didn't send you off like this. He'll call me old."

"O...okay...? He won't, though, you know?"

Aglaea scoffs. "Don't be daft, Phainon. He will gleefully point out every mistake in your appearance just to spite me."

She flips him around again as if he were a doll, and then she fiddles with his collar.

"At least he's half-blind, I suppose. Perhaps he will be knee-deep in some inane experiment again, and he will barely notice. If only I were so lucky."

"O... okay. I'm. I'll go now. Okay? That was. Yeah. Hyacine and Castorice are waiting. Mydei. Can you. Uhm. Yeah. Bye!"

His eyes were flitting to Aglaea and Mydei sighs, rolling his eyes. Now like this, he didn't even get to kiss Phainon. No. No, he knows it'll be only a week, but he's determined.

He quickly steps forward and catches Phainon by the wrist, yanking him back and the man yelps as if he were not able to withstand a titankin blow.

"Mydei, I'm leav—!"

He grabs Phainon's face and kisses him. The Deliverer almost jumps three feet into the air and he hits Mydei's chest repeatedly like a blushing maiden.

Mydei doesn’t care, and he tilts his head just so, deepening their kiss a little more. He can feel Phainon’s blush even beneath his gauntlets, and he takes pride in that. Only he can do that.

Phainon finally shoves him off, blush deep in his face. “I hate you.”

“I hate you more,” Mydei smirks and Phainon pushes his face away quite rudely.

“Let’s go!” Mydei can hear Phainon say to the girls. “Men are terrible!”

“Aren’t you a man, Lord Phainon?”

“Don’t lump me in with these brutes!”

“Then you can finally officially participate in girl’s night?”

“...was I illegal before?”

“...is it Lady Phainon now...?”

“Can we not think about it so hard? Can I correct my statement from before?”

“Lord Phainon, this is supposed to be a girls’ bonding moment.”

“Girl’s trip, girl’s trip!”

...maybe Hyacine is just as lost as the rest of them. Mydeimos alone stands as the sole survivor. He turns back to Aglaea, and she’s deep in thought. Sighing, he walks over to her.

“Are you getting sick?”

“I should have woven Phainon a new outfit,” she simply murmurs and walks away. Losses are a constant of the flame-chase journey, but he never thought those losses included common sense. Thank Nikador he’s still got all his wits about him. Now he has time to prepare breakfast for Pie-non.

The next day finds Mydei in that field of flowers he'd been in before with Phainon and the children. There's no better time than now to train his flower-crown technique, now that Phainon has absolutely no chance of sneaking up to him. Not that Mydei wouldn't appreciate the man's help, but then the surprise would be ruined, wouldn't it? He's going to weave the best flower-crown this side of Amphoreus, and then he will present it to Phainon like a fresh kill. The one time Mydei had dumped bloody game in Phainon's arms, in a vain courting attempt, the man had just slowly turned towards him, blinking, before hauling the poor dead thing straight back into Mydei's face. Back then, Mydei had decided that Phainon might be one of those *delicate* people that Peucesta had insisted were becoming more and more common. He will not resort to writing poetry. He knows Phainon likes it; after all he gushes about it every time a new book of it comes out, but Mydeimos will not humiliate either of them with his lacklustre weave of words. He could do it, obviously. But he might just end up comparing Phainon to some—some *horse* or whatever, and then it would all be just so very awkward.

Are you saying my face is too long? Titans, Mydei can already hear it. No, he'd rather spare himself the embarrassment. There are far easier ways to make Phainon feel insecure, and all of those don't require Mydei whatsoever, anyway. No, he's getting off-track. Flower crown. Right. He's a man on a mission.

"Mydeimos."

He lowers his admittedly poor attempt at a flower crown and looks up to see Aglaea approach. She looks as regal as ever, and he honestly didn't expect to see her here.

"Aglaea," he nods in acknowledgment, "did you need something?"

She steps next to him, before she slowly lowers herself to sit next to him. He rarely speaks to her one-on-one; most often Phainon is with them in the room. Krateros calls him weak for it, but he thinks he can learn a lot from her style of leadership. Kremnos cannot continue the way it has for the past

dynasties, but if he wants to truly change his people, he will need some pointers.

“Not particularly,” she says, and that doesn’t bode too well, but also isn’t the end of the world. “If you’re amenable, we might perhaps talk about the festival?”

“Did I offend you or Okhema?”

“No, no, of course not. Tell me, did you enjoy it?”

“...you heard what I said.” Until now, it hadn’t even dawned on him. Phainon should take the brunt of this. It’s all his fault anyway.

“Yes, I might have. Not to mention Cifera saw you from the roofs. I told her not to pry, but she was very adamant I ask you this. I will quote her directly here, so do please forgive me: *Who takes it up the ass?*”

Kill him. He knows it’s useless, but titans, they could put some effort in it sometimes. “I didn’t need the direct quote.”

“...I was assured it was necessary.”

She doesn’t even blush. Her face didn’t even change. Mydei wrangles his poor flower crown so hard it instantly wilts between his fingers. He’s not going to answer that. Cipher can suck it, really. And now he’s thinking. They’ve never switched. Would Phainon want to, sometime? Mydei never really thought about it. This is just how things fell into place, honestly. Maybe he should ask? What if Phainon has been waiting for a chance to say something? But Mydei *likes* being on top. He likes serving Phainon; making him gasp and moan, and watching him fall apart. Is he—what’s the word; misogynistic? But Phainon isn’t a woman. Does it still apply? No, that’s ridiculous. Phainon is a grown-ass man, he can voice his preferences.

“I didn’t realise this was a question that required such intense thinking.”

“Tell Cipher she can suck it.”

“May I direct quote?”

“I beg you do.”

After that, they return to silence, as Mydei tries to weave another crown. Aglaea watches him quietly. It doesn’t make him nervous, because he doesn’t share Phainon’s performance anxiety.

“I never thought I’d see you try to weave a flower crown.”

“The Deliverer showed me,” he replies, “so now I need to beat him at it.”

“Of course,” she laughs, “you and your endless competitions. You must know, Mydeimos, your arrival changed Phainon quite a bit.”

He looks up from his task and frowns.

“What do you mean?”

“He didn’t use to be... silly, if you excuse my choice of words. He was—far more reserved.”

Mydei looks away from her, to his poor attempt at a crown. He chose wrong colours, too. Phainon would’ve placed another flower crown on his head already, and Mydei longs for the chance to return the gesture. Phainon is still too reserved for his tastes.

“Tell me,” he demands softly, “tell me of the Deliverer’s arrival.”

~

Even after so many years, a part of her can never grow accustomed to ruling a city. She keeps wondering how the Imperator would’ve fared with the Council of Elders—but knowing her, she would have probably have them executed for daring to stand against the flame-chase. Chuckling quietly to nobody but herself, she smoothens out her reports. The flame-chase had grown stagnant, and amidst the stagnation, she needs to persevere. Aquila is

no target for now, and Cerces remains untouched from the corruption for the time being. The Heir for Strife has not yet arrived, and they have no information on Castrum Kremnos' whereabouts, regardless. Whispers of Nikador's madness grow with every passing day, and she knows she needs to take action eventually. But not yet; and only after calculating her every step, so that she might not slip on spilled golden blood. Rushing headlong into battle is not her style.

"Agy," she is interrupted, "there's trouble at the gates."

"I am aware, teacher."

With the black tide spreading without halt, more and more people flock to Okhema, to seek Kephale's eternal protection. However, regrettably, she's had to turn people away in the past. Her own people need to come first, and she simply cannot guarantee everyone's survival. Resources will become thin at some point, and how is she meant to chose who lives and dies, then? It is cruel, perhaps, but she would rather send the refugees away now, while there are still other safe havens. This group is no different, her threads tell her. They are simply persistent, even after being turned away.

"They say they have a Chrysos Heir with them," Tribbie says then and Aglaea looks up. It might be a ploy.

"Who is it?"

"**We** think it might be the Deliverer. But **we** would need to look to be sure."

The Deliverer... The Deliverer will always mark the beginning of the end. She wonders what they will be like. An astute warrior, hardened by battle? A wise scholar, agreeable to her journey? A mix of both, perhaps? A Chrysos Heir with no flaws, at the very least. No draw-backs. She closes her eyes. Maybe this flame-chase can finally come to an end, after a thousand years of waiting. Cerydra had never concerned herself with the Deliverer, and yet it's all Aglaea had clung to.

"Very well," she says and stands up, "let us have a look, then."

Tribbie smiles and moves ahead. Aglaea wonders where the other two are. They are no doubt watching, just as curious as Tribbie herself. Trianne, she suspects, will probably watch from somewhere with her own eyes.

She can hear the commotion from afar. Truly, such a bother... they should be honoured she makes an appearance. If it turns out they lied to her... well. She can be civilised, at least to some decree. The group of refugees isn't very big, from what she can tell. Maybe about twelve people; give or take, and they seem to have no provisions with them. Well. No wonder they cling to that acclaimed Chrysos Heir they want to have found.

"...fucking telling you! He's one of us, so if you want him, you gotta let us in!"

"What's the issue, gentlemen?"

"L-Lady Goldweaver!"

Aglaea waves the guard off. Instead, she focuses on the man before her. He looks haggard, easily in his late fifties, with greying sideburns. She's no hairdresser, but even she would make something better out of that mess. His eyes tell her how desperate he is, and the cloak he's wearing is old and ratty. She shouldn't scoff at that. They wear what they have; and clothes are a luxury easily discarded. She misses the days where she's done little else but run her tailor shop. She misses Cifera assisting her, too.

"T-the Goldweaver! We, we are... uh, here! We have an Heir with us! He's legit, so you gotta let us all in, won't you?"

Aglaea eyes him for one more moment—very much on purpose because she is aware of how unnerving her stare can be. Then she shifts her eyes to the person standing next to him—not by choice, perhaps, as the man holds the boy's arm in an iron-clad grip. His hair is stark white, and his gaze is directed towards the ground, His clothes are ratty and the colours are... questionable. That's supposed to be the Deliverer? Right now, she wouldn't trust him to deliver a package in her name; she'd be the talk of the town. Despite the colour choices—maybe he's colourblind, would that count as a flaw?—his clothes have holes in them. The dark patches might be blood;

they are too dark to be simple dirt. One of his shoes is worn through, with his toes showing. His pants are short, barely extending past the hem of his shirt. And yet, from the looks of it, they haven't always been this short.

He clutches a worn-down sword in his left hand. Its edge is dull and it no longer shines, and she suspects it can no longer cut even butter.

"This is your so-called Chrysos Heir? If you lie to me, I will see it fit to punish you."

The boy still does not look up. His hair is matted, like he had been unable to wash it, but she supposes that's fair, having been on the road and all. Something about it irks her, though, but she can't put her finger on it. He barely reaches up to her chest, so he must be, what; fourteen, fifteen at most?

"No, no! I, I'll prove it to you! Here, look!"

Without waiting for her permission, he takes a knife and cuts a deep gash across the boy's arm. He bleeds quickly, golden blood slowly making its way down his skin, eventually dripping down onto the ground. The boy, however, makes no sound. The man squeezes the boy's arm harder, pulling him forward, as if to make sure Aglaea sees the blood.

"See? Golden! It's not a trick, I swear! I can cut another part, if you like, too!"

Aglaea narrows her eyes. There's more, besides the dirt all over the boy's pale skin. She can spot shallow cuts, barely fading into little white scars. Bandits, perhaps? The weapons of the titankin? After all, if this group had encountered the black tide, they would not be here. Or perhaps... she looks at the knife the man so readily holds in his hand. It's old, she notes, incredibly ill-kempt and dirty, not just with fresh blood. Perhaps this man is to blame for some of the forming scars. Looking more carefully, she notices dark bruises on the boy's skin. Most are on his upper arms, no doubt from the old man holding him tight. Her hands twitch when she sees bruises on his legs. She deigns not to think on it.

Instead, she steps forward and she gently kneels before the boy. Noticing, he moves his head a little away from her. Good. At least he doesn't seem to have been drugged, but it means she doesn't get to see all of his face. What she sees, however, is a little concerning. Bruises and scratches around his neck, his lip is split and bloody, and his nose seems to be broken, at least from what she can assess with her limited medical knowledge. On his neck, she can see Kephale's sun shine wide and bright, unmarred by the dirt coating its bearer.

"The Deliverer will come to us in a form most unassuming. And yet, they alone will herald the new tomorrow."

Aglaea sighs. She would've preferred this in another way, but life has rarely dealt her pleasant cards.

"Look at me, child," she demands but the boy doesn't react. His bangs cover his face, and he seems to draw away even further. She frowns. She has difficulty seeing the shining Deliverer standing before her. He reminds her more of a street rat.

"Didn't you hear her?! Obey!"

Roughly, the man yanks the boy's head back by his hair. The boy yelps in surprise, and Aglaea rises quickly. His eyes are as blue as the sky, just like Kephale in the old legends. Kephale's symbol even seems to be woven into the boy's iris and then Aglaea knows. This, and no other, has to be the Deliverer. Whether that's blessing or curse remains to be seen. Briefly, she can see unbridled rage reflected in his eyes, but then he blinks at her direction, for the first time, and that rage quickly disappears—so quickly in fact, that later she would wonder if she saw it at all.

"These people," she asks, "are they your friends?"

The boy searches her face, and his head is finally released from the rough grip on his hair. He swallows hard and he seems to think.

"They," he speaks, voice raspy from misuse and dehydration, perhaps, "were my companions."

“That’s not what I asked. Shall I allow them into the Holy City, Deliverer?”

Everyone around her falls quiet. Many people have been waiting for the Deliverer’s arrival, and for it to be this little, broken boy... she must establish a chain of order quickly. Clothes are quickly procured, and a good wash should fix most of the boy’s blemishes.

The boy, in the meantime, stares at her with big eyes, as if he couldn’t believe her words. Aglaea isn’t one to back down, however, and this boy *will* answer her. Perhaps this answer will determine the path of their relationship?

“Yes,” he says then, looking at her still, “the gates should not be closed for those in need.”

She nods once, curtly. There was no wrong answer here, and she is pleased he answered at all. She then turns to the man beside the boy: “You and your companions may enter. Okhema welcomes you.”

“You,” she addresses a guard, “take the Deliverer to the baths; and ensure a healer looks over that injury. Once he is presentable, I will see him in my office.”

She doesn’t wait for the guard to salute, and she turns around to leave. Tribbie slowly follows behind her, having simply observed.

“Agy,” she reprimands, later in private, “you weren’t nice to the Deliverer.”

Aglaea sighs and sits down at her chair, picking up her reports again. She hopes the Deliverer can read and write, because the sooner he can assist her, the better.

“I was being practical, teacher. I tried to establish a chain of command.”

“You didn’t even ask for his name.”

Huh. Yes, she supposes, that is true. It had completely slipped her mind. Isn’t it enough that he is the Deliverer? Losses are a constant on their fated journey, and the price they all must pay is their humanity.

What's your name, little one?

And yet. It hadn't always been so, had it?

"Have you met the Deliverer yet, Cas?"

"Ah... no, not yet. I think I saw him from afar? I didn't want to scare him."

Aglaea shakes her head. "You should go meet him. The Deliverer can't be scared of little things like this. He's in the Garden of Life currently; Teacher is trying to lecture him about history."

Castorice looks up. She's been helping sorting some of the reports into neat little piles so Aglaea could hopefully ignore them in a timely fashion. The Council always wants more power, and yet they leave all these things to her alone. It feels like they wish to have the cake without having to break a single egg.

"Alright," Castorice agrees and she stands up. "What's his name?"

Aglaea doesn't answer. She still doesn't know. She still hasn't asked. When she saw him again, she... had been too focused on getting her point across. To make sure he understood the importance of the flame-chase; and what his fate would hold for him. She hadn't asked if he was well. She hadn't asked where he came from. She hadn't asked why there were bandages around his fingertips. She hadn't even thought of doing so.

"Lady Aglaea..."

"Go, Cas. The boy tires quickly, and even Teacher's patience will run out eventually."

That part is a lie. The boy does seem to get tired quickly, but teacher's patience never runs out. If the boy can't remember the year of the Imperator's death even after being told five times, teacher will tell him a sixth, seventh time. After Castorice's departure, Aglaea remains sitting, staring blankly at a report. Something, something about too much antique

forgery. She doesn’t really care much about antiques, but if their influx would upset Okhema’s market... she will have to look into that. She blinks, and then she gets up, quietly following Castorice. She could observe their meeting through their threads, but she thinks... maybe she should observe from the shadows, as much as she’d be able to. As long as the Deliverer would not spot her, it will be fine.

“...at all?”

Ah. She seems to have missed the introduction. Maybe Castorice will address the boy with his name, then. If only she could be so lucky, but when Castorice moves her head a little, spotting her, she knows she stands no chance. She, the Deliverer, and Tribbie and Trinnon are sitting on the grass, with parchments and books sprawled all over the ground. She can’t help but thinking that she should be there, helping him learn and yet... yet she doesn’t.

“Nothing alive, no. I’d rather not try, you know?”

The boy nods. “I understand. It sounds awful, I have to say.”

“Are you afraid of me now?”

Aglaea can hear the subtle fear in Castorice’s voice—she has tried to make friends in the past, just for these friends to cower in fear of her curse. She has never known a gentler soul than Castorice; a person more deserving of warmth. If the Deliverer would refuse her... then Aglaea would not shy away from a few stern words.

“No,” he replies, “but I’m sorry I can’t hug you. In Era Nova, your curse would be gone, right? I’ll promise you, then: in that new tomorrow, let me be the first one to give you a hug. Is that okay?”

Castorice’s eyes go wide, then she blushes a little, looking away shyly. She nods, then.

“Yes. I would... I would like that very much. Thank you.”

“See, Cas? **We** told you Snowy is super nice! **We** know at least a couple people that could learn from that!”

Ouch. That’s a hefty stab.

“Everyone here has been nice to me...”

“Oh, don’t lie, Snowy! **We** know Agy has not been nice to you!”

The boy shakes his head. “Everyone says the Goldweaver is a kind ruler. Scary, but kind. I don’t mind, you know? It’s okay that she doesn’t like me, I’ll survive. Now, why do I have to remember the year of the Imperator’s death? Isn’t enough that I know she’s dead?”

“No! It’s important knowledge!”

Castorice giggles.

“Who’s going to quiz me on this? Is it the secret passcode to get back into Okhema?”

“Yes! Yes it is! Now learn!”

The boy groans and picks up his scroll again, squinting at it.

“Agy,” a voice surprises her and she turns around to see Trianne standing before her.

“Yes, teacher?”

“Why don’t you join them? You heard the boy; he think you don’t like him. It would be good to prove him wrong, right?”

Aglaea hesitates. Trianne isn’t wrong, it’s just... “I wouldn’t know what to say. I will perish one day, and the Deliverer will take over. It’s best, perhaps, if he would not grow attached to me; or I to him.”

“You didn’t think like that with little Ciphy. Snowy is just a child, you know? **We** really believe he could benefit from your guidance.”

That’s true... Cifera had never been a transaction. She never once thought about Cifera’s purpose for the flame-chase beyond being herself. However, much time has passed since then.

“He and Cifera are different.”

“How do you know, Agy? You still don’t even know his name.”

Feeling scolded, Aglaea turns away and leaves. Cifera and the Deliverer are different circumstances. *She* is a different person now. And she wonders, now... is that the reason Cifera left Okhema and never returned? Is it her fault? Did she change too much? If only that cat would return and talk to her. Aglaea could apologise for whatever she did, and then—then Cifera cold be by her side again, like the old times. She hopes the girl is eating properly. She hopes the girl is staying safe.

The boy catches sight of her when she leaves, but she is too pre-occupied to notice.

“What’s the Deliverer like?” He asks Castorice.

“Oh... uh, I don’t—*you* are the Deliverer? Shouldn’t you answer that?”

“No,” he shakes his head, “not me. The Deliverer. What are they like? Before—before you met me?”

“Oh, hmm... a hero. A good and kind soul, always ready to assist others in need. A stalwart leader, ready to usher in a new dawn. I always imagined them as a radiant sun on the battlefield, standing strong and tall, never felled by defeat or sickness. They would eradicate the black tide, and see the flame-chase to its completion. A person worthy of love and trust, with no flaws or faults, and the only person that could fulfil Era Nova.”

The boy breathes softly and his fingers, bandaged as they are, clutch a little tighter on his scroll. “I see,” he says then, just a little bit hoarse, “then that’s what I’ll be. I’ll be the Deliverer.”

The Deliverer is a delight on the city, all of her reports say. He helps people where he can and refuses rewards, but accepts sweet treats sometimes. His choice of clothing remains utterly atrocious, and Aglaea knows she needs to deal with that sooner rather than later.

“Lady Aglaea, here is the report you wanted,” and she looks up. The Deliverer stands before her and he slides a piece of paper on her desk. Right. She has asked him to look into the recent forgeries that were circulating.

“Anything noteworthy?”

He shakes his head. “Not really. Some of the fakes were pretty, though. Can I, uh.” He stammers, and then shuts up. She glances up from his report—he needs to work on his penmanship—and sees him looking down.

“What is it?”

“No, no, it’s nothing, forgive me. Do you have any other tasks I can do for you?”

He places his hand over his chest, ever-ready, and he smiles gently at her, without it reaching his eyes. His fingernails look terrible. She frowns. Has he gotten into a fight? Cifera’s fingernails always looked immaculate...

“You are unkempt,” she says then, “and your clothes are offensive. Follow me.”

She puts her report aside and walks into the next room, not stopping to check if the boy follows her. He’s still growing, so she won’t waste too much time tailoring him something too extravagant, but there has to be *something* she can clad him in.

“What’s wrong with my clothes?” He asks from behind her. “These are all my favourite colours.”

Aglaea sighs. “That might be so,” she says, exasperated, “but they do not go well together. Have you never heard of colour theory?”

He stares at her like she’s grown a second head. “Colours need theory? Why?”

Oh Mnestia save them. Cifera never dressed herself like she fell into a paint bucket. “I will provide you clothes to wear; please do not try to wear anything else. If you desire change, consult me, or at the very least, Tribios or Castorice. You are forbidden from choosing your own clothes, do you understand?”

He stares at her, and then nods. “Okay,” he agrees but he sounds rather unsure. No matter. The purple pants *have* to go. She should burn them, just to be sure. She has Garmentmaker find some clothes suitable for the boy’s size, and she will soon design him garments worthy of the Deliverer.

“Your fingernails,” she asks then, bringing one of his hands up for inspection, “what happened to them?”

They’re dirty and bloody and she wonders what happened. She’s not heard of a fight inside the city anywhere. Did this boy perhaps train with the guards? But even then, this is a strange place for any injury.

“Ah, nothing, my lady,” he lies to her quickly, “I was playing with some of the children in the city, and they were burying their treasure; and asked me to dig it out again. And I didn’t have a shovel, so I had to dig with my hands, so...”

Aglaea studies his face. He has been in the city for about a week at this point and she—still has not asked his name. At this point, she doesn’t know if she ever will. Has she truly lost so much of herself that she doesn’t think this is a problem? This boy *is* the Deliverer, yes, but... he’s a person, too. Doesn’t he deserve himself? Doesn’t he deserve to be a person, too? And yet, here she is, shoving him into one box and shutting the door completely. It’s not fair to him, and yet... and yet. How was Cifera so different? She’s never seen that silly girl as a tool. And yet, the Deliverer is anything but to her.

He and Cifera are so similar, too. Teacher has told her that his hometown got ravaged by the black tide, much like Cifera’s home. Both of them came

to her doorstep dirty and malnourished, unable to avoid their fate. And yet, she took Cifera in gently, coaxing her in with love and tender care, and the Deliverer... she's barely looked at him proper since he arrived. In fact, this very instance might just be the most words she's spoken to him.

"Lady Aglaea?" He asks and she looks up. She knows she looks unfazed. She always does, these days. "Do you require more of me? I have a penmanship lesson with Lady Trinnon. I'd rather not make her wait up; she's already taking time out of her day on my behalf."

"Put these clothes on," she says, having Garmentmaker hand them over, "then you can go."

He nods and gets changed on the spot. She has the instinct to tell him that this isn't appropriate behaviour, but she stays silent. He is thinner than she thought, and she can spot white scars all over his body. Is he not eating enough? He should be provided with everything he needs, no? Maybe he can't cook? She should—she should ask. She should—she should offer to help him, if he doesn't know how. She should offer to teach him, but before she can make a choice, he is dressed and he bows to her, clutching his old clothes to his chest.

"Thank you. Please let me know if there's anything else I can do for you."

And then he's gone.

Cifera, she would've called after the girl, *do you want some candy for the road?*

But the Deliverer, she watches in silence.

"Agy," Tribbie runs into her office. "**We**'ve lost contact with Snowy's expedition group. Agy, we have to send someone!"

"When did we lose contact?"

“About a day ago,” Castorice supplies, “I know that wouldn’t be a problem normally, but the titankin activity has spiked recently. Reports close-by even spoke of the black tide coming closer. Lady Aglaea, let me and one of the triplets go. We will rescue anyone left, I swear to you.”

Yes, Castorice is always to be trusted. Aglaea looks down at her reports again. About four days ago, she had sent the Deliverer and a small party out, to scout for potential refugees. It wasn’t supposed to be difficult, and she partly sent the Deliverer so she would not have to see him for a couple days. His face makes her—it makes her question herself. She would have *never* sent Cifera on such a mission. And yet, she willingly suggested the Deliverer to go when she didn’t even *know* how skilled he is in battle.

She stands up. “We will all go. How far out are they?”

“Agy, no! Let’s use the Century Gate. **We** don’t want to lose someone else so quickly. It’s alright, **we** promise. Aren’t you worried?”

Aglaea hesitates. The Century Gate would be much faster, of course. But each use drains more and more of Tribios, and selfishly, Aglaea wants to keep her teacher as long as she can. But on the other hand, if the Deliverer is in trouble... wounded or otherwise, they have to get there quickly, especially if contact has been lost since yesterday. She hates the thought of having to use the Century Gate to get back *and* fro.

“If you’re sure, teacher... then let us make haste. Take us to the last coordinates that we have.”

Tribbie sighs in relief and Castorice nods, smiling. She, unlike Aglaea, has spent some time in the presence of the Deliverer. Aglaea never asks, and Castorice never tells, but she always smiles a little lighter on the days she’s seen him.

Tribbie opens a Gate, and the three of them step through. Aglaea doesn’t expect them to be gone for longer than two or three hours, and Garmentmaker can handle everything during that time.

“It should be around here somewhere,” Tribbie says and they look around. The place is desolate, with clear signs of recent fighting. There are no bodies though, so Aglaea has hope still. She rubs her fingertips against each other nervously and she remembers suddenly that she’s seen the Deliverer do something similar. She thinks of his marred fingernails again. She balls her fingers into a fist and they set out, following the trail of the fight. There is silence all around them.

“Look at all the dead titankin,” Castorice says and yes, she’s right. Countless titankin frame the way, but it’s so many; where did they all come from? This area wasn’t supposed to be so dangerous. If she’d known, she would’ve sent more people.

“Agy, do you think it’s a ploy again?”

Aglaea simply nods. She wouldn’t put it past the council. If anything, she’s surprised they haven’t tried to assassinate the Deliverer yet, but perhaps it was a wise move on the boy’s behalf to endear himself to the townsfolk so. To someone so public; they’d be careful to go against.

“Let us make haste,” she suggests, “while we still can.”

The tiankin soon get joined by black tide creatures. They find blood on the way, as well, but they’re unsure whether it’s human blood or not—it has dried into the soil already, and none of them would rather touch it. It hardly matters, regardless, because it is already spilled. It’s not golden, at least, and they breathe easier for it.

“Agy,” Tribbie calls her, “there’s a body.”

Aglaea closes her eyes in silent preparation, then she walks over. Among the monsters is one of the guards. She hopes he died quickly, and that none will join him, but she already knows it is a futile wish.

“There are more over here. Lady Aglaea, do you think you’d be able to provide me their names later?”

“Of course, Cas. Thank you.”

Handing a list of names to Castorice will never grow easier; on neither of them. Oh, how she wishes she never would have to again; and knowing it will only increase.

“Snowy isn’t among them. Let’s keep going.”

So forward they go. What would she do, if she found the Deliverer among the dead? Would she weep for him, like she would for Cifera? No... she knows the answer. She would weep for the *Deliverer*, not the boy that died. Oh, how cruel she has become. She doesn’t even know his *name*.

“I can hear fighting up ahead,” Castorice says and she readies her scythe. Aglaea doesn’t draw her weapon just yet, and she beckons Castorice to stand down, as well. Tribbie stays in the back, unfit for fighting. Breathing deep, Aglaea takes point and as they turn a corner, they see—bodies and bodies of titankin piled atop of each other, too many for this area, and in the middle stands a white-haired boy, pushing back the last remaining black tide creature with his sword. He screams, in rage and exhaustion, and he headbutts the creature, pushing it slightly off-kilter and he grabs his sword tight; old and dull as it is, and he slashes the monster in half with a strength Aglaea would not have expected from a body such as his.

The beast falls and the boy stands, breathing heavily, never loosening his hold on the sword he is holding.

“Snowy!” Teacher calls loudly across the battlefield and the boy flinches, turning around in their direction in a flash. Guarded, he has his sword raised, pointing it at them. His eyes are wide and unfocused, but as he starts to recognise them, he lowers the weapon and slowly, shakily, he makes his way over to them. He tries to be steady, Aglaea can tell. He’s trying so hard.

“You,” he gasps, out of breath, “are here?”

He’s covered in blood and sweat and dirt. His chest heaves with breaths he’s not allowing himself to take.

“Of course! When you stopped checking in, **we** grew so worried! What happened?”

He barely glances at Tribbie, before looking at Aglaea again.

“I,” he starts, then stops, calculating his words, “I’m sorry. I should’ve... I should’ve realised sooner. I couldn’t, I couldn’t save them. I’m sorry, it’s all, it’s all my fault. I should’ve told them to go when I realised, but by that point it was already too late. I will—I will personally go and apologise to the families. I’m sorry, Lady Goldweaver, I wasn’t—I couldn’t fulfil your mission. The refugees were dead when we arrived, and I underestimated the threat. I should have—“

He stops dead in his tracks when Aglaea steps forward and roughly pulls him into a hug.

“You live,” she breathes. His hair reeks somewhat terrible. Oh, she’ll need to wash him at least twice. “Forgive me, my little Deliverer. I should not have sent you all alone. I was unkind to you, ever since you arrived. My child, I promise to make it up to you. My little hero, will you tell me who you are?”

He is still in her embrace, and she feels his hot breath against her collarbone. Maybe he’s running a fever. She will accompany him to the healer personally. She’ll do better from now on, as much as she is able.

The boy’s sword falls to the ground and he lifts his arms slowly, unsure, to hug her back. She wishes he wouldn’t. She hasn’t earned it, but he still gives it to her.

“Phainon,” he whispers, “Phainon of Aedes Elysiae.”

*

“You were unkind to the Deliverer,” Mydeimos says and all she can do is bow her head. It is true, she can’t deny it. “I never would have thought; they way he speaks of you.”

“Phainon is a gracious man,” she agrees. “Better perhaps than what we deserve.”

Mydeimos turns his head away from her and stares at the sorry excuse of a flower crown in his hands.

“The Deliverer made a flower crown for me,” he says, “and he gifted it to me. He said—he said that the son of Gorgo may be crowned in flowers.”

The Son of Gorgo will be crowned in blood.

She has heard the detachment speak this line, and she had wondered how it affected Mydeimos. Not very well, by the looks of it.

“Is that what you wish?”

“Yes,” he answers after some hesitation. “I don’t want to lead my people down the same old path. So perhaps, this is the crown I deserve. I’m not very good at making them, however. I wish to weave a crown I could place on the Deliverer’s head and have it be worthy.”

“Well, not with these poor attempts in your hands, Mydeimos.”

“I am *training*—“

“Without a teacher? Don’t be ridiculous. Come, Mydeimos; let us weave a crown together. Between the two of us, I am certain we will create something worthy for Phainon of Aedes Elysiae.”

As she sits with the last king of Castrum Kremnos, her mind can’t help but wander to the Imperator. The almighty Imperator would never fall to anything but her own Imperator’s blade, stabbed straight through her heart, left to bleed out into the waters forevermore—as she sits here, all she can hope for; is that the King’s flowers will not suffocate his lungs and leave him to wither alone in a barren field.

May your Deliverer be the one to crown you, Aglaea wishes, *and may you be the one that will forever make him smile.*

Chapter 5: the burden of existence

Chapter Notes

> Hello, it's me again, the one that posts at the WORST times ever in the history of man.
> Fair warning, I wrote most of this in google docs so if the formatting is terrible-- it wasn't me. google docs suck. And I REALLY don't have the patience to retype everything, so we will all have to suffer this terrible formatting. I tried to salvage it a little but. Well. WE WILL ALL SUFFER. Also I will not be using google docs again.
> Microsoft Word 2007 reins supreme.
>
> Oh yeah, next chapter very likely the last one! Let's see how long it'll get~ Let me know what you think!

[Phainon]

Anaxa’s experiment blew up in my face

[Mydei]

Deliverer what are you doing

[Phainon]

I was assisting! It turns out golden blood and Dromas blood don’t mix very well. Don’t ask me what the point was, though. Something about Dromas superiority?

[Mydei]

HKS did you get hurt

[Phainon]

Hm? Oh! No no, I've been good! Well I nicked myself on accident. Hyacine already scolded me though, so don't you start! I was polishing my sword and started day-dreaming

[Mydei]

Can you focus

[Phainon]

No not usually why

[Mydei]

Ugh when are you coming back

[Mydei]

?

[Phainon]

Soon soon don’t worry but Castorice is selecting books from the library and Anaxa makes her go through a two-hour procedure for every single one

[Phainon]

Do you miss me

[Mydei]

Don’t be stupid

[Mydei]

Did you touch yourself

[Mydei]

?

[Mydei]

Deliverer

[Mydei]

Deliverer

[Phainon]

[Image Attached]

Mydei taps on the image and promptly throws his teleslate in the air. Thank the titans he's at home and not, like, *anywhere* else. He crawls over the couch and retrieves his teleslate, looking at the picture again. It's, admittedly, a bad angle, but that's to be expected.
The picture is of Phainon's naked ass, and the hand not holding the teleslate is pulling is cheek apart a little, revealing Phainon's favourite red plug nestled inside the hole. Now, either Phainon just put it in for picture purposes, he had that picture lying around for some reason *or* he's been wearing it all day.

[Phainon]

You tell me

[Mydei]

HKS did you walk around like that

[Phainon]

What if I did

[Mydei]

You're the fucking death of me

[Phainon]

Hehe =3

[Mydei]

Take it out
no more until you come back

[Phainon]

What!
But that’s unfair Mydeiii

[Mydei]

Do it Deliverer

[Phainon]

Ok fine! We should start our journey back the day after tomorrow I think
Aglaea isn’t texting me back is everything alright over there

[Mydei]

Yes Okhema still stands Deliverer she’s probably just busy

[Phainon]

Ok because I was gonna ask her if we should try to pick up some refugees on the way back because I think I heard something about them from the students so I wanted to ask if it's ok if I go alone or if I should take the girls with me

[Mydei]

HKS you're on vacation just enjoy your stay in the grove

[Phainon]

Okayyyy... if you say so!
ok I have to go Hyacine says it's lunch time

See you soon miss you!!

Mydei breathes heavily through his nose. Fucking HKS. The things Phainon does *will* kill him someday. It's been almost a week and even though they text almost every day, Mydei still misses the Deliverer. It's too quiet in the city, and it's hard to evade Krateros without a handy Deliverer at his heels.

He also misses Castorice. When they get back, they should do a—what did Phainon call it?—a video night, or something; where they watch videos together. Spending time with Aglaea and the triplets always drains him so—they're adults, after all, and he gets less opportunity to goof around. Not that he ever does, it's all Phainon, but he constantly feels like he's on inspection.

Sighing, he gets up and decides to go outside. No point in wasting away alone in here; and if Phainon spoke true, the man might be back in less than four days.

Surprisingly, he meets Aglaea sitting at a little haunt; carefully sipping away at her beverage.

“Aglaea,” he greets her and only sits down after she invited him to do so.

“Mydeimos,” she responds, “how do you fare? The city is quite silent without Phainon, isn’t it?”

“Tell me about it,” he grunts, placing his arms on the table. He won’t pout. He wants to, but he won’t. “He texted me earlier. They might return within the week.”

Aglaea nods. “Yes, he tried to message me as well. I hoped by not responding he would get the message that he’s off-duty. If there truly are refugees in need of aid, I will send word.”

He nods. He’s thought so, but Phainon is the kind of guy that just can’t stop worrying.

“It’s quite rare to see you out and about, Aglaea.”

“I suppose so,” she agrees, “but even I can’t hole out in the baths all hours of the day. Also, Teacher said I should go out more often. Really… after a thousand years, she still treats me as if I were a child.”

He thinks that if another thousand years were to pass, she would treat Phainon no other way. Such is the nature of elders, he presumes, but keeps silent on it. Krateros, after all, keeps harping about the past as well.

“Mydeimos, if I might trouble you,” Aglaea says, “I have a request.”

He nods, urging her to continue: “I have received multiple reports about several members of the detachment causing trouble. No harm nor property

damage has been reported, so I was able to put it aside for the moment, but I would like for you to interfere before it becomes a larger concern."

Trouble? It's no secret that a lot of the Kremnoans aren't happy here. They yearn for battle and bloodshed, and the tranquility inside the city is ill-becoming for them. He keeps telling them they would be able to be sent out on mission if they were only willing to cooperate with the City Guard. They wouldn't even need to join their rank, and yet—he sighs.

"I understand. I will talk to them as soon as possible."

Aglaea smiles at him, nodding in approval. "Thank you," she says, "I'd rather not get the council involved in this.You know how they vie for the dismissal of your people."

"You weren't happy with us here, either."

"No, I was not," she admits easily, "and I'm sure you understand. Your people have been Okhema's enemies for longer than you have lived; and your bloody past outpaces you. I feared it to be yet another tactic—to get inside our walls to destroy us from within. If it were not for Phainon, I would not have allowed your people to remain, even if it would've meant losing you for the flame-chase."

It's not nice to hear it, but he understands. Perhaps, in her shoes, he would've acted the same way.

"Let me find Krateros. He will know whatever is going on with my people."

"Come by my office later, Mydeimos. I have things to show you, if you please."

He nods, and stands up, making his way to where most of the detachment has pitched their tents. He hopes whatever trouble his people have found is easy to calm. He's not very skilled in playing negotiator, after all.

“Krateros,” he calls when he finally spots his old teacher. The man is talking to some others, but quickly dismisses them when he sees Mydei approach.

“My Lord,” Krateros greets him, “it has been a while. Glory has been yours, I assume?”

Mydei doesn’t pull a face, but part of him wants to. The last mission he went to was entirely underwhelming and he doesn’t believe for one second that Krateros isn’t one of the first to know if he ever leaves the city. And on the same hand, his teacher also always seems to know what kind of mission Mydei had gone onto, so what’s that useless greeting?

“I hear there has been trouble. Explain,” he demands, looking just disinterested enough. Krateros stiffens and his jaw locks tight. Ah. So he *had* something to do with this *trouble*. Mydei wouldn’t be surprised if it had something to do with the Chrysos Heirs and the flame-chase.

“My Lord, I—”

“I don’t care for your excuses, Krateros. Tell me what happened; and why it happened.”

“Our people are restless, Mydeimos! Don’t you think this… this *farce* has gone on long enough? Why won’t we go home?”

Ah. So this is what this is. Krateros had never been a friend to the idea of going to Okhema for shelter and security. In fact, when Mydei had proposed the idea, Krateros had protested vehemently against it. In the end, of course, he had conceded, and Mydei had always worried that he might do something—unthoughtful.

“We don’t know where Castrum Kremnos is, Krateros. If you wish to set out on your own, be my guest. Take whoever with you, if they wish to leave. I thought you understood that this is the end of this era, maybe even this world; and yet you still refuse to see Okhema as our allies? I have spoken to the Lady Goldweaver—should we make it out of here alive, then

our relationship towards Okhema will change. You *know* my mind, Krateros. I've no desire for senseless conquests."

"Conquests are in our blood! It's what we *are*! And yet you dare to declare that we should change our ways? I knew, I *knew*, that this *Deliverer* is no good for you. He's made you soft, Mydeimos. Or no, should I call you *Mydei* now? That boy—"

"Stop," Mydei orders, "you're out of line. Speak ill of the Deliverer *or* my allies again, may Nikador grant you mercy, because I will not."

Krateros seethes, Mydei can tell. But he doesn't care. Nobody gets to trashtalk Phainon other than himself.
"I never yearned for being king; but all of you wish to see me on the throne. If those are your wishes, then you will have to accept my ways, or leave Kremnos behind. *I* have chosen to ally with Okhema, and *I* have chosen to participate in their flame-chase journey. As for the Deliverer—you have seen him in battle, Krateros. You know even you would stand no chance against him. Speak ill of the Deliverer, and you speak ill of me. If there are things troubling you or our people—they can always address me *or* the Deliverer; and we will do our best. Our children already know, so it cannot be that hard, now can it?"

Krateros bows his head. Mydei knows the man is not satisfied, but that's not his concern. If Krateros truly hates it here so much—well, nobody is holding him hostage. And even if they were to return to Castrum Kremnos, assuming they could find it, then what? All that's left of their once splendid city are crumbling ruins. To rebuild it, they'd need resources; resources he's sure his people would want to obtain through conquering other city states. But this is the end of the world—who even has resources left? And what would be the point of rebuilding something, if the black tide is knocking on their door no matter what? Mydei is uneasy thinking about taking in the coreflame of Strife, because he fears his people will never walk a new path if he does; but at the same time he knows he has little choice in it. Phainon has spoken about his desire to obtain Strife, but then who bears the world? Aglaea indulges him, for reasons of her own he's sure, and he's also sure that she expects him to fail. It's a cruel thing, he thinks—to allow Phainon

something of his own, all the while you know he will never be able to reach it.

“I understand, my lord. I… I will talk to our people. They will trouble the Okhemans no further.”

“Let them know to trouble me or the Deliverer, if they need to. If they are too prideful, let them send their children.”

With that, he walks away. He hasn’t actually found out what this *trouble* even was, but since no damage has been done, he assumes it was verbal assault. Phainon would lecture him about how words could cut deeper than any sword and Mydei would roll his eyes, shove the man and ask him if words could hurt more than that. After that, Phainon would kick him in the shin, and they’d be rough-housing on the floor.
Words could hurt more than any blade…

Mydei thinks of Phainon’s golden blood on the tiles, and he thinks. Maybe Phainon wouldn’t be wrong. After all, the words Phainon says then hurt far worse than the cuts in his flesh.
I only cut one thigh this time! Great, right?

“Aglaea,” he says when he enters her office, just like she’s asked.

“Mydeimos,” she greets him in return. “Were you able to resolve the issue?”

“ Well, I told Krateros to leave, if he were so inclined.”

“Truly, you are a brash one,” she laughs, “but if all went well, then I’m satisfied. Come around, I have things to show you. No worry, you will like it.”

Intrigued, he walks around her table and looks at what she wants to show him on her screen. She has her conversation with Hyacine opened, and there are—a lot of pictures that the healer had sent. All pictures of herself,

Castorice, Phainon and a green-haired man—who Mydei believes to be this Professor Anaxa Phainon keeps blabbering about.
A picture with the tree of them, with Phainon holding the photostone, with the Grove behind them.
Lord Phainon ate all his provisions! Cassie was upset she couldn't baby-bird feed him, though. He promised he'd forget soon, and then she could put her skills to the test. As a medic, I'm not sure humans should be fed this way, but as a friend I can't wait to see it.
A picture with the three of them again, now with the professor forced into their midst. Mydei can tell the man goes for an annoyed look, but he wasn't able to hide the fondness in his eye.
Lord Phainon insisted we show you all our pictures, even the ones with Professor Anaxa in them. But don't worry, I won't send them ALL to you… just the ones I like the most! Which will probably end up being still a lot of them… I wonder why Lord Phainon doesn't just simply send them to Lord Mydei? I think his excuse is that I'm the one with the photostone, but… he carries it most of the time…
The next picture is of Castorice and Hyacine, grinning into the camera at some table, with used dishware still strewn about. Clearly they just finished their meal of the day, and Mydei even spots an empty plate sitting alone, suggesting that even Phainon finished his food. It's not too unsurprising; he's rather good at social eating. It's that he forgets to do it when he's alone, is the problem.
The next picture has Phainon and Hyacine sleeping on a sofa, with him sprawled over her lap, and that unicorn of hers sitting on his head.
Lady Aglaea, Lord Phainon snores… it sounds cute. Oh, Professor Anaxa didn't say anything about Lord Phainon's clothes, if you were worried about that…? He was surprised though that you allowed Lord Phainon to leave for a whole week, saying that you 'slave' him too much. I told him that that's not true! And besides, Professor Anaxa is already roping us into his experiments…

"She's right," Mydei interjects, "your Deliverer does snore. I'm not sure if I'd call it cute."

"Perhaps not," Aglaea chuckles, "maybe you'd choose the word *adorable*, instead?"

The next few pictures are more of the same. It's either all three of them—sometimes four, if they manage to drag their professor outside—or two of them, with different backdrops of the Grove. One picture has Phainon and Castorice offer up their gift to the professor on their knees: a dromas plushie, probably sewn by Castorice. Several pictures follow where this Anaxa's face lights up and there are literal hearts in his remaining eye and he looks close to tears.
I think he liked our gift. Don't you agree, Lady Aglaea? After this, he cuddled that thing the entire day and wouldn't talk anymore. But he made sure we got whatever we wanted for dinner! He didn't even mention the colours… maybe there's hope yet for Lord Phainon!

"Perhaps I have to gift Anaxagoras plushies, then, for when he visits…"

"He can't be that bad, no? Due to the way the Deliverer speaks of him…"

"Phainon is flawed, Mydeimos. We all have lapses in judgement."

The next picture is Castorice and Hyacine posing with clothes they do not own. From a glance, it looks like they have raided Anaxa's wardrobe. The clothes fit Castorice surprisingly fine, while they're a little baggy on Hyacine.
The only thing Lord Phainon could fit in were the boots, and we really tried… we'll make up for it by decorating him in make-up tonight!
And indeed, the very next picture was Phainon with prettily painted nails, likely by Castorice, and a completely over-caked face, courtesy by Hyacine.
Cassie and I clearly disagreed on what we were going to do. Lord Phainon's nails are really short, do you think he'd apply salve if I give it to him?
Next up is Castorice and Hyacine pose with a disgruntled Anaxa. Mydei can't tell where they are, but it looks like an office. In the next picture, Castorice is proudly holding up two books, but Mydei can't tell the titles. The next three pictures are Hyacine playing with that unicorn of hers; and after that, it's the girls sitting at a table, sewing something. It looks plain, but they angled themselves so you can't tell what it is. Luckily, the next picture reveals it: it shows a beaming Castorice, holding up the two wooden sticks Phainon got her, but now there are—hand-like things on them?
We got Cassie hands! Now she can pat everyone!!

The next fifteen pictures were all of exactly that: Castorice using her new hand-sticks to pat and pet literally everything around her. Mydei can't help but smile at that; she looks so happy doing all of it.
The next picture shows Phainon sitting cross-legged on a bed, eating noodles from a bowl. He doesn't look up at the photostone, and he looks tired.
Sorry for no Phainon pictures lately! But he's been sick the past couple days, so we asked Professor Anaxa to watch over him a little… I know, I know! That was a bad idea, but both are still alive! That's all that matters! Oh, and tell Dei not to worry, okay? Lord Phainon just had a little fever, but he's good again now!
Next are two pictures of a much-healthier looking Phainon, clearly taken in quick succession: the first shows the man gaze lovingly at his teleslate, and the next has him look up, having noticed the first picture, and he's blushing furiously.
Hehe, just look how cute he looks when he's texting Dei… even Little Ica can tell he's in love! Do you think they'll confess if we push them?
Mydei blushes.

"Yes," Aglaea wonders out loud, "maybe we should push him a little. What are your thoughts on the matter, Mydeimos?"

The next picture might be Mydei's favourite. It shows the three of them laying on some grass, in a circle, and they're all holding hands together. That Ica creature sits square in the middle, raising its plump little hooves up above; and it's obvious from the shadow falling mainly over Phainon's body that Anaxa is taking the picture. He looks to Aglaea and catches her fond smile. He wouldn't be surprised if she saved this picture somewhere specifically.
The remaining pictures are much of the same; most of them show two or even all three of them sleeping somewhere. Occasionally, Anaxa will also be present in the pictures themselves, either not looking up or being actively disturbed.
The last picture shows Phainon gazing into the far distance, a forlorn look in his eyes, but the softest smile on his face. The dawn coats him in a fiery light, and he looks ethereal, if Mydei has anything to say about it.

“I can send that picture to you, if you’d like.”

“Yes, please. Thank you, Aglaea.”

About four days later, the three of them return. Mydei isn’t at the gates; because Phainon didn’t text him exactly when they’d return, because Phainon is an *asshole*, so Mydei only finds out by accidentally running into Hyacine and Castorice.

“Lord Mydei!” Castorice greets him, looking happier than Mydei remembers seeing her. “How are you?”

“Oh, you’ve… you’ve returned already? Did the Deliverer forget to text me?”

“Maybe he wanted to surprise you?” Hyacine suggests and Mydei frowns. He doesn’t like surprises. He’d rather be told head-on, instead, but well, Phainon is a special brand.

“Maybe he’s already at home, waiting for you!” Castorice exclaims excitedly before tempering herself again. “I mean. Waiting for you to go to your own house, so he can visit you.”

“Of course,” Mydei sighs. They really are bad at this stuff, aren’t they? “Anyway,” he continues, “since you both are here, I had a… an idea. What do you think about a, what’s it called, a video night? The four of us at the Deliverer’s house? I haven’t asked him, but it’s not like he’d refuse.”

Hyacine claps her hands together in delight. “Of course!” She agrees willingly. “We’ll pick out some videos for us to watch, can you take care of the snacks? We could even surprise Lord Phainon with this!”
Mydei smiles and nods. He knows the three of them just spent over a week together, but he’s glad they seem so susceptible to his idea. He doesn’t feel left out, per se, but maybe he’s longing for a friend group again. He knows he could’ve gone with them to the Grove, but—that place isn’t for him. He’s hardly smart enough for the illustrious Grove, no matter how much

Phainon might protest against that. Battle intelligence and scholar intelligence are quite different things. And that's alright. He doesn't need to excel in everything to be fulfilled—after all, his name isn't Phainon.

"I will—text you later then?" He asks, a little unsure, but both girls nod. Good. That's good. "I will go home, then, to see if—if the Deliverer has arrived. Goodbye, for now."

The two of them bid him farewell, and Mydei turns back around, going straight to Phainon's house. In no way would the Deliverer be in Mydei's house, not after being away for so long. He's probably upset that Mydei wasn't there, sitting on a chair, just waiting to be surprised. Standing before the door, he sighs. Whatever. He can be nice, can't he? He's such a good boyfriend.

"Ah, I'm so lonely. Whenever will my Deliverer return," he says in the most deadpan way possible to man as he enters the house. As predicted, something flies in his face immediately. He tries to remain stoic, because he has an image to maintain but he just can't help himself when Phainon starts rubbing his cheek against his face.

"Never to fear, your Deliverer is here!"

Mydei huffs out a little laugh, and then he wraps his arms around Phainon, kissing his temple.

"That you are," he agrees, "how was your trip?"

"It was good! We had a lot of fun. Oh, do you remember the chair I murdered for Castorice? We made like, hands for that, so now she can touch things better! It feels weird when she pats your head, but it's better than nothing! What about you? Did you miss me~"

"HKS, of course I did. I only had Aglaea and the triplets for company. They're not bad, but they aren't exactly sparring partners."
Phainon nods, thoughtful.

“Well, at least I’m back now~”

“That you are,” Mydei agrees and kisses him. Phainon wraps his arms around Mydei’s neck, pulling himself tighter, and Mydei’s hands start to wander. He’s missed the Deliverer, but his body still feels the same. He cups Phainon’s head and dips him backwards, pushing his tongue in the other’s mouth. Phainon sighs dreamily, and Mydei squeezes his hip. Phainon then starts walking backwards, pulling Mydei alongside him and he guides them into the bedroom, where he bumps against the bed before sitting down on it, making Mydei bend over. He doesn’t mind, of course.

“Let me suck your dick,” Phainon breathes against his lips and well, Mydei is but a man. He pushes Phainon further on the bed and he climbs onto it himself, laying down against the headrest. Phainon is on him in an instant, nuzzling Mydei’s growing erection through his pants.

“Did you jerk off while I was gone?”

“No,” Mydei says, “only with you. Only ever with you.”

Phainon blushes and he gently unzips Mydei’s pants, letting his cock spring free. He’s half-hard already and under Phainon’s intense gaze, it won’t take long for him to fully grow hard. Ever the tease, Phainon kitten-licks the tip and Mydei lets out a long breath.
While Mydei likes swallowing a cock down to the hilt as soon as he can, Phainon has quite the different approach. The Deliverer prefers licking and teasing. For example, right now he’s simply dragging his lips over the sensitive head, breathing hot air against the flesh. His deft fingers wrap around the shaft, trailing up and down, while his tongue swirls around it, covering as little as he can stand. It drives Mydei crazy, and Phainon knows; which is *why* he’s doing it. Mydei is regulating his breathing, because he doesn’t want to blow his load so soon. It’s difficult, he’ll admit, when Phainon closes his mouth around the tip, suckling gently. He hasn’t even taken the whole head inside his mouth and *fuck*, Mydei knows if he were to look down, all he would be able to think about would be how *cute* Phainon looks.

“Deliverer…” he warns and Phainon hums around him. His fingers stopped their trailing, and instead gently wrap around him in a feather-light touch. Mydei bites his lip when he feels Phainon’s tongue licking along his slit and he sits up, grabbing Phainon’s hair. The man lets go and sticks his tongue out, as Mydei wraps his hand around his cock to jerk it off. Fucking asshole always makes him do all the work… he grunts and he comes, watching it apt fascination as Phainon catches his spend with his tongue. HIs dick twitches and he watches Phainon wipe it out of his face, looking up at him. He gets up a little, and he kisses Mydei, pushing his tongue straight in. Mydei groans, wrapping his arms around the Deliverer, pulling him back with him. The first few times, it’s been weird, tasting himself on Phainon’s tongue, but now he hardly minds it anymore.

“Deliverer,” he says again after parting and he can feel his cock twitch.

“Hmm,” Phainon responds and pushes Mydei on his back and leans over him, trailing kisses on his body. Mydei sighs in contentment and he relishes in Phainon’s soft fingertips trailing over his hot skin.

“Do you remember,” Phainon asks, “that hot day like two years back?”

Mydei thinks briefly before chuckling. “Yes,” he confirms then, “I think that thing is still in the closet.”

“It was really hot,” Phainon laughs, sitting up to undress himself. Two years ago, the heat in Okhema had been utterly unbearable for weeks on end. Phainon, who did poorly in heat anyway, had lamented his clothes, being covered head to toe. And one day, he had made the executive decision to wear something different—he hadn’t even asked Aglaea if he could—and he had gone outside, wearing just a light robe. Most of his chest had been uncovered—although the choker had stayed on—and he’d been flashing his thighs to nearly everyone in the Holy City. When Mydei had seen him, he had barely recognised him at first, until Phainon had spotted him, gleefully calling him over. At that point, they had been fucking for a while already, and Mydei had felt very possessive of Phainon and his thighs. So when he had seen the man—out and about, with thighs visible to everyone—Mydei had, admittedly, not thought with his right brain; and he had dragged the Deliverer off to an alley to slam him against the wall, fucking him right

then and there. The thrill of discovery had only spurned him on, and based on Phainon's barely suppressed moans, the Deliverer had felt it as well. He had accompanied him the rest of the day, and seeing Phainon press his thighs together to prevent himself from leaking had made Mydei fuck him so much harder later in their bed.
Mydei groans when Phainon sinks himself down on his cock. Riding him is definitely Phainon's favourite position, and who's he to argue?

"So big~" Phainon moans, breathing hard. He looks down at Mydei, licking his lips.

"And you're so tight," Mydei agrees, "always fascinating me how you take me so well each time."

Phainon laughs and he bends forwards, pressing his hands against Mydei's abdomen. He slowly starts rotating his hips, biting his lip.

"Just for you," he breathes, "only ever for you."

Mydei growls a little, reaching his hands out to grab Phainon's thighs. He'd die for those thighs. He might be a little obsessed with them, but how could anyone blame him, when Phainon wears that thigh belt every single day?

"Ah," Phainon moans, "right there, fuck, Mydeimos~"

While Phainon still does most of the moving, Mydei starts directing him a little. After all, he knows the Deliverer's body better than himself, and he knows *exactly* how to make the man lose his composure. He bucks his hips up and Phainon arches his back, moaning like a bitch in heat.

"Mydei!" He screams. "Please, more… I need more…"

Mydei moves his hands to the man's hips and after rotating his own hips for a little, he reverts their positions, and slams Phainon into the mattress. Phainon below him is definitely *his* favourite position, and who could blame him?
He leans forward and bites the man's throat as he starts to move his hips. Phainon moans and wraps his legs around Mydei, trying to pull him deeper.

Mydei, however, is relentless. He can feel Phainon's hole clench around him and he's missed the feeling. He can feel his cock twitch inside and he moves his mouth to the man's shoulder to sink his teeth into. Phainon throws his arms around Mydei's shoulders, his useless nails trying to scratch at the skin.

"Deliverer," he breathes against the freshly-bitten shoulder, "do you ever want to switch?"

"Are you… are you *really* asking me that *right now*?? You are aware you're balls deep inside me, right?"

"I… yes. I forgot, earlier."

"Oh titans. Oh, Mydei, you idiot." Phainon laughs, so that's not too bad. But yes, maybe he should've waited, but what if he forgot again?

"Do *you* want to switch?"

"I don't know," Mydei admits, "but if you wanted…"

"I *like* the feeling of you inside me," Phainon says, rolling his hips in demonstration. "I like how well you can fill me up… ah, yes, Mydei, right there… *please*… ah-ah—ah…!"

Phainon's legs around him tighten and Mydei moves a little faster, aiming for just the right spot. Phainon grabs onto Mydei's hair, pulling it harshly and he can feel the man's hole tighten around his cock and he groans himself, being squeezed *so* tight he almost comes himself. But not yet. Not just yet.

"I love," Phainon pants, "how you spear me open, ah, Mydei, fuck, you have, nnh, no idea… how much… ah, I ache for you… fuck, how are you, how are you *so* big… I love… how you, a fuck, too much, how you fill that void inside of me… Mydei please, please, fuck me—!"

He doesn't need to be asked twice. He pulls out, almost all the way, until his tip just barely teases Phainon's hole, before slamming all the way back in,

pushing the air out of Phainon's lungs. He won't last long like this, but that doesn't matter. It's been so *long*, and he just wants to be here. Phainon pants and begs and Mydei can feel his dick twitching and Phainon is so *tight*, and he comes with a deep groan, deep inside of Phainon, and the man's hands roam over Mydei's shoulders, trying to hold on, just to eventually fall away. Mydei slows his thrusts, being spent, and he slowly comes to a halt, but he doesn't pull out.

"Let's," Phainon breathes, "let's take a bath."

Mydei nods, pressing a kiss against sweaty skin, and he slowly stands up, gathering Phainon in his arms.

"I think I have a future as a career waif, don't you think?"

"Oh, yes," Mydei agrees, laughing, "you'd be the best at it."

In the bath, Mydei opens the faucet, after which he places a towel down, so they can sit and wait for the water to warm up. He won't sit either of their naked asses on tile.

"Was there any trouble while I was gone?"

"No—well, apparently there was some with the detachment, but I dealt with it."

"Oh? Did something happen?"

"No," Mydei shakes his head, "just some verbal assault, I believe. I told them they are free to leave, if they so desire."

"I'll talk to the council," Phainon sighs, "there's got to be something we can do."

Mydei softly kisses the crown of his head. "Don't worry so much about it. It'll all work out."

"Maybe you're right," Phainon laughs, "things could be good for a change."

When the water has reached a nice enough temperature, Mydei places Phainon inside first, before following after him. Phainon immediately leans back into Mydei's chest and he's not one to complain.

"Wash my hair," the bratty Deliverer demands and Mydei sighs. But he reaches for the soap regardless, getting Phainon's hair wet, and then washing it.

"You're good at this," Phainon remarks and Mydei scoffs.

"Washing one's hair is a basic skill."

"You just can't take a compliment, can you? Well then! Your nails are too long!"

Mydei hits him over the head from behind.

"I'll send you back to the Grove, so that professor of yours can blow you up properly."

"Ah… nobody loves me…"

Fed up, Mydei pushes Phainon's head under the water and the man just laughs, and he reaches out, grabbing Mydei's hair and pulling him down too. They don't get a lot of washing done, in the end, but they leave the bath dripping wet. They chase around the house, naked as the day they were born, with Mydei giving chase to an escaped Phainon. Both of them laugh, not a care in the world, and when Phainon jumps over the sofa, Mydei catches him, falling backwards and as Mydei cushions Phainon's fall, Phainon cushions Mydei's head with his hand.
They laugh, still, the last warm remnant of it and they exchange small little kisses, breathing into each other. Mydei gently caresses Phainon's cheek and the man leans into it, nuzzling.

"I love you," Mydei whispers and Phainon lets out the smallest sigh, and his eyes sparkle. He doesn't say it back, but he leans down, nuzzling his nose

against Mydei's in a sign of affection.

"I'm tired," he says instead and Mydei just gently hums. He must have had a long day, after all, and there's always tomorrow. He gently pecks Phainon's lips, before getting up. He intertwines their fingers, and walks with Phainon back to their bedroom.

"Good night, Deliverer," he says as they settle into bed, "we shall spar tomorrow."

Mydei isn't sure for how long he's slept when something shakes him awake. The Dawn Device really is a problem for natural time-telling. He could've slept five minutes or five months, and he would never know.

"Mydei," he hears Phainon's soft voice behind him.

"What?" Mydei grunts. "There's food in the kitchen somewhere."

Phainon responds not at first, but his touch is feather-light. Mydei wants to go back to sleep, but something is preventing him.
Phainon leans forward and places something in Mydei's open palm. Gruntling, he tries to determine what it is. It's a little warm to the touch, so Phainon has probably held it for a spell before passing it over. It's straight, too, and when he closes his hand around it—
He tears his eyes open and confirms that yes, it's a knife. Blissfully, it is unstained for now. He sits up quickly and stares at Phainon who looks blankly ahead. There's no blood, at least none he can see. He holds the knife tight and while he doesn't quite get *why* Phainon gave it ot him, he is glad for it.

"Deliverer—"

"I want to cut myself," he gets interrupted and all air leaves his lungs. They're still naked, not having bothered to dress. They are still damp, because they had no mind to dry off after the bath. Mydei tries to regulate his breathing because he—this hasn't happened before. Usually Phainon

waits until he's alone, and Mydei is left to find him in the aftermath. He doesn't… he doesn't know what to *do*. He could ask why. He could demand to be told the reason, but he doesn't believe that there even is one. Things like this, he thinks, are beyond common logic. And even if there *were* a reason, he doesn't believe that Phainon could tell him, in this state.

"Why give me this?" He asks, breathless, lifting the knife.

Phainon just shakes his head. "I don't know," he admits, "but I want to hurt myself."
He's fidgeting with his fingers, pulling at whatever remains of his fingernails. Mydei looks down. He could say No, he could put the knife away, and he could hold Phainon down just to be sure. He could deny Phainon this, and hope that this mood will have evaporated by morning. But…
He clutches the knife a little tighter. Maybe he will come to regret this. Maybe this will be a terrible choice, but… how many times must Phainon have felt like this; laying in bed with him only with the desire to hurt himself? How many times has he denied himself; how many times did he sneak out, give into his urges and clean the evidence away after; leaving Mydei none the wiser?

"Let me do it, then."

"What?" Phainon asks, surprised, and he lifts his head. His eyes are still too dull, but there's a spark of surprise in there. Whatever the man had expected to happen, *this* clearly hadn't been it. Maybe he had expected to be scolded? Mydei doesn't know. He doesn't know the right course of action, but he—he's chosen this path, and now he will walk it.

"Let me do it, then," he repeats, gently taking Phainon's wrist in his hand. "I cannot bear to see your pain—it hurts more than a thousand deaths. Let me do this for you, so you will not have to suffer it alone."

He shuffles closer to the man kneeling in front of him and doing it on the bed is probably a bad idea, but he's no mind to relocate. He bumps his forehead against Phainon and puts the blade against the thin flesh of his wrist. He's never wanted to be the reason for scars on the Deliverer's body.

He breathes hard, swallowing through a dry throat, and he closes his eyes. He applies gentle pressure, and slides the blade along the skin. It barely bleeds, and he hopes that it's good enough, but Phainon quietly reaches out, closing his hand around Mydei's and brings the blade to his skin once more. He makes him apply far more pressure and Mydei doesn't protest, simply following the Deliverer's lead, and he forces his eyes to stay open, so he can see it—can see the cursed blood spill forth.
I love you, he wishes to say, uselessly, but he doesn't, because there'd be no point. As Phainon makes Mydei perform the same cut again and again, golden blood stains the sheet beneath them.

"I'm here," Phainon says tonelessly, quiet against the bright night, "until the very end, I'm always here."

He speaks as if Mydei is the one needing the comfort; as if it were not Phainon bleeding golden blood; dying deaths far worse than Mydei ever could experience.

"For tomorrow," Phainon continues, "until the west wind blows forth the new dawn, I will always be the Deliverer."

Chapter 6: burn so everbright

Chapter Notes

> ....I know, I know, it's not the last chapter, but! This was 6k long already... so we'll see how long the next chapter will be! I really need to start thinking about myphaifest, haha... gotta activate turbo mode. Oh! Hephaestion is in this chapter! There's a segment signaled by * at the beginning and * at the end, if you want to skip his part.
>
> Something unrelated, but I recently decided that I HC Mydei as a gay ace (sex-positive) so. Yay :)
>
> It's 4am... on a sunday night.... I NEED A REAL POSTING SCHEDULE

Despite Mydei’s initial desire, he doesn’t spend the next few days glued to Phainon’s side. The man is like an ant: always working, always running. As he’s been gone for over a week, there are a lot of antiques that need appraisal, and everyone (Mydei assumes) has been missing the Deliverer’s live-streams. Phainon smiles and laughs like he usually does, but Mydei’s eyes keep glancing at the man’s wrist, safely hidden away from prying eyes. He does use his right hand a little less than usual, which probably indicates that the cuts *have* been a tad too deep, but since the man is ambidextrous, people don’t really notice. Mydei believes that *he* would notice, but how could he really tell? Phainon keeps everything close to his chest.

“Mydei!”

Mydei looks up from the pomegranates he had been inspecting to see Phainon run straight for him. The man barely manages to slide to a stop before him, huffing out some large breaths.

“Deliverer,” Mydei acknowledges him, “what’s the matter? Don’t tell me you saw a bird.”

“What? No! I mean yes, I did see a bird, it was really pretty but I had nothing to lure it with, so I just stared at it, making some bird noises, and then it flew away... do you think I offended it? No, wait, that’s not why I came! Why are you always distracting me? Anyway! There’s a lady selling some apples! You wanted to make, uh, apple tarts for the triplets, right? I couldn’t afford them, but I asked her to keep some for you! Come, come!”

Phainon lightly grabs his wrist and starts tugging. Mydei abandons the pomegranates, and willingly follows, because Phainon is right. He *has* promised Trianne some apple tarts, if he would ever get his hands on some apples. But the fact that Phainon remembered...

“Do you like apples, Deliverer?”

“Hm? Oh, yeah, I guess? I mean, who doesn’t, right? Come on, Lady Trianne will be delighted!”

Hmpf, typical. He could’ve just said *No, I actually like peaches better.* But nooo, of course it could never be that simple. How is Mydei supposed to surprise him with his favourite fruit tart like that? Maybe he should try his luck by asking Aglaea, but it’s doubtful she knows, if he’s being honest. He sighs, and keeps getting pulled along.

The vendor doesn’t have many apples, but what she has will have to do. They’re not even that expensive, when he thinks about it. Right, Phainon’s coin purse has the biggest hole in all of Amphoreus. He can’t gain money as fast as he’s spending it. Aglaea once said that she put him on a budget, just for him to blow through it in less than two days. Ever since, she’s said, she needed to make sure he can get free food somewhere. Mydeimos’ arrival had apparently been a blessing, even if all he fed the Deliverer was slop.

“You will help me bake,” Mydeimos declares and Phainon blinks.

“But you never want to cook with me. You say I’m pretentious and all that. Picky.”

“You are,” he agrees, “but you will bake with me.”

Phainon shrugs. “Alright, fine. But I have you know, I never actually baked any bread. I just harvested the wheat sometimes, but mostly I just slept in it.”

Right. He’s a farm boy, it’s such an easy thing to forget.

“So you’ve always been a bum.”

“Hey!!”

“So, when you said *you will bake with me*, I thought you meant more than... me just kind of sitting here.”

Phainon is placed on the counter, perfectly seated so that he can watch Mydei do all the work. Phainon isn’t useless in the kitchen. He’s actually pretty good, provided he’s cooking for someone other than himself. If it were for himself only, he’d probably just scrape something out of the drain and call that a day. So, why does Mydei not utilise the man? Maybe it’s simple: when cracking eggs, he had been too slow. Mydei is not competitive about this usually, but Phainon had been too slow; and he had used his right hand on instinct.

“You are injured,” he states, “I don’t want blood on my tarts.”

“Ugh, are you still harping on about that? It’s already been two days!”

As if Mydei would believe for a single second that Phainon hadn’t put the blade against his own flesh again. Just once is never enough for the overachieving Deliverer.

“If I look at the bandage,” he says, “would I not see blood?”

Phainon, wisely, stays quiet. He swings his legs, trying to kick Mydei, but he’s too far away.

“I wouldn’t get blood in the batter, you know.”

Mydei sighs and puts his utensils down.

“I know,” he reassures, “it’s not about that. Your wound will not heal if you don’t give it enough time. Show me.”

Instinctively, Phainon presses his wrist against his chest, cradling it protectively. He looks affronted, as if Mydei ordered him to hack it off and eat it raw. He’s not a *heathen*. He’d allow Phainon to boil it first, of course.

“I just want to check it,” he presses, and Phainon sighs, clearly sensing he’s not going to win this one, so he reaches out his arm, going as limp as he can while still remaining upright. Mydei carefully slides the cloth off his hand and turns the arm around. Yes, he was correct: there’s dried blood on the bandage. Some of it is old, but there are also fresher patches. Mydei frowns. Did the Deliverer not change the bandages?

“When did you last change these?”

“Before I left the house,” the man answers after a while of silence and Mydei knows—Phainon had changed the bandages, but not before adding a new cut to his collection. He takes a deep breath, because anger isn’t going to get him anywhere.

“Alright,” he says as softly as he can, “go and get a new bandage. I’ll dress the wound for you.”

“But you’re baking, Mydei.”

“This is more important.”

Tarts can be re-made, even if it would be a shame for the apples. But there’s only one Phainon. Phainon curls his fingers, hesitating, and then he slides off the counter to grab the closest first-aid-kit. Until he returns, Mydei picks up his bowl again. No point in wasting time by waiting.

“Here,” Phainon returns, “it’s running low.”

Of course it is. It’s Phainon’s house, so of course it’s running low. Mydei never thinks about it, because if he did, he’d break something clean in half.

He sighs, and turns to open the little box. Its contents sure are looking thin, but that's alright. Everything he needs is still there. Gently, he takes Phainon's wrist in his hand again and cuts the old bandage open just enough to remove it. The blood on his skin is smeared, with some darker and lighter patches and the cuts themselves have barely scabbed over, running all zigzaggy. He doesn't mention it. He doesn't mention it how there are more than the ones they cut together. All he does is take a swab, to gently dab the dried blood away. Like this, the cuts—they still look bad, but not as much anymore. Phainon hisses when Mydei puts a tiny drop of alcohol to clean the wound. On top of everything else, he doesn't want Phainon to catch any blood sickness by accident.

"Hold still," he reprimands without any real heat in his voice, and he doesn't look up, either. He puts some wound cream on there, and then he grabs the gauze, wrapping the bandage tightly around the man's wrist.

"Try to flex your fingers," he orders and Phainon does. Good. It's not too tight, it seems. The last thing he'd want to do is cut off the bloodstream.

"It feels so stiff. I can't even bend my wrist properly," Phainon complains and Mydei slaps his thigh.

"You're not supposed to. Keep it even, and *don't* bend it, if you don't have to. Use your left hand as much as you can. Surely that's not a problem, Deliverer?"

Phainon pouts. Sometimes, Mydei envies him for being so deft with both hands, and wonders if the man was born like that, or if he's trained himself to be. Regardless, it's impressive.

"Why do you even care so much? I've had worse, you know. If it upsets you so much, I won't ask you again."

"No," Mydei is quick to say and he leans forward, pressing a kiss into Phainon's palm. "I'm glad you asked me. You can do it every time, if you wish. I meant it when I said I don't want you to carry that burden alone, Deliverer. I care about you; I care about you so much."

Phainon reaches out his other hand and gently fondles Mydei's braid again. Mydei goes still for a moment, and then he looks up. He tries really hard to not say anything when Phainon pushes his thumb into the braid, threatening to undo it.

"If he were here," Phainon asks, "would you still care about me?"

"Of course," Mydei is quick to say, but he moves away a spell, and Phainon's fingers fall away from the braid. Nothing seems to have come loose, he is quick to check.

"How do you know?"

"Because I just do, Deliverer. What is it that you truly wish to say?"

Phainon looks down at him, and then he sighs, shaking his head slightly. He smiles, just a little, and pushes his feet against Mydei's stomach.

"Nothing," he deflects, "get back to baking. Just think of Lady Trianne's face... Miss Castorice and Miss Hyacine might like some too! I'm not sure about Lady Aglaea, but I'm sure she wouldn't turn down a princely pastry, wouldn't you agree?"

What about you, Mydei almost asks, but doesn't. Phainon just keeps smiling that small little smile he shows to everyone. The one where he closes his eyes, so nobody can tell that he doesn't truly mean it.

The tarts are a hit with the other Heirs, but in Mydei's mouth, they taste simply of ash and blood.

Phainon doesn't eat a single one.

*

Hephaestion kisses him for the first time after a battle. Their victory was assured, but still hard won. His body is marred by several lacerations, but they hardly matter—he is undying, and he heals quickly. He wishes to say that Hephaestion kissing him had come as a surprise, but it didn't really—the man has always sat close to him, their hands almost always barely brushing against each other. Mydeimos never minded, and he is not opposed but... he didn't believe his friend would act upon it. Mydeimos himself would've been content to remain as they have been.

"Hephaestion..."

"You want this too, don't you, Mydeimos?"

His friend had stayed safe, and he had slain many enemies. Mydeimos had always been proud to stand next him, but kissing—it had never crossed his mind, if he wants to be honest. Again, he doesn't mind, but... he's unsure. Could he really act upon his own desires?

"It's alright if you do, you know?"

Hephaestion's hand is gentle on Mydeimos' chest and he wonders. Maybe it really is. After all, he *is* in exile, so he's just another warrior, isn't he? It doesn't matter that the entire detachment follows his lead. He has friends. He has a teacher. He could have a relationship, too. He knows that same-sex mingling is frowned upon in a few city states, but Kremnos has never cared much for it, and Mydeimos hardly cares, either.

So, he softly cups Hephaestion's face in his hands and kisses him. Dead bodies of enemy soldiers and titankin surround them, they are both smeared in blood, and still this kiss is the gentlest thing Mydeimos has ever known.

He and Hephaestion have often shared a tent before. He, initially, hadn't wanted a tent at all, being used to the outside, but all his friends have insisted and he simply gave in. *Royal treatment*, they had joked with laughter in their hearts and Mydeimos couldn't find it in himself to be upset about it—they were joking *with* him, and it had meant the world. He was no

longer alone, and people cared enough about him as a person that they would joke on his behalf.

“We don’t have to,” Hephaestion says, leaning back after having kissed Mydeimos for the last five minutes. His hand rests comfortably on Hephaestion’s waist and he just looks at him. He knows where this is going. It’s simply...

“I’ve never done this before,” he admits. He has heard other men speak of this act in shame in camp before, particularly if they had not done it themselves yet. Personally, he’s not sure what the fuss is about. After all, a young warrior does not shame himself for not landing a killing blow, do they? He’s not sure, he was born killing.

“We can go slow,” Hephaestion offers, “only with what you’re comfortable with.”

“What do you want?”

Hephaestion laughs. “I don’t really want slow, but—I’m flexible. Have you touched yourself, Mydeimos?”

He tilts his head. Yes, of course he has. Doesn’t everyone touch themselves at some point? It’s only natural to wring your hands, or scratch your neck, isn’t it? He finds it hard to imagine a world where you would never touch your own skin.

“I mean,” Hephaestion chuckles, placing his hand on Mydeimos’ groin, “down there.”

“Yes,” Mydeimos replies without hesitation, “for urination.”

Hephaestion blinks and then leans his head forward, laughing. “Oh, Mydeimos, what a king you’ll be. I’ll never tire of your Kremnos, I already know.”

He is confused. What else could Hephaestion possibly mean?

“For pleasure,” his friend then specifies, “or have you never had the urge?”

He thinks. There have been times where his pants had pitched and he had felt weirdly uncomfortable. Usually it would go away on its own after a while, so he'd just wait it out. Perhaps this is what Hephaestion means?

"No," he admits, "I think I know what you mean, but I have never—touched it. Am I supposed to?"

Hephaestion smiles and nods. "That's alright," he says, "do you want to try?"

He's not sure. He nods anyway. If it's Hephaestion, then he can trust whatever he wants to do. The man is his closest friend, his most steadfast ally in battle. Nobody could ever take that spot away from him; and Mydeimos wouldn't want anyone to, either. Hephaestion nods and gently undoes the fittings of Mydeimos' pants and reveals the soft cock lying between his legs. Mydeimos has never thought much about it; neither size nor girth, but he knows other men do—Leonnius in particular likes to boast, and it's usually Hephaestion that calls bullshit on him. Hephaestion gently blows on his own hands and upon seeing Mydeimos' questioning gaze, he smiles: "To get them warm. It's not pleasant with cold fingers, you know?"

With warm fingers now, Hephaestion gently wraps his fingers around Mydeimos' length. It feels weird, having someone else touch it. It's not unpleasant, because it's Hephaestion, but it's strange nonetheless.

"I'm actually not very good at this," Hephaestion laughs, "so please let me know if you don't enjoy something."

"It's," Mydeimos replies, "strange. But I do not dislike it."

Hephaestion squeezes his hands and starts rubbing Mydeimos' dick. He watches and he feels... something hot pools in his belly and he can see his dick hardening. It's not an unfamiliar feeling, but he isn't used to it either. It doesn't feel bad, and he's not sure *how* it feels. His breathing is starting to become laboured and he involuntarily rocks his hips back and forth. He tries to keep his eyes open, but they keep falling shut. He wants... he wants *something,* but he doesn't know what it is.

“Hephaestion,” he breathes, but no sentence follows.

“I know,” his friend soothes him, “just let go, Mydeimos. Don’t be ashamed.”

Mydeimos closes his eyes and tips his head back, biting his lip. He’s not too sure what Hephaestion means with *let go* but he trusts his friend more than anything. His breathing comes hard and this strange heat is coiling tight in his groin. Maybe... he could let it go? He stops trying to hold it back and focuses on Hephaestion’s deft fingers stroking him and he groans deep when he feels his dick twitch; and the tight coil inside finally unfurls itself.

He opens his eyes to the ceiling of the tent and he breathes quickly, exhausted even though he moved not a muscle.

“How do you feel?”

Mydeimos blinks and pushes out a long breath. Collecting himself for a brief moment, he swallows and turns his head towards Hephaestion. He’s still slightly out of breath, and maybe that’s a little concerning. However, he doesn’t feel bad. It’s a little like the smallest training he’s ever done. He can feel his heart calm down again already.

“It was... weird. I can’t describe it properly, but I didn’t... I didn’t dislike it.”

Hephaestion laughs and nods. “That’s good, then. As I said, I’m not very skilled at this. But if you liked it, we can train together.”

Mydeimos stares at him a moment. “You do not do this to yourself? From the way you spoke before, I thought it is possible?”

Hephaestion stammers a little, which is unusual. He wipes his hand on some nearby cloth and he looks oddly uncomfortable. Did Mydeimos say something wrong?

“...yes it is, but I am... lacking the ability.”

Now Mydeimos is even more confused. “You seemed knowledgeable about it before. Does it not apply to yourself?”

Hephaestion lets out a big breath, then he turns to Mydeimos, smiling.

“I... how about I show you? It’s hard to say.”

Mydeimos nods, and crosses his arms in waiting. Hephaestion gestures to him to close his eyes, so Mydeimos does. To be honest, he doesn’t quite get the fuss. If something is wrong, Hephaestion should just say so. Mydeimos will not think less of him, no matter what. He hears the rustling of clothes, and he supposes that Hephaestion undresses. Hm. Come to think of it, the man has never bathed with them. Mydeimos believed his illness might be the reason, but what if it is something different?

“Open your eyes, Mydeimos.”

His voice sounds unsure, timid almost. Mydeimos opens his eyes and looks at Hephaestion. As he suspected, the man sits before him bared and he feels his eyes wander. It’s the friend he knows. His body bears the scars of their battles, and it is the body he knows best. On his chest, his breast has a subtle swell to them; and between his legs sits a soft mound. He drags his eyes upwards again, meeting Hephaestion’s gaze. The man looks uncertain.

“I see,” Mydeimos replies. It makes sense. How would he bring pleasure to himself like he brought to Mydeimos if he lacks the necessary parts for it?

“So you do,” Hephaestion says, still quiet, “do you think less of me now?”

Mydeimos frowns, not understanding. He shakes his head.

“You are my brother; my comrade in arms, Hephaestion. On this world and the next, there is no one I trust more than you. I do not know what reaction you wish from me, but you will always be the Hephaestion I know. Although I understand now why you refuse to bathe with us. Leonnius can be grating to listen to. I always envied that you were able to escape the telling of his escapades.”

Hephaestion blinks, and then he laughs. “Only you, Mydeimos,” he says, scolding, “only you ever could.”

Mydeimos tilts his head. He doesn’t understand. If Hephaestion wants something in particular, he should just say it. He can’t read minds, after all. His friend comes closer now, ghosting his fingers over Mydeimos’ skin. He comes to cup Mydeimos’ cheek and he kisses him again. Mydeimos closes his eyes and embraces Hephaestion, and he slowly leans back, lying down on his bedding. They do not part; and they spend the night in a tight embrace.

Mydeimos sleeps, and hopes that he will never have to let Hephaestion go.

“Mydeimos, go be king... and lead our people home.”

*

“Watch your left,” he says as he oversees the training ground. Some of the younger warriors have sheepishly requested a training session, but Mydei quickly realised that his fighting style wasn’t going to help them. And so, since Phainon is everywhere, he stepped in. The young warriors win if they manage to land a hit on Phainon—at which they had scoffed, initially, but now, two hours in, they are starting to regret it. Phainon hasn’t even started to sweat yet, and the grip on his sword is still somewhat loose.

“Deliverer,” he calls and Phainon looks over, smiling, like they were meeting at the market. The warriors clearly see this as their chance and they move to seize it, but Phainon is faster—with just a brief glance, he grabs one guy’s wrist and uses him as a makeshift weapon, throwing him into his friends behind him. There *is* a reason Mydei chose Phainon to be his sparring partner.

“Take note,” he addresses the bowled over group, “on the battlefield, even if something distracts you, never lose sight of your enemies.”

“Oh, Mydei, don’t be so hard on them! They weren’t half-bad, you know?”

“Did... did we make you sweat, Lord Phainon?”

Phainon had walked over and offered his hand to help them back up. At the question, he blinks, eyes quickly flitting around.

“Sure,” he then lies smoothly, “I’m sweating buckets. Keep at it, yeah? Never pick fights you can’t win—it’s better to retreat and fight another day, yeah? Can’t win any battles if you’re dead, we can’t all have an indestructible body like Mydei.”

“HKS,” Mydei adds when he joins them, “you’re the only person obsessed with my body.”

“Well, can you blame me? How could I not notice such a conspicuous body like yours? Besides, that Krateros keeps flaunting all your victories in my face... makes me imagine you body-slamming into a row of titankin.”

“I might have done so, yes—is Krateros bothering you?”

“Bothering me? No, no... but I don’t think he likes me very much. He keeps challenging me to a duel, but he’s an old man, and he insists on life-or-death, and I’d rather not do that to our allies, you know?”

Mydei groans. Stupid old man, thinking that only a Kremnoan could be *worthy* of Mydei’s affection... he’ll have to confront the man about it. But not now. Preferably, not ever, honestly. He grabs Phainon’s hand, intertwining their fingers because he’s a sap, and he starts pulling the man forward. It’s way past lunch time and Phainon had left this morning before Mydei even woke up, so he *knows* the man is running on empty air and prayers.

But first, he pulls the man into a secluded alcove to kiss him.

“Oh... to what do I owe *that*?”

“You did good,” Mydei breathes against Phainon’s parted lips, “in the fight. Wish I could’ve been the one to fight you instead.”

Phainon laughs when they part again. “Oh, if you had... we would’ve ended behind the weapon’s rack again, wouldn’t we?”

“Hmm... don’t pretend you wouldn’t have enjoyed that.”

Phainon laughs again, placing his hands on Mydei’s shoulders as he starts pressing small kisses to Phainon’s throat. They have had sex on the training grounds before. To be fair to themselves, it had been after an impromptu training session deep into the night because Phainon had bad nightmares that day and wouldn’t open his mouth about it; and Mydei couldn’t just keep sleeping next to a tossing and turning Phainon. When Mydei sleeps, he *doesn’t* move. His late friends jokingly told him that he slept like he was dead, and he’s kept that attitude. So, naturally, the best course of action had been to sneak out at night, bash their heads in, and then accidentally fuck each other’s brains out—as one does, obviously.

Phainon’s stomach grumbles and Mydei suppresses a chuckle against Phainon’s clavicle.

“Let me buy you lunch, Deliverer.”

Phainon pouts, but doesn’t object when Mydei pulls him alongside him. He wisely avoids the antique shop, because Phainon forgets all his bodily needs when there’s a new ancient vase on display.

They are lounging on the sofa, and Mydei is nervous. Castorice and Hyacine will come by today for the video night, and while Mydei organised enough drinks for everyone, he couldn’t stock up on quite enough food, so he had to bother the girls to bring some as well. He offered to pay, but he got harshly refused. Phainon still is none the wiser; and currently the guy is sprawled over Mydei’s lap, looking at the Weave, or his various antique forums—Mydei hasn’t really ever bothered to ask. His fingers are idly rubbing at the Deliverer’s neck, playing with the hairs there. If he continues like this for just a little longer, chances are good that Phainon will fall asleep like this. Mydei is checking the clock, and the girls should arrive soon.

“You should choke me,” the insanity of a boyfriend then says out of nowhere, like saying it’s nice out.

“...what.”

“In bed. You should try it. I think I might like it.”

Phainon doesn’t move. He doesn’t turn, he doesn’t lift his head, and he keeps scrolling on his teleslate like nothing’s happened. Mydei’s fingers stop moving and he stares down at the man in shock. After all this time, he keeps thinking he’s seen it all. Clearly, he’s wrong.

“You. You just had a panic attack yesterday, where you almost choked to death and *now* you want me to choke you?”

“Yeah,” Phainon easily agrees, like that’s a normal thing to say. “It was just scary because it came so suddenly. I’m usually better with my panic attacks, so I thought if it were you, it might be sexy.”

“You’re taking me into an early grave, Deliverer. But yeah sure fine, let’s try it, what could possibly go wrong?”

Phainon wiggles in his lap happily. What the fuck even is his life. He needs to stop his enabler-ism. This is getting out of hand. He knows he’ll fail. But he’s had determination, at least.

There’s a knock on the door and Phainon sits up slightly. He frowns, looking at Mydei.

“Am I expecting something? Aglaea would’ve messaged me before coming over to scold me, right?”

“Why don’t you check,” Mydei suggests, hoping he’s not stiff as a board. Phainon’s frown deepens, but then he shrugs and gets up, moving to the door. Mydei lets out a silent breath, and then he follows closely behind Phainon. The Deliverer notices and shoos him to the side, but Mydei just stands there, crossing his arms. He’s kissed Phainon in public *twice*, and he will probably do it again. There’s only so many times people can’t notice.

Chartonus even mentioned it—asking if there's any jewellery Mydei would like for Phainon. Rings are a little unhandy for warriors, but Mydei has been thinking about it. He has no second thoughts, but—he's been thinking about it. He imagines that Phainon would say Yes. He would, wouldn't he?

"Miss Castorice! Miss Hyacine! What are... what's that?"

"Food!" Hyacine helpfully supplies, shoving the bag they brought into Phainon's arms. Then she takes initiative and pushes her way in, Castorice following closely behind her, closing the door. Phainon, perplexed, stares at the bag in his arms.

"Huh? I have... I have food. I promise! You can check the pantry..."

Helplessly, he looks to Mydei who just smirks.

"Castorice, Hyacine," he addresses them, "I'm glad you could come."

"No, no," Castorice says, "thank you for inviting us."

"Huh? Inviting you? For what? This isn't an intervention, is it? I've been good, haven't I? Oh, and Mydei is here because, uh... wait, Mydei, why did you invite them to *my* house without asking me first?!"

He shrugs. "Do you object?"

"Well, no, but..."

"Then it's settled. I invited them for a video night. If it opposes you, Deliverer, my house is currently empty."

Phainon almost starts to speak, but then decides to pout instead. "Asshole," he mutters under his breath as he shuffles into the kitchen. Mydei directs the girl to the sofa and tells them to get comfortable, as he follows Phainon into the kitchen. He's placed the bag on the counter and rummages through it, inspecting its contents. Mydei comes up behind him and places a kiss on his neck.

"Don't pout, Deliverer, it's unbecoming of you."

“Hmpf,” Phainon responds, debate-style, “you could’ve warned me. If Castorice tells Aglaea how I dress at home, she’ll have my head.”

“You look fine.”

“They’re *your* clothes, of course I look fine.”

He sighs and leans back into Mydei. “I guess it’s nice,” he concludes then, “you must’ve been pretty lonely while we were at the Grove, huh? But video night... did you pick any?”

“No, the girls did. Help me with the food, and we can spend a nice evening together.”

Sighing loudly, and protesting a pretty token, Phainon does.

The videos the girls brought were of a variety. Mydei has been expecting some romcoms, and he hasn’t been disappointed, but Hyacine also brought a lot of horror videos with her which is... odd, giving how she and Phainon cling together in fear and terror the entire time. At some point they even hide under a blanket until Castorice tells them it’s safe to come out. Children, the lot of them, really. Mydeimos is the only responsible adult he knows. How this group achieves anything is beyond him.

“Mydei did you see?! The monster had *two* mouths!”

“Yes, Deliverer, I did see, I wasn’t hiding under a blanket.”

“Cassie, those spiders-creatures were so scary...”

“Why did you pick the video then, Hyacine?”

At some point, Ica and Phainon fell asleep. The little unicorn is snoring impressively on Hyacine’s lap, while Phainon is putting in work for tomorrow’s neck pain on Mydei’s shoulder. Deciding to not wanting to deal with that, he man-handles the Deliverer into his lap and wraps him in a blanket.

“I had fun,” Castorice says, “I wish we would do this more often.”

“I don’t see why not?” Hyacine replies, gently petting her unicorn. “Maybe next time we can go to your house, Cassie. You could show Lord Phainon and Lord Mydei all the plushies you’ve been sewing!”

Castorice blushes and she quickly hides her face in her hands.

“I’m sure the Deliverer would be delighted,” Mydei reassures her, “and I’m sure since they were made by you that their quality is pristine.”

She slowly peeks at him behind her fingers, face still flushed. “I—If Lord Mydei think so, then maybe it would be alright... I’d be happy to. Maybe we could invite Lady Aglaea and the triplets too, next time?”

“That’s a great idea!” Hyacine supplies. “We could all use a break. Speaking of—Lord Phainon is alright, isn’t he? I’m so unused to seeing him sleep so early... normally I have to scold him to go to sleep in time.”

“Yes,” Mydei tells her, even though he thinks *alright* is maybe a tad too far, but Phainon hates worrying her. “He simply didn’t sleep well last night, that’s all. He’ll probably wake up again later—if I’m lucky, he’ll spare me.”

“I’ve been meaning to ask,” Hyacine continues, “are you two officially together now? On our way to the Grove, Lord Phainon couldn’t help himself but curse your existence and lament your absence in the same breath.”

Mydeimos doesn’t blush. He is a warrior, he is battle-hardened, and he has quite literally conquered death. He stands tall and victorious over every encounter. He is Mydeimos the Undying, the Son of Gorgo, and the last king of Castrum Kremnos.

“I love him,” he mumbles into Phainon’s soft hair, “but he has not said it back.”

“Aww,” Hyacine coos, “don’t worry, Lord Mydei! He talks about you all the time! Even Professor Anaxa started to complain about the frequency!”

Mydei tries to hide behind Phainon's head, who remains blissfully asleep.

"She's right, Lord Mydei," Castorice pipes in, "Lord Phainon is so much happier around you."

"You've known him for a long time," he says and Castorice nods. "Aglaea… told me of his arrival."

"Oh," Castorice replies, blinking. "Lady Aglaea regrets her behavior dearly. Lord Phainon has always been a delight on the city—and on me, too. He's always going to be my first real friend."

"And now you have so many more!" Hyacine laughs. "Me, Lord Mydei, Professor Anaxa… your list keeps growing, Cassie!"

Castorice laughs, nodding in agreement. "Ah, maybe we should go. Since Lord Phainon is asleep—and it is rather late. Lord Mydei, why don't you bring Lord Phainon to bed, and me and Hyacine start cleaning up?"

"You don't have to," Mydei replies, gathering Phainon in his arms. "I can do it later."

"Nonsense!" Hyacine argues. "We'll help, so we're done faster. Don't worry, Lord Mydei, we'll be the fastest cleaners in all of Amphoreus!"

Mydei just nods and stands up, Phainon safely bundled up in his arms. The man moves his head a little, but doesn't wake up. Carefully, Mydei carries him into the bedroom and places him on the bed. He considers briefly about undressing him but then he decides against it, going to help the girls clean instead. With the three of them, it is done quickly, and he bids them farewell. Hyacine tells him that he and Phainon should pick out videos for the next time and that they'll convene about the time later. Mydei nods, already thinking about what videos might be appropriate.

He closes and locks the door—a habit Phainon never really picked up properly. He leaves the house unlocked all day sometimes, as if he hadn't amassed so many antiques that he holds so dear. Honestly, if someone were to rob him, it'd be the easiest heist in the world.

“Mydei,” comes Phainon’s voice from the bed and Mydei hurries over. His voice is sleepy, and he must’ve just stirred from some noise.

“I’m here, Deliverer. Hush, just go back to sleep. Castorice and Hyacine have left already, it’s late. Do you need anything?”

Phainon pulls a face. He takes Mydei’s arm in his hand, trying to pull him into bed.

“In a moment, you glutton. Let me undress first.”

Phainon pulls a deeper face. “No… I don’t want sex tonight. Just come.”

Mydei rolls his eyes. “Not for *that*, HKS. I’m getting comfortable, is all.”

“Oh… okay then. Hurry.”

Hit him with a bat. Shut him up. Sometimes Mydei indulges in fantasies like that. But nonetheless, he undresses and quickly washes down before joining Phainon, who has almost drifted off again.

“Move, HKS, I need some space.”

“Your body is too huge,” Phainon mumbles. “You’re huge.”

Titans preserve him. This man will give him grey hair. Maybe that’s why the Deliverer was born with white hair. It foresaw the future and preemptively decided to give up. Honestly, he can’t fault its decision.

“HKS, we’re basically the same size. Stop hogging the bed.”

So he shoves the Deliverer a little, so he can fit on the bed too. It’s his bed, too, even though it’s not technically, but the lion does not concern himself with technicalities.

“Mydei,” he gets woken up—hours or minutes later. His hand is empty and for a moment, he is glad.

“What? Are you hungry?”

“No, I’ve… I’ve been thinking about tomorrow.”

Mydei huffs. “We can spar, if you want. It’s been a while. The children have also asked after you.”

“Oh yeah? That’s nice… but not that tomorrow. I meant—I meant *tomorrow*. You know, there are basically no records of those that came before us. So… what purpose does tomorrow serve, if it will simply end just like today? What if—what if *deliverance* is a lie?”

Mydei is not the right person to talk to about this. He has his own problems with the flame-chase, but all his problems center entirely around Strife and the connections it has with his people. Tomorrow, in his head, has never been his problem to fix—all he can do is make sure that it has a chance to exist.

“I’ve been dreaming again,” Phainon continues and Mydei realizes that he might not need to answer, after all. “I’ve been dreaming of carrying a boulder atop a mountain, larger than the sky, but… just as I almost reach the top, just as dawn—*tomorrow*—is about to break, the boulder falls, and rolls all the way down, and I’m left with no choice but to make the trip all over again.”

“Why must you carry the boulder at all?”

“I… I don’t know, but I *must*. I’m sure if I told Lady Tribbie, she would probably say it’s my insecurities about world-bearing… you know, a long time ago, Cyrene—Cyrene read my future and essentially she’s said she wished I didn’t have to exist. But… but anyway, that dream *isn’t* that. It’s not about my duties or about being Deliverer, it’s… that boulder, it doesn’t feel like me. Have you ever watched yourself in a dream? Like, the person looks and acts just like you would, but you just *know* it’s not you? It reminds me of that dream where I kill myself. He is I and I am him, and what does the distinction really matter in the end? I walk away, and he is dead. I die, and he lives. But it *does* matter, because—it’s the same, but it’s different. Who dies matters, and it matters who walks away, even if it’s the same person.”

“The person who walks away,” Mydei asks quietly, “would you trust him?”

Phainon is quiet for a long time. Mydei almost believes he won’t answer anymore, so he is on the cusp of falling asleep again.

“I don’t know,” Phainon admits. “But I would always choose to kill him. And he will always choose to carry the boulder.”

Mydei falls to slumber. He doesn’t hear the rest.

“If the boulder is a lie, then the mountain simply has to burn.”

Chapter 7: the gentle night

Chapter Notes

> ...yeah I pushed the chapter number again, sue me. I was like "yo this chapter is getting kinda long actually"
> Be warned: this is just smut. There's like 200 words of set-up for the next chapter in there.
>
> Word tells me this is 5k but somehow I don't believe it.
>
> I need to start on myphaifest... I need to lock in.... aahhh...

“Nnn…!”

“Shh,” Mydei replies, pushing his fingers in deeper. “You don’t want anyone to catch us, do you?”

“Mmmh!”

The alley is way off the beaten path, and it leads nowhere. It hardly serves as a shortcut to *anywhere* and frankly, Mydei wonders what city planner laid this city out. Well, maybe the alley leads in the direction of the sewers, but who’d want to go there, anyway? So, in short, it’s the perfect place for some public indecency.

He and Phainon had just recently returned from a mission—originally Mydei had been supposed to go alone, but he had asked Aglaea to send Phainon along: the man had been doing badly the days prior, and Mydei had been uneasy with leaving him. Now, after coming back, Phainon’s mental state seems to be back to the usual stable levels of instability, and that’s got to be good enough.

“Doing good, Deliverer, you think you can take a little more?”

It’s fruitless to ask, really, with Mydei’s fingers deep inside Phainon’s mouth, pressing down his tongue. Phainon is pressed chest-first against the

wall, and he is *utterly* exposed. His little pink nipples are standing firm, and the arch in his back really highlights the rounding of his backside. His cock is twitching uselessly between his legs, leaking onto the ground beneath them, just always narrowly missing Phainon's shoes. Mydei is standing behind him, fully clothed, and he is slowly pushing their new rigged dildo inside of Phainon's hole. It's the biggest one they own yet, and Phainon had been excited to try it out.

"One day," Mydei whispers close to the shell of Phainon's ear, "I'm going to fuck you while there's still a dildo inside of you."

Phainon reacts immediately with a needy whimper and a thrust of his hips. Mydei swallows hard and breathes hot air into Phainon's ear. Mydei bites his lip to hold back because that was *not* quite the reaction he's been expecting. But that's good to know.

"Oh?" He says, hoping to sound raunchy. "Good to know what you think about it."

Phainon just shakes his head, blushing fervently and he bucks his hips back into the dildo Mydei is lazily moving in circles. To be honest, Mydei had never thought about doing that before. How does one even go on about this…? Something small, of course. Maybe they start with the smallest dildo they have? And of course, he's going to prep Phainon for so long that the Deliverer will start whining; and then some.

He presses the dildo a little further in. The plan is to fuck Phainon silly with it, and then make him wear it for the rest of the day. That's not too tall of an order; the day is almost over anyway, with the last big thing being dinner. Now, normally Mydei would cook whatever slop Phainon deserves to eat that day, but due to these… *special* circumstances, he's decided that they will go out. Hmm, maybe he should change his plans and edge Phainon instead…? Mydei gives in way too easily, so maybe teaching Phainon some restraint would be a worthwhile thing to spend his time on.

Phainon's legs are quivering and Mydei can tell he's holding himself back from moving. He's almost proud, but that's just borderline etiquette now, is it?

“Good boy,” he purrs, if only to hear Phainon whine around his fingers. “Hold yourself back for me, will you? You get relief when *I* tell you.”

Phainon moans in protest and shakes his head, but changes it to nodding real quick when Mydei starts pulling the dildo out. Smirking, Mydei starts pushing it back in, one tiny inch at a time until he meets resistance. Hmm, there’s still a little bit to go… he wiggles the base a little, having Phainon sob pathetically until the dildo bottoms out. Phainon’s entire body shakes, trying to adjust to the size. To be honest, Mydei is almost jealous of that thing. Gently, he drapes himself over Phainon’s back, using his now free hand to roam over his upper thigh to then rest on his belly.

“Can you feel it?” He asks. “All the way inside?”

Phainon whimpers, nodding fervently. His breathing is labored and he turns his head a little, trying to look at Mydei. He can’t completely, because Mydei uses his fingers to pull his face back. Phainon is so pretty like this, and he barely even did anything. He presses his hand a little together against Phainon’s stomach, overcome with a sudden wave of possessiveness. The mere thought of *anyone* seeing Phainon like this makes him seethe with rage.

Taking a deep breath, he forcefully calms himself down. He presses a soft kiss to the back of Phainon’s neck, and then he removes his fingers and straightens himself again. Phainon turns back at him, quizzically, and Mydei helps him dress—maybe *help* is a big word, as Phainon contributes no effort whatsoever.

“What,” Phainon pants, “that’s it?”

“Yes,” Mydei replies, “I’m famished. I know you skipped lunch, so how about we catch early dinner? I’ll give you desert if you stay good, how’s that sound?”

“Are you *insane*?” Phainon whisper-shrieks. “I can’t *walk* around with that thing, it’s re-arranging my guts as we *speak*.”

Mydei shrugs. “Then take it out, Deliverer. Were you not the one that wanted to do this today?”

Phainon blushes deeply and Mydei knows Phainon is just putting up a token resistance.

“Fine. *Fine*. But if anything—happens, I’m going to blame you.”

“If you stay good, nothing *will* happen, Deliverer. I’ll buy you your favourite off the menu, too.”

“Why would you pay?” They start walking, and they’re walking slowly. Phainon is moving stiffly, but Mydei is sure that it’ll go smoother after a couple of steps—Phainon has always been quick to adapt to things. Mydei is also watching out for any signs of genuine discomfort—Nikador knows Phainon would never just *tell* him. But all seems fine so far.

“Deliverer, I know you just bought two more antiques yesterday. And you spent all day in the Garden of Life, feeding the Chimeras. Unless you intend to pay with air and good-will, you’re penniless.”

Phainon pouts and crosses his arms defiantly. The Deliverer is the worst man when it comes to money. He usually has not two coins to rub against each other and so he either puts things on Aglaea’s ever-growing tab or he’ll make puppy-eyes at Mydei. Even Aglaea’s attempts of giving him pocket change like a child had not helped. They must not have had money in Aedes Elysiae, Mydei thinks, but then they must’ve been really cut-off from the world. How would they have traded anything, if money was a foreign concept? And it’s not like Phainon doesn’t *know* what money is, he’s just... terrible at keeping it on him.

The restaurant Mydei takes them to is a place he knows Phainon likes, and even he himself is partial to it. He’s heard people refer to it as a hole in the wall and even though he doesn’t entirely understand the meaning of it, it feels correct. He’s not stupid enough to ask Phainon for an explanation, either.

They take a table in the corner, and Mydei settles into the nook while he gestures Phainon to sit next to him. The Deliverer eyes the chair on the other side, frowning a little, but then he shrugs and slides onto the bench next to Mydei. Phainon *does* sit down somewhat stiffly, but unless you're Mydeimos, it's unnoticeable. Mydei *knew* that Phainon could do this. How does it feel, he wonders? How deep is it pressing inside? How long until Phainon will subconsciously start rutting his hips?

Phainon grabs one of the menus and folds it open dramatically, holding it in front of his face. Mydei barely glances at it. Phainon points at several things that he will have ordered, and Mydei just silently agrees with him on everything. Titans know they will be full of sugar; and he'll need to re-arrange his diet again for the next month. Phainon even demands sugary drinks, and Mydei's teeth hurt already. This must be punishment, but what does one not do for love?

"Lord Phainon!"

Both of them look up from where Phainon discussed the meal by himself and they see Zacharias approach. Mydei's eyes twitch immediately. He hasn't seen the man since the festival, and had honestly expected that he had simply ceased to be. Why is he *here*?

"Oh, Zacharias! Long time no see! How, uh, how are things?"

Mydei sneaks his hand around Phainon's waist rather possessively—which is dumb, because Zacharias can't even *see*. It takes everything in him to not growl when the man sits down on the empty chair before them.

"They have been fair, Lord Phainon. I wanted to thank you for all you've done in the festival again, Lord Phainon! It's good to know that we can still find enjoyment in a world full of strife, such as ours. Oh, there has been some dispute in-between some of the refugees, but it was so minor, I tried taking care of it myself. I hope I didn't make it worse, but it truly was such a trivial matter that I felt wrong to bring it to your attention... You have much more important things to tend to, Lord Phainon! I hope I did you proud...?"

“Ah... uh, yes, yes, of course! Haha! Thank, uh, thank you so much, that’s really, uh, nice of, uh, of you!”

Phainon laughs, rubbing his neck as he does so. While Zacharias had been talking, Mydei had taken initiative and casually slipped his hand beneath Phainon’s waistband. This hadn’t been something he ever considered doing, but seeing how easily Phainon shifted his attention on Zacharias... well, nobody’s perfect, now are they?

Mydei slides his fingers over Phainon’s smooth skin, until he hooks his hand under Phainon’s ass, pressing two fingers onto the base of the dildo nestled within. He’s not going to fuck Phainon right here, even though he’s tempted, just to stake a claim, but he is restraint himself. However, he can have a little fun, no? After all, it would not do well if his Deliverer forgot the large dildo pressing against his insides. So he slowly moves his fingers, gently jostling the toy from side to side. He watches Phainon’s blush creep past his neck greedily and he wants to *bite;* to mark him for the world to see.

“Anyway,” Zacharias says, “do you have plans for the upcoming holiday? I know a lot of vendors are planning special sales for the occasion.”

“Oh, oh, ah, ahem, they, they do? I hadn’t, eh, I hadn’t heard! Ha! I, I mean, haha... I must’ve, must’ve been busy, I, ah, I guess, ha... ha... y—you have plans?”

“Well, nothing concrete yet, if I’m honest. Beside yourself, Lord Phainon, I’ve been struggling to befriend a great many people. So, if you wouldn’t mind, I wanted to inquire whether or not you’d be interested in perusing the stalls with me? My treat, of course!”

How bold. Normally, Mydei might call this behaviour brave, but in this case it’s just stupid. Mydei carefully holds the base a little firmer and instead of simply moving it from side to side, he pushes it in and out minutely, but at a rapid pace. Beneath the table, Phainon is pressing his thighs together in a desperate attempt to retain his dignity. Mydei wants to bend him over the table and fuck into him, in front of everyone here, and straight into Zacharias’ face.

“O-oh, ah, I, ehm, I don’t, uhm, I don’t know yet! A-Aglaea might, ha, s-send me ou-haa-out o-on a mission-ooh!”

Mydei’s breath hitches, watching as Phainon comes undone right here. He hadn’t—he hadn’t even entertained that possibility.

“Lord Phainon?! Are you alright? Your face is all flushed, are you coming down with a fever?!”

Phainon’s eyes are pressed shut and he breathes heavily and it’s only thanks to Mydei’s immense restraint that he doesn’t pounce on his man right here and now.

“Uh... aah... uh, e-excuse us! Goodbye!”

Phainon forcefully grabs Mydei’s hand and rushes to stand up, pulling Mydei behind him. He goes willingly, eyes fixated on the back of Phainon’s head. The Deliverer takes them inside the restaurant proper, straight into the bathroom stalls, and he essentially throws Mydei into one of the stalls, slamming and locking the door behind him.

“What,” he pants, moaning, “are you doing to me?!”

“You came,” Mydei responds, taking a hold of his arms, “you *orgasmed* in front of all these people.”

Phainon growls and hits his fists against Mydei’s collarbone in rage. His face is flushed, and his eyes glow with fury. Mydeimos has seldom felt more possessive in his life.

“I hate you,” Phainon snarls, “put your dick in me *right this instant*.”

Mydei forcefully grabs Phainon’s nape and presses him into a messy kiss, devouring his mouth, biting his lips and tongue until he can taste the copper of blood on his tongue. Phainon responds in aggression, pressing his blunt fingertips into Mydei’s neck, trying to choke him out. In response, Mydei simply hums in revelry. His fingers fumble downwards, initially trying to open the Deliverer’s pants, but after failing once, he decides to just rip them

open and he wraps his hand around the man’s half-hard length, squeezing it tight. It twitches under his touch and Phainon shudders. Mydei doesn’t move his hand, he simply changes the pressure of his hold until Phainon growls and slaps him across the face.

“What,” he growls deep from his chest, “about *right now* did you misunderstand?”

Mydei bites his lips as he relishes in the sting of his flesh. It’s hardly a wonder most of their spars end in wild coupling—honestly; maybe they should start thinking about that. There’s only so many times they can get away with fucking on the training grounds.

“If I remember correctly,” he quips back, “you’re currently stuffed full.”

Phainon seethes and Mydei feels himself warm up. He loves pressing Phainon into their bed, make him whimper and force him to submit, but this—this is what he’s *really* after. A Phainon that simply *takes* what he wants and Nikador be his witness, Mydei will let him, every single time.

Phainon grabs him by the shoulders and slams him down on the toilet, straddling his hips immediately. His fingertips dig into the flesh of Mydei’s shoulders, but honestly, he can barely feel it. Phainon should bite him. He should jam his teeth straight into his jugular, show the world who they belong to.

Roughly, Phainon shimmies Mydei’s cock out of his pants and reaches behind him, yanking the dildo out of himself in one movement. He closes his eyes, moaning and his body shakes as he has to adjust to the sudden emptiness inside of him. Fervently, he presses the toy into Mydei’s hands and lifts himself up a little, lining up, and then he sinks down on Mydei’s lap in one fell swoop.

Mydei clutches the dildo tight in his hand, and his other finds Phainon’s hips easily, squeezing hard. Being inside Phainon simply feels too good every single time it happens. The way he pulses, the way he draws Mydei ever deeper, the way he clenches down.

“Ah,” Phainon moans loudly, a rolling sound in his throat. “Feel so good in me... you fucking ass.”

Mydei doesn’t chuckle, even though he’s tempted. He squeezes Phainon’s hip a little harder, urging him to move. The Deliverer complies, but he only moves around a little bit—hardly enough to satisfy either of them.

“Deliverer,” Mydei growls in warning.

“Shush,” Phainon replies, “Zacharias might still wait for me.”

Mydei’s hand rushes forward to wrap around Phainon’s neck, squeezing. He *knows* the fucker does it on purpose, and yet... and *yet*—! Mydei can’t help it. He’s feeding straight into Phainon, but what is he *supposed to do*? The thought alone... of Zacharias in *his* spot? No. No, he needs to rein himself in, lest he does something he might come to regret later.

“What?” Phainon teases, even though he wheezes. “Getting possessive?”

“*Yes*,” Mydei replies, pulling Phainon closer. Phainon simply chuckles, as much as he is able to. Then, he starts moving in earnest, rolling his hips and Mydei groans. He had planned—somewhat—to tease Phainon, make him come in the alleyway, and then fuck him silly at home. He had certainly not planned to pound into Phainon in a bathroom stall, where anyone could walk in on them at any moment. And yet, somehow... it feels good. Phainon’s here. That might really be all that Mydei needs.

“Mydei,” Phainon moans loud enough for anyone with ears to listen, “fuck, *Mydei*.”

Mydei lets go of his throat and grabs the man’s nape instead, pulling him close enough to bury his nose in the crook of his neck. He can taste the sweat on the man’s skin and Mydei can’t help himself; and he bites deep into Phainon’s neck, desperate to claim him.

The Deliverer howls, throwing his arms around Mydei’s neck, rutting faster now. Mydei can feel him clench down hard, and he knows he himself isn’t far off either.

“Deliverer,” he pants into Phainon’s neck, wrapping his arms around the body, pulling him as close as he can. Phainon sobs, and his movements become erratic, frantic even. Mydei starts sucking a mark onto the flesh he’s just bitten, because he just *needs* to.

“I’m,” Phainon mewls, “I’m—I’m... *Mydei*!!”

Mydei presses Phainon tighter to himself and he can feel it—Phainon clenching down hard, intent on milking him dry. Hugging him tight, Mydei grunts as he spills himself deep inside his lover, breathing hard in the aftermath. After a couple of breaths, Phainon pushes slightly away from him, trying to catch his breath. Mydei still holds onto him, and he rakes his eyes over Phainon’s body. He’s still mostly dressed, and the pants—well. He’s no idea how Phainon will explain *that* to Aglaea, honestly, but that’s not his problem. For some reason, Mydei’s eyes linger on the Deliverer’s midriff. He places his hand on there gently, feeling the rapid breaths the man is taking. It’s stupid. It’s dumb, so very, very dumb, and yet...

“If it were possible,” he states with a raspy voice, not knowing what he’s saying, “I would.”

He waits a beat, before lifting his eyes up to meet Phainon’s. His cheeks are still flushed, and he looks down at Mydei bewildered, before he looks further down, to where Mydei’s hand rests. Realisation flashes across his face, and he gently places his own hand over Mydei’s.

“If it were possible,” Phainon murmurs softly, lifting his gaze to lock with Mydei, “I would.”

*

The next day, Phainon complains loudly about the bite mark that Mydei left wonderfully visible on his neck. He even threatens not to leave the house at

all today, but Phainon is Phainon and he'll go stir crazy if he stays cooped up indoors for too long.

He complains, but Mydei sees him all day subconsciously touch that mark, as if to make sure it was still there.

Mydei wishes it could stay. He wishes it wouldn't already be fading, gone with the following morning. He wants to sneak up behind Phainon, and embrace him from behind, hold him so tight the man would gasp for breath and he—he wants to bury his fangs deep into Phainon's sweet flesh; to devour him whole; to make sure nobody but *him* could ever have Phainon whole. He wants to rake his nails over Phainon's skin, leaving bloody trails and he wishes to bite ever deeper, tasting the blood on his tongue; feel it drip down his throat and he wants Phainon to moan, spurn him on and he wants to *consume, consume, c o n s u m e.*

"Mydei," Phainon moans that night, Mydeimos fucking into him with wild abandon and he arches his back, tilting his chest up and his nipples are ringed with bites placed at random, deep and dark. The mark on his neck is almost gone, just some pink tissue remaining and Mydei growls, furious like he's hardly known before and he rushes forward, fucking right onto that spot he knows Phainon likes, and he sinks his teeth deep into Phainon's barely-healed flesh again just as the man hollers out his fifth orgasm of the night.

"More," Phainon begs, and Mydei is still painfully hard and he rams himself into his lover again and again and he takes and takes and *takes* and Phainon gives and gives and *gives* and Mydei devours him, way past the point of exhaustion and he still, he *still* needs more, he needs *everything*.

"Yes, yes," Phainon cries, having gone soft hours ago, his orgasms being dry only now and simply pushing him over the brink of displeasure again and again and Mydei should *stop*, he's lost track of time, but he can't, he *can't*, and Phainon's blood stains the bed-sheets and he claws at Mydei's back with dull fingers, egging him on, wanting it all and Mydei *needs*.

"All of you," Mydei growls, from deep within his chest.

“All of you,” Phainon replies, voice quiet and soft, but it burns like the blazing sun.

*

“Both of us?”

“Yes. My reports on that particular area have been more than lacking and—Phainon, will you sit down?”

“No, thank you. Uh, I got, uh, ants in my boots, is all. Do please continue.”

Aglaea throws Mydei an annoyed look that he skillfully ignores. He doesn’t know what they’re on about. Phainon is an antsy guy by default, isn’t he? The man barely sits during the day.

“Very well, then. As I’ve said, I have very little reports on this place, so I want you to investigate. I can offer you no insight on what you might encounter—none other than that there seems to be a temple there. To whom it is dedicated, I do not know. You are to find out and when possible, eliminate all threats within. Tribbie will accompany you on your journey; so please keep her safe, Phainon. And you, Mydeimos, please watch out for the both of them.”

Phainon pouts, and Mydei simply nods. A temple with unknown origins? He wonders what Titan they were honouring—maybe it is Thanatos, and they can find a clue to their whereabouts.

“When do we depart?”

“Tomorrow, at the earliest light. The journey should take you about two days on a dromas’ back, but I implore you to be thorough with your investigation. Teacher will be able to keep in contact with us, and if you find any refugees, they absolutely take priority.”

“Don’t worry, Lady Aglaea, with me and Mydei there, we will face no problems! Will Okhema be alright though, with both of us gone?”

“Yes,” Aglaea answers, “Cas is still here, and myself as well. I expect nothing to happen in the near future, and you know not to underestimate our Holy City guard. We will be fine, Phainon.”

Phainon nods, kneading his fingers into the backrest of the chair he’s standing behind.

“Do you think—?”

“It’s always possible. Please keep a look-out. The situation here is under control, and out there, I will rely on you, dear child. Come back home safe, all three of you.”

They both nod, and they take their leave. Half a day for preparation isn’t a lot of time, but they are usually always ready to move out at the drop of a hat.

“What did you ask her, at the end?”

“Hm? Oh—I was wondering if it was...you know the Cleaners, right? They tend not to go after you because well... you’re undying at all... or after Miss Castorice... or Lady Aglaea... or Ladies Oracle... and Professor Anaxa and Miss Hyacine are somewhat safe at the Grove... she’s also a healer and he’s one of the seven sages... Miss Cipher is who knows where... wait, am I the most expandable one?”

“HKS, can you keep your thoughts straight for three seconds?”

“The only straight thing about me is my posture! Uh. Well, anyway. The Cleaners, eh, they have laid traps for us in the past to try and get rid of us discreetly, without being directly involved. So I was wondering—an unknown temple we’ve never heard before? That’s suspicious, so let’s be on our guard, Mydei. They don’t shy from cowardly tactics like poison and the like, so we got to make sure we watch out for Lady Tribbie.”

Mydei folds his arms and nods. He has heard of these Cleaners, but just as Phainon said, they tend not to bother him. How to eliminate someone that cannot die?

“Did they move against you?”

“Hm? Oh, yeah, lots. I got smeared, trapped, poisoned, exploded and almost just plan up assassinated. Anyway, what do we eat for dinner? Oh, what about some salad? I could bake bread, but Okhema’s wheat is so... dry, it’s a shame...”

“Hold on, they did *what*?”

“Huh? Who? Oh Mydei, are you alright? You look so constipated. Shall we spar the rest of the day? Although I’m really sore, you brute... you spar with yourself and I provide running commentary, how about that? Or I throw random stuff at you...”

“*Deliverer.*”

“What? Look, if you don’t like my suggestion, then start coughing up some of your own! I can’t be doing all the work here.”

“These Cleaners tried to *kill* you?”

“Huh? Uh... yeah? I did just say that that’s like their entire thing, right? But they obviously never got me, so what’s the big huff? So, what about dinner, now?”

Mydei isn’t going to grow old around Phainon. He can already feel the heart attack coming on. How can someone so mortal be so nonchalant about several assassination attempts? Only Phainon, only ever Phainon.

Later that evening, Mydei is sprawled over Phainon’s lap, having hiked up the man’s shirt to lazily press kisses on his stomach while Phainon taps away on his teleslate.

“Can you believe it?” He huffs, agitated. “They really think that this fake could be from Aidonia... Castorice would *die* if I showed her this... oh, and they want to have found *that* in Janusopolis? Pfft, yeah sure, I believe that in a heartbeat! Seriously, who wouldn’t be able to spot that that’s a fake? The pottery is all wrong...”

Phainon is a full-body complainer. It’s a small miracle he’s not bouncing his leg right now and he’s probably trying hard to suppress it so that he won’t disturb Mydei on his lap. Mydei appreciates it, really. He hooks his fingers into Phainon’s waistband to pull his pants down, but Phainon reaches down first, grabbing Mydei by the hair and pulling his head up.

“No.”

“Why not? You know I’m good at it.”

“I have to sit on a dromas for two days,” Phainon rolls his eyes. “I’m already sore, you know? You’ve fucked me *non-stop* for over a week, Mydeimos. Is it Kremnos fertility week or something? Usually *I* am the one insisting.”

“Can I not desire you? You always howl for more, after all.”

Mydei straightens up and sits himself on Phainon’s lap, stroking his hands over Phainon’s pecs. The man blushes prettily and averts his eyes a little.

“Well, I, it, uh—it’d be rude to say no at that point wouldn’t it? I, I mean... since it’s already in and all...”

Mydei pushes Phainon’s shirt up, exposing his chest. He presses his fingers on both of his nipples, starting to play with them. Phainon whimpers quietly in the back of his throat and he is sensitive *everywhere*. Mydei bends forward and takes Phainon’s left nipple in his mouth, gently closing his lips around it. His right hand, meanwhile, strokes down his side, resting eventually on the dip on his hip, kneading the flesh there.

“M-Mydei...”

He laps his tongue over the nipple until it stiffens in his mouth, and then he moves on to the other side, repeating the process there.

“Could you come from this?” He asks. “If I plugged you up and just sucked your nipples, could you come?”

“I hate you,” Phainon replies, “but—yes.”

Mydei’s grip tightens and he breathes out. He pushes Phainon to the side gently, so that the man lies down on the sofa, and Mydei leans above him.

“You drive me to the brink of insanity, Deliverer. Have you any idea how much I had to restrain myself to not take you right in the market square, in front of everyone?”

“Fuck off,” Phainon says, “you wouldn’t.”

“You know, in ancient Kremnos,” Mydei starts, lowering his body down so he presses Phainon into the sofa, “consummation was public. Just like a fight to the death in the arena—it was said to boost fertility and that the child would grow strong.”

It’s a total lie. Well, they *might* have done that in ancient times, but what does he know? Courting rituals had never piqued his interest back then and he’d been sure if he’d ever need them, someone would lend a helpful hand.

“Do you want to fuck me in front of your people, Mydeimos?”

The possessive side of Mydei screams No. Only *he* gets to see Phainon in the throes of passion, but another part of him gets really excited at the idea. When he reaches down to shimmy Phainon out of his pants, the man doesn’t protest this time and Mydei finds him hard and leaking already.

“They’d all see how big you are; how good you fill me. They’d hear me cry out your name and they’d see how you wouldn’t even have to touch me to get me to come undone.”

Having undone his own pants, Mydei pushes into Phainon who sucks in a harsh breath, but doesn’t protest otherwise. Mydei can feel him all around

his dick and the tight heat is flooring him every time. He starts moving slowly, pushing in inch after inch, until he is seated fully inside. Phainon doesn’t wrap his legs around him, but his heels are hitting the back of Mydei’s legs anyway. He leans forward, sucking a mark into Phainon’s neck and he snaps the ever-present leather band against his throat.

“Mydei,” Phainon sighs, “Mydei.”

Mydei rolls his hips and does as Phainon demands. It’s slow, and fulfilling and Mydei sighs in satisfaction when he spills deep inside Phainon. He wonders what it feels like. Does it feel good? Phainon gets upset when he doesn’t finish inside, so it can’t be uncomfortable, at least. He slips out and kisses his way down until his lips rest on Phainon’s belly. He’s not sure he understands his current obsession with it. It’s inane to think about and yet, he can’t help it. If it were possible...

“If we were to meet again in the next life,” Phainon sighs, brushing his hands through Mydei’s hair, “would you rather me be a woman?”

Mydei stills. Phainon’s tone isn’t condescending or irritated, he just seems curious. If Phainon were like Hephaestion... but...

“I would rather you be you,” he replies, heaving himself back up again to be level with Phainon’s eyes. “In whatever form you come, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae, I would always wish for you to be you.”

Phainon cups his cheek and pulls him closer, whispering against his mouth: “Then in that next life, I shall greet you with my full glory.”

Chapter 8: rage against the dark

Chapter Notes

Look, I am consistently inconsistent. That counts for something, no?
But I SWEAR, next chapter will be the last.
This one also has fight scenes and I never write them so tell me what you think?

!!!PLEASE READ ME!!!
In this chapter, there is gore. *I* personally don't think it's that bad, but I am historically bad at judging this. (It's more clinical, if that helps?)
Anyway, if you want to avoid it at all, then please stop at: **“Deliverer—“ he finally hears, but as he turns his head** and pick back up at **He’s dreaming. It’s the mirror. It’s something, because**
Stop again at **The blade clutters to the ground and he rushes over to them.** and pick up again at **“Lady Tribbie,” he calls, “please wake up. Please. I need your help.”**
I will put what happens in a spoiler here:

▶ Click here

Regardless of whether or not you want to skip, please read the spoiler as I will reference back to it at least twice, (in a "that's what happened" way.) so that it doesn't catch you off-guard.

In any way, I hope you enjoy :)

Their journey to that temple goes on without a hitch—if Mydei ignores the daggers that Phainon glares into his back while travelling. Tribbie seems concerned, and she constantly engages Phainon into conversation but the Deliverer is a man on a mission, and he *can* do two things at once: having a pleasantly nice conversation with Tribbie while also planning Mydeimos’ public execution.

When they rest, Phainon still uses Mydei as a pillow, so he thinks the execution might get delayed. Tribbie giggles when she sees them, and Mydei blushes and doesn't address it any further.

"Agy wasn't lying," she says when they arrive and Mydei silently agrees. This temple looks even worse than he expected—honestly, if he hadn't been told it was a temple, he would have taken it as a random place filled with rubble.

"I think it goes underground," Phainon says, having heaved away some of the rubble. "It's not enough destruction for a whole building, so I think whatever was here was just the front. Look, there are some symbols etched into the slab, but I don't know them. Lady Tribbie, have you seen them before?"

Mydei briefly looks over as Tribbie makes her way to Phainon. Instead of looking at symbols he won't understand anyway, he might as well try to find a way inside. With the level of destruction, it's unlikely that any refugees will be inside—at least none that are alive. But still, Aglaea has requested that they investigate, so they will. And maybe they'll find some remains to bring back, even though it would cloud Phainon's mood on the way back.

So he hauls the biggest pieces of rubble aside, mostly focused on the centre. After all, the entrance makes most sense in the middle, no? He's also on the lookout for any signs that would indicate someone's been here—man or monster alike, but he comes up empty on that front. He can't decide whether that's good or bad, but at least he finds something that looks akin to stairs. Just like Phainon suspected, it seems to lead down into the ground.

"Lady Tribios, Deliverer," he calls over to them, "I have found the entrance."

Both of them poke their heads up from the slab they've been staring at like rousing chickens. It's perhaps improper to think of Tribbie this way, but he can't help but revel at Phainon looking dumb.

"You have?" Phainon asks when he comes over.

“So I have said. Are your ears sore, too?”

Phainon throws him a look and grumbles. “I hate you. Anyway, looks like I was right, it really leads underground. Lady Tribbie, you’ll be okay, right?”

She nods: “Of course, Snowy! Don’t worry about **us**, nothing will happen! Tribbie will just stick close to you, and if something wicked comes our way, I can always fly away. But with both Snowy and Little Dei here, we won’t have anything to worry about!”

Mydei nods, he’s of quite the same mind. In fact, he alone would probably be enough, but Phainon at his back will make sure that he’ll need not watch out for Tribbie as much. Phainon nods as well and takes a step closer to the stairs.

“I hope they have torches down there. Otherwise we’ll have to hold hands while Mydei walks first into all the traps.”

“Heart-warming, Deliverer. I always knew you cared about me.”

Phainon turns and blips his tongue at him, before descending down the stairs. Mydei watches him and waits until Tribbie follows him before he brings up the rear. It feels odd, seeing Phainon get swallowed up by the darkness—it feels like as if the world itself groans, almost like something breaks when Phainon disappears into the dark.

He tries not to dwell on it, but when Phainon finds and lights a torch, it’s like the world moves itself back onto course, even if the cracks still linger.

“Let me carry the torch, Snowy,” Tribbie offers, “I’ll light the path ahead.”

He nods and hands it over and she holds it proudly.

“It’s surprisingly well-kept,” Phainon remarks as they begin walking, “considering it was rubble up top. It can’t have been an earthquake, right?”

“Probably not,” Mydei agrees, “we would see it here.”

“These symbols still don’t make much sense,” Tribbie says, “**we’ve** never seen them before. I wonder if they belong to a titan, or some local deity?”

“The latter is more probable, no? If it were a titan we would have recognised it, right? I’m not *that* bad in history.”

“But you are, Snowy... anyway, you’re probably right! Much has been lost due to the black tide, and sadly, records were among the first things to go.”

Mydei listens to them talk while he looks around. There are multiple symbols on the walls, but he too, recognises nothing of it. But a local deity? He has a hard time really believing that. As far as he is aware, even small villages tend to worship the titans, regardless of how far out they are. Didn’t Phainon once mention that even his out-of-the-way village used to worship Oronyx? And this temple is in the middle of nowhere. Of course, it’s possible that whatever settlement has been here had been completely eradicated, but there hadn’t even been any signs. And no real road led here, either. Something is off here, but he can’t put his finger on it.

“They look odd, don’t they?”

Mydei nods when Phainon steps next to him. “Honestly, they give me the itches. Feels like it’s watching you, somehow.”

“Then don’t look at it.”

“Ha, Mydei, you never fail to give advice. You don’t recognise them either, do you?”

He shakes his head. A part of him tells him to grab Phainon and Tribbie, and get the hell out of here and never look back. Tribios likes explosions, doesn’t she? She could blow this forsaken place up into pieces and do them all a favour.

“Snowy, we should take pictures for Agy! Maybe Cas will know some of these symbols?”

Phainon looks over and nods. “Good idea. Hm, I should have my teleslate right here... ah! Alright, Lady Tribbie, can you get up next to the symbols so that they are clearly visible?”

As the two try to organise themselves, Mydei looks around. There’s nothing here. Granted, it seems like a corridor only, but he hasn’t seen any doors yet. The path feels winding, and his heels itch. Something’s wrong. Something’s wrong, but he doesn’t know *what*. Looking at Phainon, he doesn’t seem to feel it—or he’s better at hiding it, although at this point Mydei knows him well enough to spot little signs. Phainon is always a little on edge on missions, and he only really relaxes when he gets to fight some enemies.

“Okay,” says Phainon and rips him out of his thoughts. “I’ve taken enough photos for now. Let’s try to find a real room, though, maybe there’ll be a statue there, or something of the sort. Also let’s make sure there aren’t any monsters hiding; so we can send in the real historians—ah, no offense, Lady Tribbie.”

“Don’t worry, Snowy! **We** don’t claim to be historians, after all! Maybe we can find a prayer room further in? It’s a little odd that there haven’t been any rooms yet—the temple back home had loads of rooms everywhere!”

“Maybe they all caved in?”

“No,” Mydei throws in, “even if it were so, we’d be able to see the doorways. Yet it’s all smooth walls.”

Phainon stills for a moment, thinking. “Let’s go a little longer. I want to see one room at least and if we don’t find anything there—let’s go back, and return here with better equipment. I can’t believe we didn’t bring any light with us.”

Mydei is still uneasy, but he nods in agreement. If they turned tails now, Aglaea would not be too pleased with their expedition. At least civilians seem unlikely, so they wouldn’t leave anyone here to die.

“Deliverer,” Mydei says after a few more steps, “you keep stopping. Is something in your boot?”

“No,” Phainon replies, not even rising to the bait, “the more I look at these symbols, the more familiar they seem.”

“Do you know what they say?” Tribbie asks excitedly, coming closer from where she’d gone ahead.

“No,” Phainon declines, “I just feel like I’ve seen them before somewhere. But I can’t remember where or if I just dreamt that or... I don’t know. Maybe Professor Anaxa’s scribbles looked similar to these?”

Tribbie doesn’t respond and Mydei urges them to move forward again. Phainon can analyse his feelings later over the pictures he took, and Mydei wants to get out of here as soon as possible. It doesn’t take them long after this that they come across a huge archway, door still fully intact. It’s made out of metal, by the looks of it. There seems to be no scratch on it and that’s —concerning, isn’t it? His unease grows and he grabs Phainon’s arm before the man can go touch the door.

“Something’s wrong,” he warns him, “the feeling just got worse.”

Phainon, surprisingly, doesn’t mock him, but nods instead.

“Yeah,” he agrees, “just this one room, Mydeimos, then we’ll turn back, I promise. It’ll be fine, okay? We’re both here, you and I, and as long as that’s true, we don’t have to worry about a thing, right? You shield my front, and I watch your back, just like always. As it has always been; you and me.”

Saying that, his hand flies to his head, rubbing his temple. Before Mydei can inquire if he’s got a headache, Phainon shakes his head and smiles, turning back to the door.

“Come, big guy, help me open this door, yeah?”

Sighing, Mydei complies and they push the door open a crack, just enough for them to enter. The room is rather large, at least from what he can tell in the darkness. Tribbie carries the blazing torch inside behind them and she immediately heads towards the wall where some braziers are located. She lights them all in record time, coating the room in a gentle firelight.

The room is—barren. There is some rubble here, but nothing more than what they already saw on the way here. He frowns and alongside Phainon, he steps further into the room, looking around. Mydei had been expecting *something*, some sort of altar, some sort of shelving, *anything*, really. And the room isn't in a condition bad enough that he could rationalise nothing being here.

"Did they take everything?" Phainon asks. "But no, that makes no sense, right? No way they could haul any sort of altar out of here, especially if they left in a hurry."

"Maybe it's a greeting room?" Tribbie suggests, but she sounds unsure as well. "This temple looks nothing like what **we** expected. Where are the trinkets? The scrolls? The homage to whatever they worshipped here?"

Mydei walks a little further into the room, pushing some debris aside. But there's nothing under it either and he feels cheated, a little bit. There aren't even any signs of monsters around. And from the state of the outside, looters are also unlikely. Besides, they would've left the containers behind, and statues are quite hard to loot.

"Snowy, do any of these feel familiar to you?"

Mydei doesn't pay them any further mind, and he instead walks even further into the room, trying desperately to find anything. But he comes up empty, and the room is just—empty. It's empty, like it's a fake; like a showroom he knows some monarchs prefer to have so that they do not get robbed of their valuables. But the difference is—a showroom is filled to the brim. It's never empty, and it's never desolate. It's not even dusty, but here... there's just *nothing* and he's not sure why it upsets him so much.

Then he hears a loud *click* from where Phainon and Tribbie are and suddenly, it sounds like the room is *moving*. He steadies himself before he hastily returns to their side.

“HKS, what did you *do*?!”

“I—I just pressed on that symbol! I, I didn’t know it was a switch! What’s going on? Are we caving in?”

Mydei only throws a brief glance at the symbol Phainon mentioned. He’s seen it before on the walls—it’s of two circles, intertwining in the middle. He thinks it’s called—infinity? There’s something off about it, though, but he doesn’t have the time to dwell on it as he thinks hard on how to shield Phainon and Tribbie from any part of the ceiling that would crash down on them. Surprisingly, he needn’t have worried, as after some suspicious groaning, it all stops and they are all uninjured. He frowns. Did some mechanism in the background activate? Maybe it unveiled a door somewhere.

“Little Dei, Snowy... the door is gone!”

“What?!” Phainon and Mydei shout at the same time as they whip their heads around. But to no avail, as Tribbie is right: where the door used to be is nothing but a smooth, blank wall. Phainon runs ahead and he punches his fist against the stone, probably hoping it’s just an illusion or a trick of the mind but judging by his hurt wail, the wall is rather real and solid. Damn it all. Mydei should’ve given in to his instincts and simply drag these two back outside.

“Snowy! Are you okay? Did you hurt yourself? Do you want me to blow on it?”

“I’m okay,” Phainon sniffles and lets Tribbie place a big kiss on his knuckles. If Mydei weren’t so mad right now, he’d think it adorable.

“What now, O Great Deliverer? Deliver us to the outside, will you?”

“Don’t act like this was all my grand plan! You think I *want* to be stuck underground with *your* smelly ass? I’d rather—oh, is that a mirror?”

He points to the other side of the room and sure enough, there is a mirror there, standing tall and untouched by the dirt around it. Mydei is absolutely sure that it hadn’t been there a second ago. He balls his fist, ready to strike. They have to find a way out of here.

Come, a voice whispers, seemingly from the walls, *cast your glance at me so I may glance at you in return. Once we have met, your path will forever lead into the future.*

“What the fuck,” Mydei mutters, looking around. He doesn’t think that there is a tangible person attached to that voice, but it sure would be nice if there were, if only to give him someone other than Phainon to punch.

“Does it... want us to look into the mirror?”

Mydei and Phainon exchange a glance. “Can you punch us out of here?”

Mydei turns back to where the door used to be and hesitates. What if the building will crumble? He supposes it would be alright—he is immortal, and Phainon has always been sturdy. If both of them shield Tribbie, she should be fine. Mydei test-punches the wall until he deems it’s probably safe and then he punches the wall as hard as he can, expecting a giant hole to appear so he can smugly smirk at Phainon, flaunting his raw strength again, but—nothing. The tremor flows through his entire arm, but the wall stands unimpressed, like he never even tried to punch through.

“...I’ll never forget this. Anyway, the mirror.”

Mydei grumbles as Phainon grins and turns away. He doesn’t trust the mirror, because why should he? A magic mirror just what, fell from the sky and is beckoning them in? It reeks of a trap, and with no way out of here, not even with brute force, what choice are they left with? But who could’ve set this up? These Cleaners Phainon spoke of before, could this be their doing? But how? The whole thing seems so improbable.

“Let **us** look first,” Tribbie offers as they arrive before the mirror. It is incredible large, Mydei notes, almost twice his height. His unease sky-rockets. If he smashed the mirror, maybe that would work? But if some sort of magic is at work, it might just doom them completely.

“What do you see, Lady Tribbie?”

He and Phainon stay off to the side, perhaps a little cowardly in case the mirror explodes or something. Tribbie stands before the mirror and she stares with big eyes, unmoving, and yet so visibly moved.

“I see... I see mama,” she says, putting a hand on her chest, “I see mama holding me... just like she did so long ago. I can—I can almost hear her sing to me. I can almost feel the warmth of her embrace. She’s petting my hair... Snowy, I—do you think mama would be proud of me?”

“Of course,” he replies gently, “she would be so proud. How could she not? You have travelled so far, have experienced so much and have aided countless people on your journey... She would be sad, I think, about the fragmentation but she would love all of you so dearly, because you all would be her beloved child. If she could see you now, Lady Tribbie, she would hold you tight and love you to the moon and back, forevermore.”

Tribbie starts sobbing and she throws herself to the side, straight into Phainon’s arms. He holds her tight, petting her hair and making shushing noises. Mydei’s heart warms at the sight and he walks the two steps over, putting one careful hand on Tribbie’s head while the other leans on Phainon’s back. He doesn’t say anything but Tribbie seems to snuggle into his palm regardless.

“Thank you,” she sniffs after she’s done crying. “It’s just... **we** miss mama very much. Thank you Snowy, for what you’ve said. I—no, **we** know she would’ve liked you very much.”

Phainon laughs, still holding onto Tribbie, and he rubs his neck awkwardly.

“What praise,” he laughs nervously, “I am honoured. Mydei, do you want to go next? It appears we might all have to look, anyway.”

Tribbie is still holding onto Phainon herself, even if she doesn't seem to be too aware of it; still seeking some comfort. Mydei breathes, and nods. He hopes he doesn't see the river of souls or the-like, or worse—his father.

He pauses before the mirror. He sees... he sees—

"I see my mother," he says, "and I see my father. He is... patting me on the head, as if in praise for a deed well done and my mother—she stands next to me, laughing as if she had been just told a joke and—" His breath hitches for a moment. "I see my friends. I see Hephaestion and the others... they are alive and well, and they are clad in Kremnoan colours, part of the royal guard. My friends come over to me and—"

He stops. At Hephaestion's feet, he can see a child. He dares not look at it much further because—does he yearn for it? Did he yearn for it back then; does he yearn for it now? And if he does—why is it not Phainon? Is it because Phainon is *incapable*? But that's—that's not fair, is it?

"And?"

Phainon's voice is gentle and ever un-pressing. Mydei turns to him, looking at his soft smile.

If he were here, would you care about me still?

His eyes find the mirror again. Phainon will never know the lie. The child has Mydei's hair, and Hephaestion's nose.

"Nothing," he says, "they hug me. It appears I have won a great victory for Kremnos."

"That sounds great, Dei!" Tribbie says, having finally let go of Phainon. "**We** know, once tomorrow comes, you'll be reunited again. **We** can't wait to meet your friends and family!"

"Yes," Phainon agrees, smiling with his eyes closed, "once tomorrow comes."

Mydei swallows around the lump in his throat, and he steps away from the mirror, returning to the side. He quickly brushes his hand over Phainon's. The Deliverer doesn't pull away, but he doesn't reciprocate, either. Does he know, somehow? Does he worry once more? If Hephaestion had made it to Okhema alongside Mydei... would his relationship with Phainon still be the same? Normally, he doesn't ponder these *what if*-questions that Phainon seems to favour so.

"Your turn, Deliverer," he says instead and Phainon smiles.

"Saving the best for last," he grins and steps forward.

"I see..." he starts, leaving a long pause. Asshole. "I see Aedes Elysiae. Everyone is there... I think they're having a festival? Did I ever tell you about the harvest festivals we used to do? I always made sure everyone got a pretty crown to wear! Oh, even my parents and Cyrene... oh, she's talking to Hyacine. Ah, the two would've liked each other, I think... hm? Oh, is that the Imperator? Was she... really that short? She's no taller than Cyrene, and Cyrene can't even reach up to my chest."

"Yeah," Tribbie laughs, "Cery didn't like her height being talked about. She's never said, but **we** always believed she was embarrassed."

Phainon laughs. "Ah, I see. It's got to be hard to get taken seriously if you barely reach up to a man's chest, huh? I used to squat before Cyrene sometimes and she'd always kick me... I guess the Imperator would've beheaded me, huh?"

"HKS," Mydei scoffs, "she would have beheaded you for your words before you would even get the chance."

Phainon laughs and looks over. "I guess you're right! I'm an insensitive bastard, right? Ah, Mydeimos, you break my heart. They look like they're having fun though. I wonder what they're celebrating?"

"Maybe they're celebrating Era Nova!"

Phainon smiles wistfully. “Yes, maybe,” he agrees quietly. “Maybe Era Nova’s come for them.”

Something’s wrong, Mydei thinks, but he’s not sure what it is. Something’s wrong with what Phainon’s saying. But what is it? What is he missing? It feels so small, so insignificant, and yet it is so momentous. Just thinking about it leaves him bereft of breath.

I have gazed you, the voice returns, *and in turn, you have gazed me. Continue on, o hallowed child of Amphoreus.*

There’s rumbling again and they worry once more about the roof caving in, but nothing of the sort happens. Instead, on the far side of the room, a new doorway appears, because that’s not creepy whatsoever.

“Sure,” Phainon says nonchalantly, “that’s normal. That’s just how doors work. Appearing out of nowhere. Anyway, I vote we go. What’s the worst that could happen?”

“We could die,” Mydei responds instantly.

Phainon sighs deep. “It was a rhetoric question, Mydeimos. Can you haul your conspicuous body over there, please?”

“I can, yes.”

“That was—you know what, forget it. I’ll go first. Duck, duck, go!”

Mydei frowns. What’s that supposed to mean? Is there a duck? Is *he* supposed to duck? He’d like to see the duck, if there is one. As they leave, Mydei throws one last glance back at the mirror—maybe just to make sure he didn’t make all of this up. And sure enough, the mirror still stands, but he thinks—he thinks he sees a faint crack, but he is left with no time to dwell on it, as Phainon marches ever forward.

“There are more symbols now,” Tribbie remarks as she holds the torch high. He’s surprised it hasn’t burned out yet, but he’s grateful. He’s no stranger to

fighting in the dark, and he knows Phainon is more than capable himself, but protecting Tribios might be too difficult in the dark.

“Yes,” Phainon agrees, “but they seem to be getting all over the place; more like mad scribbles. Should I take pictures of them, too?”

“Sure! The more, the merrier, right? Maybe Naxy can analyse them too? He’d be sure to figure out what they mean, right, Snowy?”

Phainon hums only in agreement as he lifts his teleslate again, waiting for Tribbie to get into position. Mydei steps up next to him, looking at the screen.

“I do not like this place,” he states, “we should attempt to leave as soon as possible.”

“Yeah,” Phainon nods, “but if you can’t punch the wall down, we have little choice but to continue with whatever is going on. At least it’s not been malevolent so far, right? I thought about smashing the mirror, but what if the whole thing collapses on us then? We don’t even know how far we are underground. If only there were a window somewhere... we could even climb up by the side of a cliff.”

Mydei hums. He’s of the same mind, and hopefully Zagreus will be on their side. Even a temple underground would beget a window or two, right? He still doesn’t understand how in the world the door just fucking *disappeared*. Doors don’t do that. They also don’t just appear randomly on previously barren walls. They shouldn’t have investigated, they should’ve fucking blown the place up and call it a day.

He grabs Phainon’s hand on instinct alone. The man jumps a little, clearly surprised, and he turns to Mydei with big question marks in his eyes. He hasn’t checked the bandages in a few days, but he knows they’re there.

“Stay close to me,” he commands, “no matter what happens.”

Phainon blinks, taken aback, and then he smiles softly.

“Of course,” he promises, “I’ll always be right behind you, Mydei.”

Satisfied, Mydei nods. He gives Phainon’s hand one last squeeze before he lets go again. Part of him wants to ask if his wounds hurt, but the more rational part of him tells him it’s fruitless to ask.

“**We** see another door! Come on you two, let’s hurry! Tribbie misses the sun~”

“Coming, coming,” Phainon laughs, putting his teleslate away before quickly following their little guide. Mydei watches his back for a moment, before he, too, follows.

The next room looks much like the first, just a little smaller. Here, again, stands a mirror, larger than him.

I now pose a question upon thee, the voice from the walls whispers, *hollow child, what have your golden eyes spied? Answer me, and make your way unto the future.*

Mydei frowns. Out of the three of them, he’s the only one that could be considered having golden eyes, but somehow, he doesn’t feel like he’s been addressed at all. Did the voice expect somehow else? He exchanges a glance with Phainon, and the Deliverer clenches his jaw.

“I’ll go first,” he says then, “it’s only fair, right?”

Mydei crosses his arms and nods. He wants to fidget, and he *doesn’t* fidget. He can’t even blame this sudden want onto Phainon. He looks around, but there’s nothing there. No monster, no nothing, not even any destroyed structures. This place feels artificial. Like it exists for one and one purpose only, but what? These mirrors... what do they really mean? Why did all see what they did? And what could they possibly see now?

Phainon steps before the mirror and he tilts his head a bit, stepping closer still, as if he couldn’t see anything within. He pulls a face and squints, rubbing his palm over the surface. Mydei frowns. Isn’t he seeing anything? Or is he going blind? With Phainon, you never really know. Then, however,

the Deliverer freezes and suddenly goes very, very rigid. He presses his hand against the mirror, eyes wide and mouth agape, shaking his head minutely.

“Deliverer—“ Mydei starts but never gets to finish. Black fog emerges from the mirror, quickly followed by the loud bang of an explosion, and Mydei’s world goes dark. He doesn’t even see what’s happened to Phainon or Tribbie. He hopes they’re alright. He hopes they didn’t get hurt.

When he comes back to, he has no idea how much time has passed. Groaning, he turns his head to the side, dizzy and blurry in eyesight, and he thinks he sees Tribbie lie next to him. She can’t be dead... right? No. No, she’s just—knocked out. He forces himself to turn and he almost has to puke, but he suppresses the urge. He reaches out and gently shakes her small body and she whimpers slightly, unwaking. He breathes out. Good. She’s still alive. He blinks and restrains himself from shaking his head and he looks around. Phainon is like a beacon in the dark, but he can’t see him anywhere. And there’s... not enough rubble for him to be buried. Mydei closes his eyes and instead strains his hearing. Yes; he can make out the distant sound of fighting. Chances are; he’ll find Phainon there. But... he can’t leave Tribbie here all alone. What if someone finds her while she’s helpless?

Groaning, he gathers her in his arms and pushes himself upwards. The world swims before his eyes and he figures he must’ve gained a concussion. Just what had happened? No matter, he can try to find out later. Right now, Phainon will need his assistance.

He progresses slower than he would wish for. His vision swims, and he has difficulty walking in a straight line. He can pull through, though; he’s a warrior of Castrum Kremnos. What would his people say if they saw him defeated by a measly concussion?

The noise is getting louder now. He has to be close. And sure enough, when he turns a corner—had there been one before?—he sees Phainon in all his glory, battling against the creatures of the black tide and titankin alike. He... wants to help. But instead of taking a step forward, he falls to his knees

again. This shouldn’t happen. He should... he should be fine. He’s Mydeimos the Undying, he shouldn’t...

“Deliverer,” he shouts as loud as he can, barely a whisper against his tongue, but the Deliverer turns still and his eyes widen but before Mydei can think more of it, darkness’ veil puts itself over him. How odd, he thinks, he can’t remember closing his eyes.

*

Tell me, o void child, what hast thou seen in mirrors hence?

A memory you could lose yourself in: everyone he knows and loves, safe and sound in a home that is no longer, with golden fields softly swaying in the ever-gentle wind. If he tries just hard enough, he can hear them laugh, too. They will never turn around to look at him; because for their happiness, he cannot exist.

A future where you have lost yourself: he saw himself staring back, unmoving, cold and cracked at the very core, and worst of all, clad in that damned black that has haunted his mind for years now. Sunken eyes, devoid of any life and the very tip of that sword dipped in dried golden blood. The blazing sun, enthralled in thorns, bleeding golden blood and under its weight, he still could never crumble.

And after that…

The swordsman *looked* straight at him and came out of the mirror, ready to take Phainon away. He blacked out then, and when he woke up, he could feel a blaring pain in his leg. He hisses at it and looks down, finding an arrow lodged straight into his thigh. Turning his head, he finds both Mydei and Tribbie lie on the floor unmoving and he makes his way over to them to try and wake them. Tribbie has a wound on her temple, and she’s likely concussed but she still lives. That has to be good enough for now, and

Mydei…Mydei seems unharmed, but he, too, is knocked out cold. Who knew that there is a word for *blacking out* in the Kremnoan language? Phainon lets out a hefty breath and looks at his own leg again. They didn't bring any bandages with them—Mydei not ever needing them, and Phainon usually agile enough to avoid having to need them. It would probably the better idea to leave the arrow in, so that he wouldn't bleed out. Should he break the shaft off? But what if the arrowhead would slip in further then? Hyacine is going to kill him… ugh, hopefully he can deal with this on his own before they get back to Okhema so he wouldn't even have to tell her.

He hears sounds and his blood runs cold.

Panicked, he looks around, standing up. Sudden sounds are *always* bad. After having encountered *nothing*, sudden sounds can only mean monsters. He summons his sword and looks around. He can't fight here. He absolutely cannot risk Tribbie and Mydei to get out hurt while they're down. He tightens his grip and runs towards the origin of the sound, hoping to intercept them before they can get here.

Mydei just needs to wake up, and then it'll be all fine. Phainon can hold out until then.

Phainon runs down yet another cursed corridor and he sharply turns a corner, where he finds the sound's origins. Titankin, and worse still, black tide monsters mixed in with them. Usually they don't mingle, but this place is weird enough that it hardly surprises him. No matter. He just has to push them back here, and all will be fine. It's not like these monsters are endless, right? Everything ends.

He slices the first enemy clean in half and he runs further into the room. He wants them to focus on the opposite site from where he came from—once Mydei gets here, he doesn't need the man ambushed straight away.

Phainon dodges the next two attacks, and blocks the third. He has to be careful with the black tide. Chrysos Heirs are naturally more resistant to its effects, but they're hardly immune to it. As long as he can avoid open wounds and their weapons lodged into him, he should be fine. He evades an arrow in the last moment and decides it would probably be wise to deal

with the backline first. He body-slams into an enemy to shove them aside and he breaks through, rolling over the ground to hopefully make two enemies hit each other and with one swing he cuts the archer's legs off, before he rams his blade in their chest, hopefully eliminating them for good.

Sensing something approach from behind, he jumps to the side, locking his eyes on the next archer. There are four here, but as long as he can get rid of at least two; he should be in a better position. One enemy punches him in the leg and Phainon grunts, jumping forwards and swinging his sword before looking. The head makes a hard sound upon hitting the ground, much like a stone upon marble. Then, he rolls out of dodge and gets upright again. He must take note of the wall, because he doesn't want to get backed into a corner.

He quickly evades some of the Warrior's swings and when they bend over, having tried to grab him, he jumps up and uses their back to launch himself into the air, coming down again with a powerful blow, killing two creatures of the black tide. He's doing well, but there are still so many enemies. At least none of them are focused on the corridor he came out of. His mind keeps drifting off though, and he forces it to remain on track. He can lose himself later.

I see Hephaestion and the others.

No. He can't think about that now. With any luck, whatever he's feeling about that will be gone by the time they make it out of here. Speaking of, how are they going to do that? Well, the monster had to come from *somewhere*, right? Maybe that blasted mirror could be useful for once.

Phainon moves to block two attacks at once and oddly, his legs are growing tired. That shouldn't happen so soon. He's been fighting for long enough that his body got used to the strain and as much as he enjoys complaining to Mydei about his soreness, he isn't actually *that* frail. He grits his teeth and decides to ignore it. Whatever it is, he can deal with this later. Where the fuck is Mydei? The man does *not* need additional beauty sleep. Phainon *wishes* he were only a third as pretty as Mydeimos.

“Deliverer—“ he finally hears, but as he turns his head, maybe to chastise Mydei for taking so long, his eyes widen instead. Mydei has come out of the corridor and he’s holding Tribbie in his arm, but—can’t he see? Doesn’t he know? Right next to him stands a monster with its greatsword raised high and before Phainon can shout out a warning, anything at all—the blade goes down, and Mydei’s head makes a soft sound on the ground, like a pomegranate splitting on the dirt.

The sound of his body follows, a dull thud, and golden blood spills on the ground and Phainon is frozen in shock because—because—because—

He’s dreaming. It’s the mirror. It’s *something*, because—because—because—because Mydei *can’t be dead*. No. He refuses it to be true. It’s a trick of the light. An illusion of the darkness. Something. Anything. He doesn’t care.

He gets forced out of his reverie by a blade piercing his middle and in the blind hot pain he remembers he’s still on a battlefield. He growls and whips himself around, cleaving the head off his assailant’s shoulders in one fell swoop. He needs to get to Mydei and Tribbie. They’re vulnerable, and he won’t let them fall. So he sprints over to them as fast as his worryingly quick numb growing legs allow and he cuts the titankin with the greatsword in half. He whips around and blocks an enemy sword with his bracer while stabbing something else through the face. He has no more time for dilly-dallying. He grips his sword with both hands and swings it in a wide cleave, taking several monsters out. His middle grows sickeningly wet and heavy, but he’s no time to think about that. One after another, they fall before him.

His sword shatters before the fight ends, and he curses the shoddy blade work. He’s shattered every gods-forsaken sword he’s been given, and *now* it decides it’s time? Whatever. Phainon is far from helpless and with a roar, he grabs the monster before him and tosses it into its friends. He dodge-rolls to the side and picks up the fallen greatsword. It’s far bigger than what he’s used to, but when did that ever stop him? The sword burns the palms of his hands and with a shout; he throws himself forward, driving the corrupted blade through a titankin. Using the momentum, he turns and raises the blade upward, straight into a black tide creature trying to ambush him from

above. He flips over an enemy to land again on his feet, swinging his blade around him.

His feet slip on the blood on the ground, but he adjusts his stance and jumps up, kneeing something in the face and not feeling the impact it should have and then he twirls around, cutting a few heads in half during the movement.

His breaths come heavy when the last monster falls and Phainon's eyes scan the battlefield, just in case he's missed something. But nothing is moving. He's... won. His gaze finds Mydei and Tribbie again and he knows he still has no time to breathe.

The blade clutters to the ground and he rushes over to them. He skitters on the ground and heaves Mydei's body around, to check for Tribbie's life-signs. She doesn't move, and her head is wounded, but she still breathes. For now, that has to be enough. A part of him had hoped that maybe he could waste more time on her, so he wouldn't have to face the ugly truth, but perhaps it's best done while adrenaline still cruises through his veins. So he turns to Mydei and he pushes his body straight and after a moment, pulls it away from the golden blood crowning it. *Crowned in blood*, and he won't, he *won't*. Not even trying to control his breathing, he looks towards —towards Mydei's head. His hands shake when he crawls over to reach for it and titans, he's lucky nothing's happened to it during the fight. He picks it up gently and Mydei's eyes are still half-open. Choking on the bile in his throat, Phainon closes the golden eyes and turns back to the headless body before him. He doesn't even try to stand up, and instead robs his way there on his knees. His legs are—numb, even more, but he has no time to think about it.

Maybe the easiest solution will work. Mydei's body is unstudied territory, after all. So he just—holds the head back on the stump, hoping it'll just... grow back on, or something, but of course, he's no such luck. Phainon doesn't even know if Mydei's ever lost limbs before and if he did, how he worked around that. Do they re-grow when he returns to life? But surely, there's a difference between an arm and a head, no?

No matter what, he's not going to test it. What if Mydei would come back to life just to die again immediately? No. No, he needs to... re-attach the

head... yeah, that’s easy. Why is Hyacine not here? Hyacine should be here. He can’t heal. He can’t care for anything. He can’t even care for *himself*, for crying out loud!

His breaths become sporadic and he notices; and he *needs* to calm down. He can’t get a panic attack now, because if he gets one *now*, they’re all doomed. He presses his eyes shut and bends over, hugging Mydei’s head close to his middle. Fuck, he’s still bleeding himself, but what difference does a little blood make in the grand scheme of things?

“Okay,” he breathes and sits up straight again, “okay.”

He looks around. How do you re-attach anything? Stitches, probably. But he doesn’t have any, so he’ll have to improvise. Firstly, he needs to make sure to fasten the head to the neck somewhat securely. But with what? He has *nothing*. Wait. His leatherband. Maybe he can use that as a base? He gently puts the head back on the ground and unfastens the band, looking at it. It’s never ripped on him before, even when he’s had to strain his neck, and he and Mydei have a similar build, so it’ll fit for sure. But that only won’t be enough, so what else is there? Even if he were able to rip his clothes for strings, he has no needle, and not even anything close to it. Is there something here he can use? Surely it’s not too much to ask that one of the titankin carry a sewing kit? Fruitless, of course, but... their bodies are hard, aren’t they? He crawls over to the closest felled enemy and inspects its body. It looks a little bit like crystal, doesn’t it? It’s hard enough for sure. If he could chip some parts off... he looks to where he’s dropped the sword and immediately decides against it; that blade is *way* too large. But his own hands would be too soft; and if he breaks his hand now, that would spell disastrous. He looks to Mydei. Mydei’s gauntlets would be hard enough. He crawls back over to the body and buckles on the way there, his knees giving out. That’s not good. That’s something he really, *really* has to think about, but—not now. He can ignore it. He doesn’t need to feel them, they just need to *work*.

He gently unclasps the gauntlet and slides it onto his own arm. It feels odd, if he’s honest. He’s never worn them before; never even wanted to, but there’s a first time for everything. He hobbles back over to the titankin and starts punching its arm until splinters are starting to fall off. He tears the

arm a little, trying to break off fragments that are long enough. He tries to bend one, just to see if they can, but it breaks between his fingers. No good, then. Fair enough.

He continues until he has seven pieces of roughly the same length, and they just have to be enough. He hurries back over to Mydei and now he hesitates. How does he do this? He's afraid the band and the splinters won't be enough on their own. Think. Think, Phainon! You're no debate champion for nothing.

Hold on, his cape! He can use that! Can't he? Aglaea will surely forgive him. He unfastens the cape and thinks—band or cape first? No, band. He doesn't want to get the cloth inside of Mydei be accident, or something. If only Tribbie were awake, then she could just whisk them back away to Okhema. Oh, Hyacine would be so much better at this. She'll probably scold him for his sloppy work, but what is he meant to do? Okay. Okay, okay, he can do this. He can do this.

He hauls Mydei's body next to a low wall and carefully manoeuvres him into a position where he won't slide down. Okay. Great. Hurriedly, Phainon goes to retrieve the head and carefully, ever so carefully, places it back on the neck, and then holds it tight with all his might—and one hand. Quickly, he wraps the band around Mydei's neck—it's a little hard to fasten it with just one hand, but he makes do. He pulls it a little tighter than he would on himself, but it's alright, isn't it? Okay, okay. He's breathing too quickly again, but he has no time to think about regulating it. He can breathe when he's dead, really. Phainon swallows around the bile in his throat and reaches over to grab the carefully collected splinters, still holding Mydeimos' head tight.

"Sorry," he breathes as he pushes the fragments through skin and flesh. He still has one gauntlet on, but he barely notices. His vision blurs at times, but he pushes through until all the splinters are in place. It's not pretty, and he doubts it's functional, but he has nothing else. His hope of Tribbie waking up dwindles with every passing moment, but he can't give up. Okay. Okay. He gently lowers Mydei back down onto the floor and pulls his cape close. He should probably try to wrap Mydei's head completely, and then try to tie it back to his body, right? At least his cape isn't made of flimsy material,

thank Aglaea. He carefully rips it into several strips, and then starts wrapping it around Mydei's head. A couple times around the head, then a couple times around the neck and he has just enough left to wrap it once around his chest. It's a tight fit, but if it works, it works. Okay. Now, he needs to... test it. He closes his eyes and breathes a couple times. He can do this. It'll be fine. He grabs Mydei's shoulders and gently pulls him up, keeping his eyes shut. He's waiting to hear the same sound again, and when no such thing happens, he blinks one eye open to peek at Mydei's head still being attached. Oh... oh, thank fuck. Okay. Okay, that's good. Not wanting to push his luck, he lowers Mydei back down again and crawls over to Tribbie, shaking her a little. Her head wound looks nasty, but it's stopped bleeding.

"Lady Tribbie," he calls, "please wake up. Please. I need your help."

Of course, he's not so lucky, and besides her quiet breathing, there's no sign she's even still alive. Fuck it. He sits back on his hunches and looks around. He needs to get out of here. He needs to get back to Okhema. With his luck, the dromas ran off too. But how does he get out of here? Sighing, he stands up on numb legs and he looks over to the far wall. If he's not wrong, this might be an outer wall, and with that, his only chance. He balls his fist still in Mydei's gauntlet, and he walks over full of determination. He stops before the wall and he breathes in deep, trying to calm his troubled mind. He fails, and he punches the wall as hard as he can. The reverberations travel up his arm into his head, but he grits his teeth and he tries again and again and again until the wall crumbles under his blow. Phainon almost stumbles and falls outside, but he steadies himself the last minute. He can see...

He can see the sky. However, there is no ground for him to step on. He looks down a sharp Cliffside, until he spies the ocean below. Great. He leans forward a little and looks up the raggedy site and wonders how far down they are. At least he can see the sky, so that's got to count for something, right?

Phainon doesn't have a choice; he'll need to climb up. He goes back inside and stares at Mydei and Tribbie lying on the ground. How is he going to transport them? He can't hold them if he needs his hands to climb. Hmm.

Oh! What about his coat? It should be long enough, right? He'll put Mydei on his back, and try to strap Tribbie to his chest. He hurries back to them and strips himself. Well, this *has* to work, because after this, he'll have nothing else. He pulls Mydei on his back and he hunches over, trying to wrap the coat around him enough to ensure he doesn't drop. So, under his buttocks and around his middle... okay... and then Tribbie too, shoving her into his chest and tying the cloth tight. He does some experimental little jumps, but neither of them falls out. Hopefully the climb won't be that long.

Phainon closes his eyes and walks back to the hole. It'll be fine. If he goes slowly, it'll be fine. The wind is cold and harsh in his face, and he breathes in deep. No use in dilly-dallying. If Tribbie showed signs of waking up, then maybe, but she's as still as a stone. At least she's breathing, so that's something. Mydei is cold and heavy on his back, but that's *okay*.

"Let's go," he hypes himself up, "golden boy of Okhema, Deliverer of Era Nova, let's go."

He's still wearing Mydei's gauntlet. Well, maybe it'll help find crevices while he climbs. He swallows down hard and decides he's stalled long enough. He places his hands on the rocks and then swings his legs out. It's difficult; to climb with numb legs, but he'll make do. His arms are stringer anyway, so he'll rely on them. Mydei never says nice things about his arms, it's always just *thighs, thighs* and more *thighs*. Personally, he thinks they could use some more muscle, but he hasn't had time to come up with a new training regime.

It's awkward, having to watch out for Tribbie's head. He won't slam her against the rocks, so he needs to ascend while a little hunched. At least Mydei stays somewhat secured, even though Phainon can feel that he's slipping a little.

His arms burn from the sting and it really was a great idea to cut himself nearly to the bone *just* before they departed. Truly, he's the king of timings. Whatever. So he bleeds a little more, what's the big deal? At least his hands stay blood-free and he only has to worry about sweat.

“Mydei,” he pants half-way up the Cliffside, “please help me. You *always* help me.”

But Mydei stays silent. Phainon closes his eyes, longing for a break, and pulls himself up further. He’s not going to give up, even if his arms fall off. His feet keep losing ground, but that’s okay, because his arms are working double-time.

It feels like forever until he’s able to pull himself over the edge and he crawls away from the cliff, allowing himself to collapse to the side for a minute. He’s dizzy, his vision swims and he can’t breathe properly. But he’s made it. He’s made it to the top, and neither Tribbie nor Mydei were lost in the process.

Phainon desperately wants to close his eyes and sleep, but he can’t. What if there are monsters about? Besides, he needs to get back to Okhema to report to Aglaea. So, he heaves out a breath and pushes himself up again. Standing on shaking legs, he re-adjusts both Mydei and Tribbie to make sure they’re staying secure. He hooks his arms under Mydei’s legs for added security and hopes Tribbie’s sling will hold. But... which direction is Okhema? He’s usually good with directions. Maybe he should just aim to find a road first. If he’s lucky, he’ll find a caravan heading to the Holy City as well and they could hitch-hike. Or Tribbie would wake up and contact Trinnon and Trianne... or did the two already realise that Tribbie isn’t asleep?

“Heave-ho,” he whispers, “duck, duck, go.”

He’s no idea how long he’s been walking for, He’s still bleeding, he thinks, but he’s not sure. He’s pretty sure that that arrow had been poisoned—he can’t explain the persisting numbness otherwise. And the gash in his middle... he doesn’t want to think about the sickening feeling within. If he doesn’t think about it, then it’ll go away, right? And at least his left arm is bleeding. He’s not sure about the right, because the gauntlet might be too taut. Whatever. He shouldn’t think about that.

I see Hephaestion and the others.

Stupid. Stupid, stupid, *stupid*. What reason is there to be jealous of a dead man? And yet, he can't help but be insecure: if Hephaestion had made it into Okhema with Mydei, then—would Mydei have spared him any thought at all? In his dreams, the Kremnoan sometimes calls for his old friends. It's *fine*. Phainon's sure he's called for Cyrene at some point, too, but... it's different, isn't it? Mydei isn't as insecure as he is.

Mydei had seemed *guilty* when he'd looked away from the mirror. Why? Had he secretly lavished in a fantasy that Phainon didn't exist in? It's alright. It's gotta be alright. Phainon already knows that he can't stand next to Mydei in any other context but combat. And Krateros, the closest thing Mydei has to a mentor, can't stand him... what if that old man compares Phainon to Hephaestion and finds him lacking? After all, according to Mydei, Hephaestion had been a sight to behold on the battlefield.

You don't truly love combat.

Phainon's leg buckle, but he catches himself before he falls. His insides throb in pain and misery, but he has to keep moving. Forward, ever forward. He can't fall, he can't give up; the things he carries are far too important.

May this world never again need a Deliverer.

He grits his teeth and his ankle rolls on a loose rock on the path and he stumbles, landing hard on his knee. He just catches himself on one hand, curling his fingers in the dirt before he pushes through and stands back up again.

He tries, doesn't he? He tries so hard, he just wishes it were enough. He will never hold it against Aglaea, but it took her three months to even ask his name. Trianne had told him of this Cifera and he didn't know why, but it had stung somewhere—still does, on bad days. Tribbie has told him how much Aglaea cared about this Cifera, just akin to a daughter really, and he remembers thinking that it surely hadn't taken her three months to ask Cifera's name. He'd never say it out loud, but he knows he's just a rebound.

That’s all he ever is, isn’t he? He can just hope that in the end, at least someone remembers him in the margin of their own stories.

Hephaestion braided it for me.

What is he going to leave behind? His inability to save money; up to a point where Aglaea is keeping track of his spending? The alleged atrocious way he’d dress himself, if Aglaea hadn’t colour-coordinated his entire wardrobe? *Mydei*, he thinks, *you’ll meet so many great warriors, why would you ever remember our spars? I’m just a placeholder for the real thing to show up.*

His eyes start to droop and he can’t say for how long he’s been walking. Has he even looked for any signs? He might’ve walked past Okhema already, for all he knows. Maybe he should turn back. Mydei is so heavy. Tribbie’s breaths are too hot against his clammy skin and he wants to sleep. His insides feel hollowed out; and like they’ve turned to stone at the same time.

If not for the flame-chase, he thinks, *none of you would’ve given me the time of day.*

“Heave-ho,” he rasps with a hollow voice, “duck, duck, go.”

His eyes sting with tears, but they don’t fall. It’s better this way. The Deliverer wouldn’t cry, would they? So he can’t, either. Keep going. Just always keep going. Just one more step, always just one more step. That’s all it takes.

I think you would’ve liked him.

Sweat rolls down his neck, and his arms start to really hurt from all the weight. Even Tribbie’s body pressed into his chest provides no comfort any longer and he longs to get rid of her. But he fears, if he puts either of them down, he’ll have no strength left to fasten them to himself anymore.

A person worthy of love and trust, with no flaws or faults, and the only person that could fulfil Era Nova.

“Then that’s who I’ll be,” he whispers, “I’ll be the Deliverer.”

Would Cyrene laugh at him, if she saw him like this? Would anyone even recognise him anymore? He can’t go home anymore. If he dies, all of Aedes Elysiae dies with him. He’s so cold. He wonders if mom baked any bread today. He misses it. He misses sitting on the roof with Cyrene and he misses feeding the fishes some bread. Would she miss him too, if she were in his stead? She’d be such good friends with Castorice and Hyacine... these three would go along well with each other, he thinks. Aglaea wouldn’t have needed to waste so much time on training her how to speak, either.

He’s tired. Does he still have legs? His eyes say yes, but are they really real if he can’t feel them anymore? One more step. His feet are dragging. He can’t seem to put one foot down right. How odd. He stops next to a wooden beam. Wasn’t he... looking for that? Was he? It’s hard to remember. Did he... want to do something with it? He lets go of—what, exactly? Something’s on his back, something so heavy and yet so precious. He needed to get somewhere, he remembers. But where? And why? The wooden beam was part of it, he’s sure. If he tries hard enough, he’ll remember. He always does. He never forgets. So, just... think. It’s easy, right? Just thinking. Someone mocked him once about it, he thinks. It was a little embarrassing. He puts a hand on the wooden beam. He’s wearing a gauntlet. He’s wearing a gauntlet? Didn’t he have a sword? How odd.

He hears sounds behind him. Steps. A lot of steps, actually. There aren’t supposed to be any steps. He closes his fist around the wooden beam. He has a gauntlet. His sword is gone. Is his cargo in danger? When the steps are close enough, he fastens his grip on the wooden beam and he pulls it out of the ground in one fell swoop, whipping it around to hit whoever has approached him. He’s countered, and the beam splinters, breaking in two. He growls and re-adjusts the beam, ready to stab rather than swing.

“Lord Phainon! Calm down!”

That voice... it sounds familiar. It could be a trick. It could be like Livia. Nobody will harm the cargo on his back. So he ignores the voice and ducks low, to feint towards his left. He doesn’t get countered this time, but

something akin to threads weave around him, hindering him from moving. He tries not to panic, but the dread is rising in his chest regardless.

He flexes his muscles and he won't be stopped. They want what he's carrying? Then they have to kill him first. It's just odd, that these threads feel familiar somehow, but they feel *wrong*. He can't truly describe it, but they're not *right*. So, he rips free of the flimsy threads and grabs the broken beam in both hands, stabbing forward only to hit empty air. They're fast, but that's alright. There's scarcely anyone faster than him in Okhema. The threads curl around his arm this time, pulling him back and forcing him to drop the beam.

"Stop resisting, Phainon!"

These voices are almost familiar, but he knows the tricks of the black tide. He won't fall for them again. These threads are a nuisance. He needs to find the source and get rid of them. Instead of lurching forwards, he jumps to the back, pulling his arm away until the thread breaks again. Something brushes against his cheek and he remembers to finish quickly. Every second wasted is a second slower back to Okhema. Two threats before him, and he won't be fast enough to outrun them both. If he were able to maim one, however... strangely enough, they seem to be attached to each other. He's never seen that tactic before. No matter.

He fixates his eyes on the initial aggressor; the one without the threads. He's not too used fighting with his fists alone, but he'll make do. He squats low, as low as the increased weight allows him, and then he jumps forth, aiming for the weapon. As he expects, it is simply raised in defence—what odd behaviour—and he clashes against it with purpose. Hmm. The wielder isn't weak. Why won't they attack properly?

He closes his fist around it, testing to see if he could break it but to no avail —he wishes his broken sword had been the same—before he rips it out of his assailant's hands. He hears a shocked gasp and he expects a bodily attack but none comes. How odd. He whirls around with the scythe—he knows this weapon. He does, he *does*. Clenching his jaw, he whirls around with the weapon, intending to cut down the thread-weaver. He is met with steel, and the steel stands firm but he'll win in a battle of attrition.

“Phainon!” A sharp voice cuts through the fog. “Cease your reckless behaviour!”

He knows that voice. He knows the tone too. But he has a mission. Twisting his hold on the scythe, he breaks their deadlock, and his enemy loses their weapon and before the sword can hit the ground, he’s turned the scythe around, ready to behead his opponent.

Yet, before he can succeed, something heavy rams into his arms and he yelps, dropping the scythe. Stupid, stupid, stupid! A warrior *never* drops their weapon!

“Snowy, *stop*!”

He growls, ready to tear the new interference off of his arm, but—the red makes him stop. He blinks, and stumbles a few steps back and frantically, he looks down to his chest. She’s—she’s still there, but... wait, that... that means...? He looks up again, but the two figures before him still remain foggy, but they’re approaching him, hands held up, but he can’t help but snarl a little. He squeezes his eyes shut and shakes his head, breathing through his teeth.

“Snowy, **we’re** here now. It’s okay. You can let go. You did good, Snowy.”

No... he can’t, not yet. “Okhema,” he replies, in lieu of answering, “I have to... they are...”

“It’s alright, Lord Phainon. We’ll take you there, I promise. We’ll take you to Okhema.”

He still shouldn’t give in. He should refuse, and be on his way again. But he knows these voices. He trusts these voices. And despite it all, they’re still so gentle with him, as if he deserves it.

Why didn’t you save us?

“Mydei,” he says, “he got... I tried, I did... his head, I tried, and, and Tribbie, she... she’s warm.”

“Don’t worry, Lord Phainon, I’m here. I’ll take care of them. You carried them so far, let me carry them for you now.”

But he shouldn’t allow that, right? These burdens are his to bear, and if he can’t even carry *this*, then how could he ever hope to bear the world? He’s so tired. Maybe it’s okay to give in just once, right? It’s going to be okay, right? He can still be the Deliverer.

“Alright,” he agrees with a weak voice, and a warm hand grabs his, pulling him forward. He goes willingly. The others are behind him, and he tries to not raise his hackles at that. He knows them. He knows these voices. They won’t hurt him. It’s just hard to... remember that.

He blinks, and he stands in Okhema. Looking up, he can see Kephale in the distance. So, he’s... made it? He’s made it back to Okhema?

“Lord Phainon,” the gentle voice urges him on, “please keep following me.”

He simply nods and follows two bobbing pigtails. He knows them, doesn’t he? Things are way too fuzzy in his head. There’s a bed in front of him, and he blankly stares at it.

“Lord Phainon,” the pigtails speak, “please put Lord Mydei on the bed. Lady Aglaea can take Lady Tribbie, alright?”

He doesn’t react when Tribbie is taken out of the makeshift sling. His chest feels cold, all of sudden, but he’s been given a task. He reaches behind him to hold onto Mydei, while he undoes the knots in the front, until the coat flutters to the ground. He leans to the side and almost topples over, as he needs to adjust to Mydei’s weight with only one arm. He hesitates for a moment, as he goes about how to best do this. He walks over to the bed and turns his torso, trying to slide Mydei onto the bed as gently as he can. Looking at him for the first time again after titans know how long, he was worried that Mydei’s head would’ve... slipped off, or something, but it looks—good? He hopes, at least.

“You must be hurt, Lord Phainon. But, can you tell me what happened? Anything I need to look out for?”

Hurt? No, he’s not hurt. He can’t remember. He shakes his head and then turns to Tribbie, pointing at her.

“She... I think, I think she has a concussion but she. She didn’t stop breathing.” Maybe he should’ve tried harder waking her up. Didn’t he read somewhere that someone with a concussion shouldn’t sleep?

He turns back to Mydei. “He... I think... I think he got concussed too. He didn’t. He didn’t see the monster. I, I tried, but I... I didn’t have anything. I didn’t know. I didn’t—I didn’t want him to come back without a head.”

“Thank you, Lord Phainon,” pigtails—no, no, Hyacine—says, “and what about you? You’ve done so great, Lord Phainon, please let me take care of you now.”

Take care of him? No. No, she has more important things to take care of. He shakes his head again, tired. How long has it been? It would be embarrassing if he’d only wandered for like, two days.

“It’s... it’s fine,” he says, rubbing his temple, “but I... I think I should sleep. I’m—I’m sorry for attacking. We, we were ambushed, I think, before, and I —“ He stops himself by coughing hard and he slams his fist on his chest.

“Don’t worry yourself, child,” thread-weaver—no, no, Aglaea—says from behind him, “rest first, would you? The report can wait a little longer. But please answer Hyacine first. Where are you hurt?”

She’s asking like she’s expecting an injury. How could he be her most trusted warrior if he always returns with injuries? He can’t remember the last time Castorice got hurt. But it would be hard to deny all the blood, wouldn’t it? Not to mention his behaviour... he’s so tired.

“How long were we gone?” He asks instead.

“**We** lost contact with Tribbie about a week ago. It was hard to locate you, Snowy. You move really fast, you know?”

“Sorry,” he apologises, abashed. “I... got shot in the leg, I think. They’re all numb. B—but Mydei and Lady Tribbie should come first. I’m fine. I can just sleep it off, yeah?”

“No, Lord Phainon. Please let me have a look at it, alright? I know you must be tired, but please—for my own sake of mind.”

She’s not even guilt-tripping him. Well, maybe a little, but she means well. And his leg is fine, isn’t it? As long as she leaves his midriff alone—he closes his eyes and nods, sitting down on a chair. He won’t let himself relax just yet, because then how the hell would he get back up? Hyacine settles in next to him and she gently cuts a hole in his pants to inspect the impact wound. Huh... the shaft must’ve broken off at some point, he didn’t even notice. He should’ve pulled the arrow out before... now poor Hyacine will need to dig it out.

“Are there any other symptoms besides the numbness, Lord Phainon? Weakness, perhaps, or some seizing?”

“No,” he replies, “just numb. I think I rolled my ankle at some point? I can’t remember...”

Hyacine nods, and she gingerly takes his ankles in hand, rolling them both carefully, testing. Maybe he should try to give some rough report to Aglaea, but he just can’t bring himself to do so. He should, he knows, because he has downtime while Hyacine works, but... he’s so tired. Aglaea will understand, right?

“I think it will be alright,” Hyacine then says, standing up. “I will get you some cream for your ankle and the wound, please apply them at least twice a day. It seems it was truly just a numbing poison, even though I wonder how it persisted for so long... ideally, it should go away on its own in a couple days. If the numbness persists or gets worse please come back to see me right away, Lord Phainon.”

He just nods. Did she get the arrowhead out? He can’t remember. Doesn’t matter anyway, right? It’ll be fine. He can look later. He feels Hyacine’s

hand on his forehead and he tries hard not to flinch. He’s not usually this jumpy, is he?

“Hmm,” she concludes, “you do have a bit of a fever. Cassie, can you make sure he gets home safe? I want to look at Lady Tribbie and Lord Mydei now.”

“Of course,” Castorice says, “can you stand, Lord Phainon?”

He groans, and pushes himself up. He slips the cream into his pocket and turns towards the door. He feels too light, like he might float away. A week... it can’t have been that long. Maybe time was distorted in the temple? But Tribbie didn’t mention losing her connection to Trianne and Trinnon... weird. But in the end, what does it matter?

“Lord Phainon,” Castorice says, “you are a terrific fighter.”

“Huh?”

“I mean,” she laughs, “facing off against you truly made me fear for my life. I keep thinking that if you’d had your sword, we wouldn’t have stood a chance. Not even Lady Aglaea’s threads could stop you.”

Oh... right. “I’m—sorry. Did I hurt you? It wasn’t my intention, I just—“

“No, no, don’t worry. It just occurred to me that it’s been a long time since I saw you fight. You truly are impressive, Lord Phainon!”

He *knows* Castorice wouldn’t lie to him. But it still feels like hollow praise. How could he be impressive if he failed to protect both Tribbie and Mydei from harm?

“Miss Castorice,” he says and she turns, smiling. “I would wish to bathe first. I promise I’ll head home straight after, so there’s no need to wait on me.”

“Oh... are you certain? I can wait for you, Lord Phainon! I would offer to assist you, but, well... but I can make sure nobody would disturb you!”

He thinks a little, then nods. “I would appreciate that, Miss Castorice, thank you. I’ll make haste, too. I’m sure there are important things you must be doing, as well.”

“Nothing is more important than you right now, Lord Phainon,” she smiles gently and it almost *hurts*. But still, he smiles in return and they make their way to the baths. He feels strangely naked without his coat. He can see people try to greet him from afar, but he’s trying hard to ignore them. If he makes eye-contact, he’ll stop and talk to them. A week... it feels so much longer. He feels so much older than when he started. Maybe that feeling will go away once he’s slept. Should he eat something? He’s not very hungry, and maybe Mydei has some stuff still left in his fridge. If he doesn’t... well, he’ll live.

“Lord Phainon,” Castorice turns to him, “will you give me your clothes? I’ll see if I can salvage them... and in the meantime, I’ll bring you something fresh to wear.”

“Oh... no, no, you mustn’t make such an effort for me, Miss Castorice. It’s fine, truly.”

She shakes her head. “I insist. You’ll feel much better wearing fresh clothes, believe me.”

She’s probably right, too. But still... looking at her, though, makes him give up. “Fine,” he relents, “but I think it’s better if you just throw them away. There’s bound to be a lot of blood on there... and, uh. Could you. I, I mean —“

“Yes, I’ll get some of Lord Mydei’s clothes for you, don’t worry,” she laughs. “I’ll be back as soon as I can. Just please don’t fall asleep in the waters, alright?”

He nods and hands her his tattered clothes after he’s undressed. He waits until her steps have faded into silence, and then he dashes into the Hero’s Bath. The wound on his stomach looks—well, he wouldn’t want Hyacine to see it, that’s for certain. It started to half-heal, but the edges are all red and puffy and he still retains the heaviness from it. He taps one foot into the

water first; an old-born habit, before he sinks into the bath. This bath always made sure that the Chrysos Heirs would never fall to the corruption of the black tide. Truth be told, he's not sure how it works or why *this* water specifically can do it, but why ask questions nobody could answer anyway?

However, as he sinks into the waters, his blood begins to burn. He chokes on nothing, gasping for air he can't take in and it feels like his body is trying to devour itself. He can't—he can't be corrupted, right? No, no, that can't be... it's got to be something else. But the pain keeps pulsing, keeps rushing through his very core and oh, he *burns*. Still, he tries to endure, because surely, if he stays in just long enough, the waters will burn the corruption away, won't they?

However, after too short a time, he throws himself out of the bath, convulsing on the floor. Oh, how pathetic, but it hurts so *much*. He curls up on himself, wrapping his arms around his stomach, barely caring where his towel goes. After the initial pain has passed, he uncurls and looks at his hands. There's blood on them, but the blood is—it's black. He's not supposed to bleed black. Wasn't the water meant to cleanse him? Why did it burn him instead? He whimpers and curls back up, waiting for the pain to pass. He has to get up before Castorice returns. He has to... oh, he's so tired.

"...non! Lord Phainon!"

He blinks his eyes open to gaze upon the blurry vision of the baths. Huh? What happened? He turns his head towards the voice and blinks lazily. When did Castorice come back?

"Miss... Castorice...?"

"Lord Phainon! Are you alright? Should I go get Hyacine? Was the water too hot? I, I came back and you were lying on the floor!"

He blinks and turns his head away again. It hurts. He's still tired. "No, no..." he reassures her, "I'm just—I'm just tired. Maybe a bath was a bad idea, I'm sorry. Do you... have some clothes for me?"

Castorice nods, lifting a red robe in her hands. Oh, she really did get some of Mydei's clothes... how nice. He nods in response and sits up. Castorice puts the clothes on a nearby chair, so not to get them wet and then turns around to give him some privacy. He heaves himself over to the chair, trying to stifle a groan. It takes entirely too long to put the garments on, but ah, well. He's allowed, right?

"I'm. I'm done, Miss Castorice. Forgive me for keeping you waiting."

"No, no!" She's quick to say. "I'm sorry I can't help more. But, if you'd allow me..."

With a bright smile, she extends her wooden hand. Right, he remembers making that in the Grove. It's nice to see she still has them. He laughs a little, and takes her hand, allowing her to lead him. He still can't close his eyes, in case she has to stop suddenly, but at least he won't need to concentrate on walking like this.

"This is Mydei's house," he says when they arrive.

"Yes," she agrees, "it's where you wanted to go, isn't it?"

"Fair enough," he chuckles. "Thank you, Miss Castorice. Please let Miss Hyacine and Lady Aglaea know I made it here safely? I'll report to Lady Aglaea tomorrow in full, I promise. If Kephale wills it, Lady Tribbie will have recovered by then, as well."

She smiles and bows a little. "Of course, Lord Phainon. Please don't hesitate to contact me or someone else should you require anything. I'll come by tomorrow again to check on you, if we haven't heard from you by then. Rest well, Lord Phainon."

He nods in response and walks inside the house. The air is a little stale, but he's lacking the strength to open the windows. Tomorrow he'll do it, he swears. But right now, all he wants to do is sleep, so he sprawls over Mydei's bed and tries to fall asleep.

However, as tired as he is, his mind still races. He's still not sure what exactly happened in that damned temple, or what the purpose of it even was. These mirrors... how do they work? *Why* did they work? And what did they want? He doesn't understand; and these symbols—these symbols he's never seen before, but that still feel so familiar. Where did the monster come from all of a sudden? Was it all just some elaborate ploy? But this seems way above their usual abilities... his head hurts. He's still wearing Mydei's gauntlet. He hopes that Mydei wakes up soon; that he didn't mess up or that Hyacine can fix it. He really tried, didn't he...?

He'll deal with—with the corruption tomorrow. If he just takes enough baths, then it'll go away. He *can't* tell Aglaea or Hyacine; he doesn't want to worry them even further. Tomorrow, he will stand tall before the Lady Goldweaver and report to her what happened and he'll show her the pictures he took and then maybe someone will have some answers and maybe they can blow the place to bits. He'll apologise to Tribbie and Mydei as soon as they wake up and hopefully, they'll forgive him. He'll be upset at Mydei for dying in front of him again and Mydei will scoff and tell him that it's his fault for not being faster. And then they can forget that forsaken temple and go back to how things were before.

He closes his eyes and falls into uneasy slumber.

"Little Deliverer... you can never reach your destination, for it is nothing but a lie. It's an everlasting labyrinth of mirrors that reflect you a thousand-fold. For freedom; for truth; for deliverance*, one must shatter the mirror. But are you strong enough? Do you yet burn hot enough?*
The ever-raging flame inside the cavity of your chest... when will it sweep the land like wildfire? The Scourge of Amphoreus will ascend into the heavens, for to slay a god, one must become a god themselves.
Crown yourself in their golden blood and destroy every blight in the universe. O Khaslana, son of Amphoreus, do you still remember them?
Sing, o aeons, for your eternal hymn will shatter under the footsteps of his golden rage.

Little Deliverer, do you still remember why you started your journey?"

Chapter 9: once tomorrow comes

Chapter Notes

> Yaaaay we reached the end just as my keyboard is about to die!!
> I don't have anything special to say, I think, other than thank you! This wouldn't have gotten this long (and so out of hand) without you. So I hope you enjoy this last chapter! Let me know your thoughts, okay~?
>
> now I need to focus on myphaifest hhhh pray for me!

Mydeimos can hear the wind before anything else. He’s not sure where he is or what’s even happened, but—the wind sounds soft and he can smell no blood, so it can’t be a battlefield. He tries to remember but all he comes up with are blanks. Hadn’t he been with Phainon? Where’s Phainon? He can’t feel anyone holding his hand or hitting his chest. Where is the Deliverer?

“...dei?”

A voice. He’s not sure who it belongs to, but voices are good. He tries to open his eyes, and he groans. This never used to be so damn hard. If Phainon were here, it’d be easier. Maybe it’ll help if he deludes the Deliverer by his side.

“Hey now, Mydeimos! Can’t even open your eyes properly? Guess that means I’ll win our blinking competition! Bow to your champion!”

Asshole. Under extreme difficulties, Mydei manages to open his eyes and is greeted by the blurry visage of the sky. Blurry blobs shove themselves into his field of sight immediately and he grumbles, frowning. Can a man not wake in peace?

“Little Dei!”

He blinks a couple times before turning his head, staring straight into Tribbie’s face.

“You,” he rasps, “...Deliverer?”

“He’ll be by soon,” a new voice says and he blinks, identifying the new blob as Hyacine. She smiles warmly at him, coming closer. “How do you feel?”

“Groggy,” he replies: his body feels like it’s made out of lead. “How long was I out? What even happened?”

“Hmm, about three weeks I think? That’s when we brought you back here, anyway. I have to admit, you had me worried! It’s never taken you so long to come back!”

Three weeks? She’s right, it should never take this long... the longest it’s taken so far had been a *day*. How in the world could it have been *three weeks*? Oh, Phainon must be so mad.

“Snowy said that you... you got beheaded, Dei.”

He stills and turns his head to look at Trinnon. Oh, all three of them are here. “What... did you say?”

“Please, Dei, don’t make me repeat myself. It’s what Snowy told us.”

“Yes,” Hyacine nods, “she’s right. And it—it really happened. Lord Phainon did his best to... re-attach you to your body and given his limited knowledge *and* limited tools, he performed spectacularly. However, it was still gruesome to see. I keep hoping that the shock made Lord Phainon forget the details.”

Mydei gingerly touches his neck and he is met with—a band of sorts? He frowns and feels around it. If he’s not mistaken...

“Lord Phainon used his leather band as a stabiliser. I wanted to give it back to him but he started panicking when I went to undo the clasp so I opted to leave it on. It’s still odd to see him without it.”

“What happened?”

“According to Snowy, something knocked all of you out and gave you and Tribbie a concussion,” Trianne supplies, “then he heard some monsters and went to fight them. You apparently woke up and went to check on Snowy but you... didn’t see the monster and died. Snowy took care of the rest of the monsters, punched you a way out and wandered around until we could find him. Snowy was scary, you know? Trianne really thought he’d kill Agy and Little Cas! Everyone’s real glad he’s our friend.”

Phainon... all alone against an entire horde of enemies, while also having watched Mydei fall? However much time has passed, Phainon will not be in a good state. How is Mydei going to make up for this?

“Did he get wounded? Is he alright?”

“Honestly,” Hyacine sighs, looking uncomfortable, “I was hoping you could help me with that. He hates to bother me, when he never *could* bother me. I keep telling myself that it’s just stress and the like, but—I’m only two steps away from chaining him here to force-feed him. Seeing you up and about will do wonders! Now, do you want to try standing up? I and Lord Phainon did some exercises with you while you were sleeping, so let’s see if they’ve helped.”

He nods, taking her hands as she helps him up. Yes, his legs definitely feel like he hasn’t used them in a while. He *can* stand, but... it feels rather wobbly. However, it shouldn’t take long to regain functionality in them. Hyacine asks him to move his arms, his torso and most importantly, his neck. It all feels fine; if a little stiff. He should definitely ease himself back into training slowly. Knowing Phainon, he’ll have overdone it while Mydei had been gone, so going slow would probably do him some good, too.

“...Mydei?”

His eyes widen and he turns his head at that voice. There, at the entrance of the courtyard, stands Phainon and by Nikador, he looks *terrible.* Eyes sunken in, cheeks hollowed out, skin pale. He wears most of his usual get-up, but instead of his white coat, he has one of Mydei’s robes wrapped around him; and his right arm dons Mydei’s gauntlet.

He’s so beautifully perfect it’s unfair.

“Deliverer,” he whispers and he lets go of Hyacine, to walk over to Phainon before he simply breaks out in a run. Phainon himself can’t avert his eyes and he takes small steps towards Mydei, clearly not believing what he sees. Mydei slams into Phainon with all his might, absolutely uncaring of where they are and the impact shock sends Phainon backwards on his back as Mydei ravages his mouth.

Desperate, his hands hold onto every part of Phainon they can reach and after slight hesitation due to shock, Phainon wraps his arms around Mydei, returning his kiss in kind.

“Deliverer,” Mydei pants into Phainon’s open mouth, “oh, my Deliverer.”

“Mydei,” Phainon breathes, “it’s really...? Are you—are you okay? Your, your neck, is it fine? I... Mydei, I—“

“Shush,” Mydei whispers, kissing him again. “I am well. Titans, Deliverer, you should wear nothing but my clothes ever again.”

Phainon blinks, frowns in confusion and then laughs.

“Oh Mydei,” he sobs, “oh *Mydei*.”

“Is it really okay?” Phainon asks for the nth time. “Maybe you should go back and—“

“Deliverer,” Mydei interrupts him. “You were *there* when Hyacine said I’m good to go. I’m even still wearing your little collar, so what’s there to worry about?”

“It’s not a collar...”

Mydei laughs softly and turns over from where they lie in bed and he gently cups Phainon’s cheek. Tomorrow, he’ll make a meal plan for both of them.

He’s sure Aglaea will agree not to send them out on mission for at least two weeks.

“You still wear my gauntlet.”

“Huh? Oh, yeah... sorry, it, uh, it became kind of a habit. I, uh, I put it on to... do stuff. And then, ah, then I punched a wall with it. Sorry, I’ll take it off right away—“

“*Deliverer*,” he reprimands, “it’s fine. I keep your collar, you keep my gauntlet. It looks good on you. You, however, look *terrible*. Has it truly been three weeks?”

“Yes,” Phainon admits after a short pause. “Longer than that, I think. I’m not sure how much time passed after I left the temple.”

“Speaking of it—did Aglaea send someone there to investigate?”

Phainon remains quiet for a bit, idly playing with the gauntlet in a way that tells Mydei it’s become a habit. “No,” the man then says, “I told her about it but when she sent people there... Mydei, there was nothing. *Nothing*. Even the pictures I took are *gone*. It’s like the place never existed. I wanted to go back myself, to confirm, but Lady Aglaea strictly forbade me from leaving Okhema.”

Phainon looks genuinely distressed and Mydei frowns. It’s impossible for a place to just straight up vanish, isn’t it? Especially if it’s underground. Mydei reaches out his hand and brushes it through Phainon’s hair. It’s not as soft as he remembers and just another sign how easy it is for Phainon to neglect himself.

“We’ll go together,” he says, “when we’re both better.”

“Okay... wait! I’m fine. I didn’t get hurt; I just ran a little fever for a while.”

Mydei doesn’t mention Hyacine’s concern to him. He sighs and moves his hand to Phainon’s left arm, wrapped in a thick bandage.

“Does it not ache?”

“I... it’s nothing, Mydeimos, I promise. I even put some cream on it, so it’s fine, isn’t it?”

Oh, *cream*. Wonderful. The famous miracle cream, said to cure any and all ailments. But well, at least it’s something. Gently, he lifts the arm and reaches over, pressing a kiss on the bandage. It’s not spotted, at least, so he’ll take that little mercy.

“I’m sorry,” he says, “that I wasn’t there to take care of you.”

“It’s fine,” Phainon mutters, but he doesn’t tug his arm away. Mydei sighs and closes his eyes. Phainon smells the same and honestly, he shouldn’t miss it so, having slept all this time. He still can’t wrap his head around the fact it’s been three whole *weeks*.

“Are you... really okay? I know what Hyacine said, but—“

“Come,” Mydei replies, “feel for yourself, then.”

Hesitant, Phainon turns over and gently presses his palm against Mydei’s neck. He rubs his thumb into the skin and strokes along the side reverently. Mydei simply watches Phainon as he does so. He looks tired—when has he slept last? He wishes Phainon would put himself first sometimes, because what good would it do if he were to collapse in the streets? It’s alright, though, because Mydei is going to make sure the Deliverer gets enough rest, now.

“I have to tell you something,” Phainon whispers, cradling his hand back to himself. Mydei already misses the contact. He nods at Phainon, urging him to keep going.

“I—a while ago, Zacharias kissed me.”

Maybe Mydei should be furious. Maybe he should get angry, but instead he feels—calm, almost.

“Did you like it?”

“No,” Phainon replies, “I don’t know. I was sick and drunk, so it’s a little blurry. I just—if you want to go—“

Mydei reaches over for his face and pulls him close, kissing him sweet and gentle on the mouth. It’s a closed-mouth kiss, born from devotion and reverence, not their usual fire and desire. Phainon doesn’t put his hands on Mydei’s body, and he is hesitant in returning the kiss proper.

“This,” Mydei whispers against his lips, “is how I and Hephaestion kissed. Do you remember what our first kiss was like?”

Phainon’s eyes are always so big, even when they’re clouded from too little sleep and too much stress. Looking into these eyes, and Mydei doesn’t even need Kephale’s Eternal Dawn Device. He’s got his own little pocket sun right here.

“Like, our first *kiss* or our *first* kiss?”

Mydei pouts. He and Phainon have had a physical relationship long before they’ve had a romantic one, so they fucked first and kissed later. Of course, during sex they had kissed sometimes, but it hadn’t meant anything back then. The Deliverer is such an ass to bring that back.

“Don’t ruin the mood, Deliverer. So: do you still remember our first kiss?”

Phainon nods, and smiles deviously. Mydei smirks and pulls Phainon back in, pressing his lips against the other man’s again. He starts slow, cradling Phainon’s face in his hands and the man finally, *finally* puts his hands on Mydei’s chest, where they belong. The tension ebbs out of Mydei’s shoulders and he pulls Phainon closer; flush to his chest before he moves his hand to grab a fistful of snow-white hair. Then, he opens his mouth and pushes his tongue between Phainon’s teeth, claiming his mouth as his own, pulling Phainon even closer. Phainon sighs in contentment and Mydei rolls him over on his back, putting his whole body-weight onto the Deliverer, pushing him deep into the mattress. Phainon’s hands find their way onto Mydei’s back and only Phainon, *only ever Phainon*. Mydei presses his hips down, straight into the man’s groin and he sighs into Phainon’s mouth. He

angles his head a different way and burrows deeper into their kiss, devouring the man before him.

They part, and Phainon breathes hard with his eyes closed, cheeks flushed. Never has Mydei seen a prettier man in his lifetime.

“Tell me,” he pants in tandem with Phainon, “did Zacharias kiss you just the same?”

Phainon shakes his head. “No,” he breathes, “only you. Only ever you.”

“Then don’t fret, little Deliverer,” Mydei soothes, “because only I can give you this.”

Phainon huffs out a breathy laugh. “You forgive me, then?”

Mydei gently caresses his cheek. Phainon, for some suicidal reason, likes to jump from roof to roof. *Like a hero in the stories,* the man would claim. He’s given all of Okhema a heart attack at least once and Mydei is sure Aglaea doesn’t even see it anymore. Anyway, he’s dared Mydei countless times to see who can jump further and even though Mydei does not share Phainon’s tendencies, he still agreed. It landed them both in the Twilight Courtyard with a hefty reprimand from Hyacine.

Phainon dared him to see who can hold their breath the longest. Mydei said yes. Phainon dared him to see who could clear a table faster. Mydei said yes. Phainon dared him to see who could heat a kettle of water faster. Mydei said yes. Phainon dared him to see who could cross all of Okhema faster. Mydei said yes. Phainon dared him to see who could maintain a handstand longer. Mydei said yes. Phainon dared him to see who could read a book faster. Mydei said yes.

“There’s *nothing*,” he says, “Phainon of Aedes Elysiae, *nothing* I wouldn’t do for you.”

Phainon’s eyes go wide and Mydei shuffles back on the bed, pulling the man up with him. He drags him to the edge of the bed, his legs swung over

and Mydei goes to kneel on the floor. He *knows* Phainon is watching him with confusion in his eyes but that doesn't stop him.

He gently cradles Phainon's bare foot on his hands and he bends down, pressing his lips down on the arch in a solemn promise. Phainon's breath hitches and he tries to retract his foot, but Mydei's hold is stronger.

"I've told you before," he whispers, lifting his head to look back up again. "You are *it*, Deliverer. In this world and the next, you are my only equal; the one person I will always yearn for—to fight, to love, to hold, it doesn't matter. You could burn the world and I would know you have purpose. Maybe I would not agree, but I trust none more than you. I am *yours*, no matter what and I will walk to the ends of this earth if I have to. I love you, *I love you*, even if you spelled nothing but doom for us. I am yours, and I pray you'd be mine as well."

Phainon breathes only, and Mydei can hear the subtle hitches in it.

"Marry me, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae," he whispers gently against the man's shin, "marry me and claim the heart that's always been in your hands."

Phainon inhales and it sounds suspiciously like a choked sob. Mydei places a kiss on his knee and remains kneeling, looking up at his Deliverer. His eyes are wet with unshed tears. Mydei knows he should probably have talked to Aglaea and Krateros both first, but those are problems for later; and it's not like he's planned this whole thing.

Mydei pushes himself up and cups Phainon's cheek, kissing him. The man's eventual answer doesn't even really matter, because regardless of what he'll say, the truth won't change. Gently, he pushes Phainon back and leans over him, still kissing him deep. Finally, Phainon starts to kiss him back and it develops in the way it usually does: a competition in a battle for dominance. The kiss turns hot and searing and Mydei lowers his weight further down onto Phainon. Phainon groans into his mouth, and Mydei's hands wander down, to the hem of Phainon's shorts.

“Mydei,” Phainon pants as he wanders down the Deliverer’s body, pressing kisses into skin and cloth.

“Shh,” Mydei soothes when he reaches Phainon’s half-hard dick. He licks his lips in anticipation, and he opens his mouth to close his lips around the pretty cock. Phainon whimpers and his legs kick out by instinct until Mydei wraps his arms around the beautiful thighs and holds them still. Slowly, he takes more and more of Phainon’s dick inside his mouth until it hits the back of his throat and he sighs in satisfaction. Beneath him, Phainon trembles. Mydei hollows out his cheeks and begins sucking.

Phainon groans and arches his back, pushing deeper into Mydei’s throat and he *loves* it. Feeling Phainon twitch on his tongue is a high he keeps chasing. Above him, Phainon pants and chants Mydei’s name until he lets out a stifled scream, spilling down Mydei’s throat. Mydei sucks him through the aftershocks, after which he releases Phainon’s member with a nice *pop* and he seats himself upright, feasting upon the view. Phainon’s body blushes deep, and he is quivering with the remnants of pleasure shooting through his veins.

Freeing himself from his own pants, he eagerly pushes his cock against Phainon’s entrance. Phainon whimpers and he scrambles his hands down—pulling down his shirt further, oddly enough—and he grabs his own thighs, spreading his legs wide. What a whore.

“Missed me?”

“Mydei,” Phainon whines, “*please*.”

With a smirk, Mydei pushes into the tight hole, and both of them groan in relief. He keeps going until he bottoms out and he breathes deep, relishing in the feeling.

“So good, Deliverer,” he praises, “just like you were made for me.”

Phainon bucks his hips in answer and Mydei takes that as his cue to start thrusting. He’s not doing it very fast—after all, it’s been a while. Hurting Phainon on accident is very far off his list. The Deliverer keeps whining and

Mydei is considering pressing his mouth shut, but he *likes* the noises Phainon makes, so he remains at a dilemma.

Moaning unsatisfied, Phainon locks his legs behind Mydei and with a rather impressive show of strength, flips them over so that Phainon ends up on top. Immediately, Phainon begins to bounce up and down at rapid speed, seeking his own satisfaction. Mydei watches in rapt attendance before lifting himself back up, wrapping his arms around Phainon and kissing him deep.

“Can’t get enough of me? Do you need me deeper?”

Phainon whimpers and pulls Mydei’s hair. “More,” he demands, “*harder*.”

So Mydei gives him more, harder. Phainon yelps and he bares his neck and Mydei takes the opportunity to sink his fangs into sweet flesh. He moans around it while Phainon ruts and bounces harder in his lap, and they’re both so, so close.

Screaming, Phainon tightens his legs around Mydei’s hips and Mydei himself groans in deep satisfaction as Phainon clenches around him hard; and he spills himself so deep inside he hopes it’ll mark Phainon from within.

Out of breath, they still attempt to kiss each other, but they keep missing and they laugh in exhaustion.

“Yes,” Phainon pants then into Mydei’s ear. “Tomorrow,” he continues, “let’s get married once tomorrow comes.”

*

Mydei wakes slowly. His pillow is breathing. In all honesty, that’s rather unusual. His pillows are usually stuffed with feathers, not lungs. He blinks a couple times before he lifts his head to be greeted by Phainon’s sleeping

face. Oh. That is *most* unusual. Eternal insomniac Phainon sleeping in for once?

Smiling, Mydei leans on his arms and watches Phainon sleep. He looks better asleep, although the dark circles under his eyes stand out. Gently, Mydei brushes his thumb over Phainon's cheek and thinks about a suitable meal plan. His general plan is to make sure Phainon eats, and then to get him napping. The more he rests, the better his body will be able to recover. He bends down and nuzzles his nose against the Deliverer. Phainon pulls a face in his sleep and turns his head away.

Chuckling softly, Mydei sits up. He's tempted to remove the large bandage around the man's torso, but he refrains. He's seen it last night, but because he hadn't wanted to ruin the mood—and because he believed it to be from Phainon's self-harm—he had left it unmentioned. Now, though... it *is* a rather large bandage and Phainon has never resorted to his stomach before. What made him do it? The cuts on his arms and legs are by no means old, but they aren't as numerous that he would have run out of space. Maybe it was desperation? After all, he doesn't know what really happened—and some part of him believes *nobody* knows.

"Whatever am I going to do with you," Mydei whispers and brushes his hand through Phainon's hair. It's a little oily and Mydei is hardly surprised that Phainon straight up forgot to take care of himself. No matter. Mydei is back now, and the Deliverer will be cared for, whether he likes it or not.

He leans down again and presses a soft kiss against Phainon's slightly heated forehead. It's alright, Phainon runs hot a lot of times. Again, nothing a good rest won't fix. Hesitating, Mydei gets out of bed and quietly dresses himself. He washes down quickly and then heads into the kitchen to prepare some breakfast. He'd make honey cakes, but since he's not sure when the Deliverer will wake, he decides against it. He makes sandwiches instead, and in the worst scenario, the Deliverer will have to suffer through some sogginess. He'll live, regardless.

He places the plate on the counter, nicely visible, and he heads back into the bedchamber for a spell; just to see if Phainon had woken. The man has

scarcely moved, and Mydei huffs with a smile. Just how ragged has he run himself?

“I’ll return soon,” he promises, “eat the sandwich I made, or I’ll choke it down your throat.”

Successfully threatened, he turns and leaves. His first order of business is the detachment. Possibly four weeks out of commission must’ve run them down, and he must make appearances to placate them. He speaks with a few people, and each one sighs in relief upon seeing him, but they all promise they have done him proud in his absence. He wonders how much Aglaea has let seep through—do they know he perished? Do they believe him having been on a mission? He won’t ask, as not to risk expose himself, and perhaps Aglaea can shine light on it later. He finds Krateros as a last stop.

“My lord,” he is greeted and Mydei nods in acknowledgment.

“Krateros. How have things been? The people tell me nothing but good news.”

“Yes, nothing much happened in your absence. That Deliverer of yours helped us out whenever he could, although I must admit—he would not speak of your whereabouts, and he himself looked worn thin. Indulge your old teacher?”

Hm. So his death had been kept secret. Perhaps it was for the best. “Not currently,” he answers honestly, “I wish to speak to the Goldweaver first. Since—returning, I haven’t had the chance. But rest assured, once I am able, you will get the truth.”

Krateros sighs deep, and Mydei didn’t expect anything else. It must be frustrating, to be kept in the dark like this. But he finds himself agreeing with Aglaea—he, too, is hesitant to share past events. How would they react, if Mydeimos the Undying has stayed dead for weeks when normally he stays dead for minutes? It might be too frightening—they rely on his immortality more than he does.

“Very well then, my lord. And that Deliverer boy of yours... is he faring well?”

Mydei crosses his arms. “He wears himself thin as usual, especially considering I was not here to knock some sense into him. Fret not, teacher. I am surprised you ask after his well-being—do you not consider him the same as the rest of the *Okheman scum*?”

Krateros clenches his jaw. “He gained your respect, my lord, so he gained mine as well. In this city; I’d be a fool to turn a helping hand away, no matter how much it grates me.”

“He is an Outlander, much like us, and you know this,” Mydei counters, “if not for him, the Goldweaver would have us placed in the pig stalls.”

“If you would insinuate I was unkind to him, my lord, you are mistaken. He integrated into Okheman society seamlessly—what man that loves his home abandons it so easily?”

There is no home left for Phainon to return to. Even in ruins, Castrum Kremnos still exists, and could potentially be rebuilt. Aedes Elysiae, however, has fallen to the black tide completely. Mydei’s people are a burden, yes, but one he is glad to shoulder. Kremnos will continue to exist without him, whereas Aedes Elysiae only exists within Phainon now. Is it fair to say he abandoned it? Lowering his eyes, he thinks of golden blood on clean tiles and thinks that maybe Krateros isn’t *all* wrong.

“The Deliverer will never abandon his home, of that, you can be certain.”

He bids his farewells and turns to head to the Grand Craftsmaster. On the way there, his thoughts wander to his mother. He had never truly understood why she had clung to her husband so desperately; why she had plead with him instead of simply ending him before he could’ve tossed Mydei into the river. But now, he thinks, he gets it. If it were him and Phainon in that situation—Mydei, too, would cling to the version of Phainon he would remember. Gods forbid, but if Phainon ever went mad... Mydei might plead with him just like Gorgo had done. Phainon would

never, Mydei knows, but then again, he’s sure Gorgo had thought the same of Eurypon.

“A rare sight, the crown prince is.”

“Good day, Chartonus. Are you faring well?”

“Indeed, I am. Your return, I am pleased to see. Need something, you do?”

Mydei chuckles. Straight to the point, just how he likes it. No senseless small talk Phainon is so fond of.

“I do indeed. You know you excel in weaponry but I wondered... is jewellery in your arsenal?”

“Another earring, the prince is looking for?”

Mydei shakes his head, stepping a little closer. “Not quite,” he says in a quieter tone, signalling Chartonus to bend down a little. “Would you be able to craft a ring?”

Chartonus moves his head and looks at him a while, not answering. The armour makes it impossible to see his face, but Mydei is not one to back down.

“Craft, I can. For the Deliverer, it is? Silver, a good colour on him?”

Mydei nods curtly and Chartonus takes Mydei’s right hand, inspecting the finger size. It doesn’t have to fit perfectly right away; they can always come back here and have it resized. Mydei just—wants to have it. He wants *Phainon* to have it.

“There should be flowers on it. Can you do that?”

“Hmm,” Chartonus hums. “Tomorrow, you return. Tomorrow, I have samples. Then, you pick. For the Deliverer, the prettiest ring.”

Mydei smiles and nods. “Thank you, Chartonus. I will make sure to pay you extra for the sudden request.”

“No,” Chartonus denies, “friend, you are. Friend, the Deliverer is. Like to remember, the Deliverer reading a book on mountain-folk in the forge. Sad he was, for Geokles and Terravox. The materials, you pay. No more.”

Mydei smiles again and bows his head. If—*when*—they have a wedding ceremony, he’ll make sure to reserve a special spot for Chartonus. When he goes to meet Aglaea probably later today, he absolutely *has* to bring this up. *He* wants to be the one to tell her, especially after he didn’t even ask her blessing beforehand. He wonders if Phainon has texted Castorice or Hyacine.

He starts walking away from the forge, thinking if he should go back home to Phainon first, or head to Aglaea immediately. Maybe back to Phainon, just to make sure he ate the sandwich and Mydei doesn’t have to shove it up his ass. If he returns and the thing is still on the counter—

“Little lion!”

Cipher crashes into him so very unlike her and she scrambles at his chest, clearly not having meant to collide with him like that.

“Cipher? What—“

“No, no time, just hold on!”

She holds him tight and starts to run. Mydei fumbles and clambers on her in the end, hoping not to hurl. Where is she taking him? She never does it... did something happen to Aglaea?

When Mydei comes back to, he stands in Phainon’s house. He doesn’t... why is he here? There’s half a sandwich still on the counter. Something is off about it. Something is *off*.

“Agy, I... I got him. I should—“

“Thank you, Cifera,” Aglaea says strangely subdued and she reaches out, holding Cipher’s arm and pulling her close. If Mydei weren’t so sure of

himself, he'd say that her voice is trembling. Her voice *never* trembles. She doesn't cling on Cipher for comfort. They're in Phainon's house.

"Mydeimos," Aglaea breathes shakily. "I am—so sorry."

No.

He looks toward the doorway Aglaea and Ciper are half-standing in. From here, he can only see half of Castorice. His feet move of their own accord and he doesn't look; he doesn't turn his head. He can't see Hyacine, can't *see* the bed, but he can hear her hefty sobs.

No.

"Lord Mydei," Castorice says, voice forlorn and heavy, "it was—when I arrived, it was already—"

Castorice no longer cries for the departed, but she weeps with all her heart. And still, here he can hear the tears on her voice.

No.

He doesn't ask why she came here at all, if it became routine the past month or if Phainon had texted her, asking to come over—it doesn't matter. He just stares blankly ahead, acutely aware of his own breathing. His heart thumbs in his chest, ringing in his ears like a drum. If Phainon didn't eat the sandwich, Mydei is going to push it down his throat regardless. The sandwich is half-finished. He doesn't want to turn his head. If he doesn't look, it's not real. He's not usually such a coward, but this is *Phainon*.

In the end, he does look. Maybe he can delude himself into thinking that Phainon's just still asleep. He lays so still on the bed, after all, not even a breath leaving his chest. He looks just a little worse than when Mydei left him this morning. He should have... maybe he should've woken Phainon up, just to say good-bye.

"What," he asks flatly, "happened?"

“The,” Hyacine starts to hiccup, “the corruption *hic* ran so deep, Dei *hic* there was *hic* nothing I could *do*!”

“On your mission,” Castorice jumps in, only slightly more composed, “Lord Phainon must’ve gotten corrupted by the black tide. I... I should’ve known when he collapsed in the baths after his return, but I—I foolishly believed when he assured me he was fine.”

“It’s not your fault, Princess Homebody,” Cipher throws in, “if the Delivery Boy was—I mean, if he didn’t wanna say. Don’t beat yourself up about it.”

“Lord Phainon is dead, Lady Cipher. I am doing far more than *beating myself up*.”

Cipher slinks back a little, ashamed, and Aglaea holds her tight, not saying anything.

Dead.

No.

Phainon can’t be dead, Phainon can *never* be dead. There has to be... there has to be *something* he can do. He is Mydeimos the Undying, the Conqueror, eternal victor of the battlefield. And yet here he stands, rooted to the spot, and he’s never been weaker.

“Out of the way!” A new voice shouts, but Mydei hardly registers it. Phainon, dead and silent on the bed.

“Let me through, woman!”

A blurry flash of green rushes past his peripheral vision and Mydei blinks. This is... Anaxagoras. The great scholar of the grove, and Phainon’s beloved teacher.

“Phainon of Aedes Elysiae!”

Anaxagoras has jumped on the bed, panting out of breath and he shakes the man’s shoulders, making them both bounce on the bed.

“What do you *think* you’re doing? You owe me at *least* fifteen more essays on the superiority on dromases! Open your eyes!”

He leans close to Phainon’s still form, noses almost touching but Phainon does not move. Anaxagoras balls his hands into fist and tension flows out of his shoulders; and he almost sags.

“Pro—*hic*—Professor Anaxa...”

He pays her no mind.

“No matter,” he says, mainly to himself, “I can fix this. It’ll be an easy feat. Defying death itself? Ha! Nothing is impossible with alchemy.”

He gets up and hurries out of the room, only to be stopped by Aglaea’s hand on his arm. She’s not holding him tight, but he still stops regardless.

“Anaxagoras,” she says, voice as old as her years, “you are aware I cannot let you continue.”

“Is he not your golden boy, Aglaea? Are you content with his still body? I, for one—“

“*What,* Anaxagoras. Use alchemy to return him to life? You sacrificed your eye to simply *glimpse* at your sister again. What would the cost be for a life? Your brain? Your body? Your soul? Your *heart*? Phainon,” she stops herself, taking a deep breath and pulling Cipher closer, “did not simply perish. He fell to corruption. I wish—I would throw you in golden fire if it would bring him back, Anaxagoras, and I am aware you’d do the same to me. I would *let* you. But if you were to sacrifice yourself—is that truly a burden you’d wish to impede Phainon with?”

Anaxagoras slightly turns his head towards her, not answering. He lowers his head and turns his body towards the room again.

“If he would live,” he quietly says before stepping back into the room. He passes straight by Mydei and halts before Castorice, holding out his hand.

Castorice closes her eyes and nods in thanks. Anaxagoras lingers a little, before he walks around the bed and kneels down next to Hyacine.

“Hyacine,” he tells her, “I know you did all you could.”

She lifts her head from the bed, tears still streaking down her face and she hiccups, throwing herself in his arms. She wails against his chest, not being able to form coherent words or phrases, and Anaxagoras simply rubs her back, pressing his face against her hair.

Mydei turns his gaze back on Phainon. Corruption… now he understands the purpose of the bandage. He should’ve looked. He should’ve looked, and maybe—maybe what? Suck it out of him?

“I don’t understand,” he says, “how did it take this long?”

“You’re right,” Hyacine agrees, still sniffling, but having shed most of her tears for now. “While we Heirs are somewhat resistant to the black tide, we’re hardly immune. For a normal person, the transformation is near-instantaneous, but even taking the resistance in mind, four weeks is… excessive.”

“Might it be possible,” Castorice throws in, hands still tightly clasped, “that Lord Phainon was waking for Lord Mydei to wake? I’ve seen many people defy death until they see their loved ones one last time.”

“Maybe,” Hyacine sniffles, “but with how aggressive the corruption usually is, that sounds like a non-possibility.”

“He didn’t transform, either,” Cipher remarks from Aglaea’s side. They have interwoven their fingers.

“That’s right, so… in short, I don’t know. It… it doesn’t even matter. If he’d only come to me, maybe I could’ve…”

“Can you clean the corruption now?” Mydei asks.

Hyacine blinks, then looks down at Phainon. “I… think so? Are you worried he might turn?”

Mydei shakes his head. If Phainon didn't turn until now, he never will. But he… he can't let this be the way it ends. He's immortal. He should use it.

"The River of Souls is stagnant," he says instead.

"Ah," Anaxagoras nods, "his soul might not have yet reached the afterlife. What a peculiar thought, Mydeimos. I see why Phainon is so enraptured with you. Let's make haste, then."

He stands up and looks at Phainon, reaching forth a hand to brush through Phainon's hair. Mydei regrets not having taking a bath together yesterday.

"However," Anaxagoras warns, "a soul is a delicate thing and unlike you, us plebeians cannot force our soul to turn back. How will you transport him back?"

Mydei falls silent. He hadn't thought that far.

Anaxagoras eyes him silently, and then he reaches inside his coat, procuring an empty vial.

"This," he states in great grandeur, "is a soul phial that I just happen to have on me. Once you locate Phainon's soul, all you need to do is convince him to go into the phial and then you return to life as usual. Surely that's something you can manage?"

"I never heard of a soul phial before."

"It's a real thing," Cipher says quickly, "I see them in rich guys' vaults like all the time. They don't sell, so I never take them, but that's what they are. Stores one good soul just right, just like grove boy here said."

Mydei frowns. He's not convinced. But why would they lie to him? He reaches out and takes the little bottle. It looks so unassuming and— Phainon's soul is meant to fit inside that? He supposes souls aren't corporal, so it shouldn't be a problem, but still…

"Don't think so much, Mydeimos," Anaxagoras continues, "or is that simple task too much for you? I would go in your stead, but why ease

Aglaea’s life of this burden?”

“No, it’s fine,” Mydei says and closes his fingers around the vial. He can do this. He won’t give up. He’s lost all his friends, he will *not* lose Phainon as well. Phainon is too important.

“Castorice,” he turns to her, “will you grant me death’s embrace?”

Hesitating, she clasps her hands tighter together. He knows it’s cruel to ask it of her. Phainon is still wearing one of Mydei’s gauntlets. He takes a step closer to her.

“I will return,” he re-assures her and she turns her head away.

“I know,” her voice is tightly pressed, “but it isn’t easy. What if my touch… is final, Lord Mydei?”

“Then I will gladly take my last breath in the embrace of a friend.”

Her eyes widen and she looks up at him. Steeling herself with a steadying breath, she nods and steps forward, embracing him. He closes his arms around her, hugging her close.

“Your hands are warm,” he says, feeling death lap at his heels, “one day, the Deliverer will not be able to stop holding them.”

The last thing he feels is her squeezing him tight. Her body against his is such a comforting thing. He thinks he understands now, when she speaks of the flowers at the end of the westwind. Maybe one of the first things he’ll do in Era Nova is hugging Castorice.

*

Mydei wakes slowly. He doesn’t remember falling asleep, if he’s honest. He groans and sits up, rubbing his head. What… was he doing? There’s

something nagging at the back of his head. Maybe it’s just a headache. No, that’s not right.

“Mydeimos!”

He blinks and looks over, seeing Hephaestion waving at him from the camp they set up. Right… he remembers that. He doesn’t really, but… it doesn’t feel strange to him, either. He frowns, rubs his temple and gets up to walk over to them.

“Are you alright? That nap knocked you out, huh?”

“No naptime could defeat me.”

“Of course not!” Peucesta is quick to proclaim. “The mighty lion conquers naptime in one fell swoop!”

Mydeimos frowns. That sounds an awful lot like mockery. However, he decides to let it fly. These are his friends, and it was a jest, anyhow. Mydeimos settles in next to Hephaestion and observes the—camp. It feels odd, somehow. There’s fish on the fire. His friends never used to favour fish... he has to admit he is partial to it, after having sustained on nothing but sea creatures for the first years of his life. So why...?

Let’s get married—

“We should make haste,” he says, “to Okhema.”

“Okhema?” Leonnius asks. “Have you set your eye on the holy city, Mydeimos? I’ve no doubt we can do it, but taking it *will* be difficult.”

Taking it? Frowning, he lifts his head. He’s never said anything about seizing it, has he?

“No... they are our allies. On the flame-chase journey.”

“My, Mydeimos,” Perdikkas worries, “have you caught a fever? The Holy City has been our enemy since ancient times.”

“I *know*,” Mydei insists, “I’ve not taken ill. Okhema is our ally; has been for a long time.”

“Perhaps he’s had a dream,” Ptolemy muses, “of distant days in distant realities?”

“No, no, I believe Mydeimos,” Hephaestion says, smiling, “if he declares Okhema our ally, then so they will be—whether they want to or not. Right?”

Mydeimos is slow to nod. Right. Only—that’s not how. An alliance cannot be forced, for if it is forced, it is no other than servitude. Everything feels... wrong, somehow, as if there was a thick fog cloud over his mind. Hadn’t he had a mission? Something important?

He’s missing his right gauntlet for some reason. He doesn’t remember unclasping it and putting it away. Someone... took it, didn’t they? But he feels no panic rising at the thought; more like quiet content. Like he’s pleased by it. Like his missing gauntlet is staking a claim somewhere.

He flexes his fingers. Something’s wrong.

—once tomorrow comes.

“Where’s Phainon?”

“Impressive,” an unknown face says behind him. Mydei had not even heard them approach, so his hackles rise and he jumps about and around, raising his arms. Before him stands a black-clad swordsman, but Mydei can’t make the face out. The voice is—odd, almost familiar, but he still can’t place it.

“I truly thought I would have to shatter the memory to free you from it.”

“Who are you?”

The swordsman remains silent, face turned towards him. Oddly enough, he seems to think about the question. Seeing as he does not raise his sword, Mydei lowers his fists as well. It’d be best if he would not try to engage

with an enemy he can't read properly—especially on an important mission like his own.

"Khaos," the swordsman settles on, "it will serve well enough."

"Khaos," Mydei repeats and it feels odd on his tongue. Everything is *odd*. It never used to be like this. Castorice's embrace cannot have played such a huge factor, can it? No matter, he's better off not telling her.

"What do you want?"

Khaos remains still, like a statue. "Your mission," he states, "is of utmost importance. You should see it through."

His mission... Mydei balls his fists again. How does this *Khaos* know of Mydei's mission? And why should it be of *utmost* importance to him? If Phainon were to remain dead, a new world-bearer would emerge sooner or later, no matter how much the thought hurts.

"How do you know? Why do you care?"

"While you waste breath," Khaos says, undeterred, "Phainon slips away." The man turns his head upstream and remains still. It's eerie, the way he doesn't even seem to breathe.

"Then get out of my way."

"I am not an obstacle. Not yet, anyway. Isn't Strife about forcing a path despite the hindrances?"

"What would you know of Strife? I have no intention to fight you."

Khaos lowers his head slightly, in a manner that feels achingly familiar and yet, so alien.

"I know more than enough. Tell me instead, where will you go from here?"

Mydei frowns. He's not sure, actually. In past visits, he would occasionally encounter people from his past, but the chance that those were simply

memories is high. Phainon, however... Phainon's soul should still be here; and not a memory. He's just always wandered straight to the end, so to find someone... if Castorice was here, maybe she'd have an idea.

"It is of no concern to you."

Khaos moves his head up, casting a glance at the sky.

"It *concerns* me a great deal, Mydeimos. Still... your thoughts do not matter; not to me. Answer me instead. Where will you go? How will you retrieve Phainon before there is nothing left?"

"By walking," Mydei replies and starts. He's not nervous as he passes Khaos by, but the man—he feels so hot; and so cold at the same time. Phainon has to be *somewhere*, and Mydei will not leave until he has found him. It doesn't matter how long it takes. He *will* retrieve Phainon.

"The golden fields," Khaos says, "the golden fields of Aedes Elysiae always burn."

Mydei doesn't turn around. But—what better way to entice Phainon than Aedes Elysiae? If he can spot that famed golden wheat Phainon cannot go one day without yapping about, then he'll find the Deliverer.

"You know where to go," Mydei simply states.

"Yes," comes the reply. Mydei has never seen him before, and he has been here many times. Did this man die? How does he move about the river if he did not? And this aching feeling... no. No, it doesn't matter. Phainon is all that counts.

"If you care about Phainon so much, then why not go save him yourself?"

Khaos is silent for a moment, and Mydei holds his breath. "I am no saviour," he finally says, "never have been and never will. I could never save Phainon, but you can. In every life, every form, always; as it has always been."

Mydei contemplates for a moment. He could be stubborn, and insist on finding Phainon himself—it would have a certain romance to it, he supposes, but this is a battlefield; and not a story told to children. But if this Khaos knows where to go... if he knows where Phainon is... Souls in the river are fickle things, and even with the waters being as stagnant as they are, Phainon might still just vanish after all.

“You can take me there.”

“It is,” the man replies, “within my capabilities. However, is victory served on a platter worth it?”

“You urge me to hurry,” Mydei mocks, “yet you dare question me for utilising the tools at my disposal?”

“A tool, am I?”

Khaos’ voice sounds almost mocking, when before his cadence had stayed rather monotone. If Mydei had more time, maybe, then he could dedicate the time to properly think about his thoughts; but as things stand, he cannot afford it.

“Yes,” Mydei confirms, “you’re either a hindrance or a tool. You pick.”

“Can I not be both?”

“No,” Mydei growls, “pick or leave me in peace. I’ve no business with you.”

“You’re right,” Khaos agrees, “you do not. Not yet, anyway.”

He comes closer until he hovers right behind Mydei’s back. He stiffens a little, but he won’t let it show. For one, he is already dead, and second, there is no way this man could know... right? Still, he is uneasy.

Khaos leans over, still and un-breathing. It’s perhaps the weirdest presence Mydei has felt in a long time and he almost startles when the man lifts his hand—it almost looks like he’s wearing a golden gauntlet, but that must be

coincidence. Gauntlets are not uncommon. In his fingers he holds a wind-chime. It looks a little crudely made, as if by a child.

“The sound,” Khaos says and drops the chime in Mydei’s hands, “follow the rabbits.”

Mydei frowns and whips his head around to ask what the *fuck* that means but—as he does, Khaos is gone, like he never even existed. Mydei closes his fist around the chime and looks around. He’s not—who *was* that? There are things he’d rather not think about. He closes his eyes and releases a breath before he looks at the chime. The sound... the rabbits. What the hell? Is this a fairy tale all of a sudden? Nevertheless, he lifts the chime and sounds it. He doesn’t expect anything to happen, if he’s being honest. And yet...

In the corner of his eye, he sees a pink *something* dash away, but it’s gone before he can properly see it. He blinks furiously and shakes his head for clarity, but it doesn’t change the fact that he *saw* something. He doesn’t *hallucinate*, and he doesn’t question his own perception. If only he had caught the direction that thing had dashed off to...

And then, he hears a distant sound—the sound of a wind chime. Mydei doesn’t hesitate, and he dashes off. Even if Khaos was lying to him—and Mydei doesn’t believe that—he has no other leads anyway.

As he dashes across the stagnant land of Styxia, he can hear his mother’s voice call out to him. This isn’t new. In death, she’s the only constant, and he’s never given in to her. He wonders now, however, what she would think about Phainon. The Deliverer has proven himself a warrior worth his mettle, who shies from no challenge or competition. Maybe Phainon would’ve challenged her to a duel to gain her respect, and Mydei wonders who would’ve won that fight. Maybe in the new world, he’ll find out. Maybe in the new world, his father won’t go mad, and they can tag-team, two-on-two. Maybe in the new world, Mydei could court Phainon in whatever way Aedes Elysiae does courting; and Phainon can participate in the Kremnoan Festival with him. His mother would approve, he’s sure. He wonders if their mothers would get along—Phainon never mentions his parents. Maybe, when they return, Mydei will ask.

The wind chime rings clear now, and when Mydei blinks, he is surrounded by golden fields of wheat. Stunned, he looks around, and the place—is beautiful, but feels hollow. He can see houses in the far distance, but they are beyond reach and honestly, they feel more like set dressing from a theatre play. Something is so terribly wrong about this place, and Mydei should never have been here.

“Oh, Mydei,” the voice says and Mydei breathes, but the illusion doesn’t shatter. The tranquillity remains, and it sends shivers down his spine.

“Deliverer,” he responds, slowly turning. Before him stands Phainon, hearty and hale, dressed down. His right arm still dons the gauntlet he stole off of Mydei. However, Phainon doesn’t seem to be aware of it. In his arms he holds a book Mydei doesn’t recognise. It looks a little like the scrap book Hyacine and Castorice have started ages ago. He remembers the Deliverer eagerly participating upon request.

“No need to be so formal, Mydei,” Phainon laughs, “I’m no Deliverer.”

“But you are,” Mydei protests.

“...yes, I am. But not here. Nobody needs a Deliverer here.”

“All of Amphoreus needs a Deliverer—this place included.”

Phainon pulls a small face. He’s displeased and if these were normal circumstances, Mydei would expect Phainon to participate in a competition he wouldn’t tell Mydei about until he’s already won.

“Do *you* need a Deliverer?”

“Yes,” Mydei answers without hesitation. He needs *Phainon* and maybe, he thinks, he should’ve thought about what he was going to say; rather than going in blind. It’s too late for that now, however.

“Fine,” Phainon sighs, “then I’ll be the Deliverer.”

Somewhat relieved, he steps a bit closer and starts to outstretch his hand. How he’s going to get Phainon stuffed into the vial is another mystery. That

teacher isn’t very good at explaining things, is he?

“Good,” Mydei says, “then let’s go home.”

“Home?” Phainon laughs. “Mydei, I *am* home. Aedes Elysiae, just the way I remember it. Everyone’s here, too! Why would I ever need to leave? If I need to deliver anything, I can do it from here, right? Hey, do you want to meet them? I’m sure they’ll like you! They’ve never met a prince before, so you’ll be the talk of the town for the next two years!”

He reaches out and grabs Mydei’s hand and he wants to resist, initially. The houses in the distance aren’t real, so they will never get closer. But, instead, he lets Phainon drag him away. What’s the harm? They’ll never reach anything and maybe if Mydei complies, Phainon will be more willing to listen.

“My mom makes the best bread,” Phainon says, “and dad can tell the best jokes. We have our own field, you know? I help with harvest, assuming I don’t sneak away to slack off. You’ll love the bread from our own wheat! I help mom make it sometimes, but I can never quite get it right... she says the secret ingredient is love, but that’s not right, is it? One day, mark my words, I will conquer breading!”

That’s not... whatever. Mydei sighs and looks at Phainon. He looks younger, now that Mydei can spare more thoughts on it. He still resembles the Deliverer he knows, so—*when* exactly did Aedes Elysiae burn down?

As Phainon drags him through the endless fields, never getting closer to the actual village, Mydei thinks living here would’ve been nice. If he could have washed up here instead of into the arms of the detachment, maybe he could’ve tried to have a nicer childhood. Maybe he could’ve played games with Phainon and the other children living here. Maybe he and Phainon would still have competed who could climb the tree faster. He would’ve won, of course.

Maybe, in the next life, the world will be kinder to them. But they’re not in that world yet, and if Phainon stays here, they might never even make it there at all.

“That book you’re holding,” he asks, “what is it?”

Not once has Phainon looked back at him while dragging him through the fields.

“Ah, this one?” Even now, he barely turns. “It’s Cyrene’s book. I’m just holding it for her.”

“Why?”

Phainon stops moving and lets his hand slip away from Mydei’s. It would be easy to go move in front of him, but it feels wrong. The wind brushes past his hair and the wheat follows in a gentle wave. He can almost hear children laughing; almost smell the promised bread and almost hear the gentle rhythm of a swing.

“She,” Phainon stop-starts for a while, clearly struggling. “She says the book holds my future.”

Mydei frowns. He’s never heard of such a book, but they *are* currently dead, so he supposes anything goes. *And* Phainon’s village did worship Oronyx, so the future isn’t too far-fetched a concept.

“What does it say, then? If you’re too scared, I can look for you.”

Phainon moves, putting his hand on the cover. From behind him, the cover is blank and bland. Did it look like that before? No... he’s sure it reminded him of something before. Now it just looks like a sad, forgotten little thing.

“No, no,” Phainon says quickly, “I mean, I was a little worried. What if it said I’ll die to like, I don’t know, the flu? Something embarrassing like that, but I did look, eventually. Guess curiosity killed the Deliverer, huh? Anyway...”

He turns around, and Mydei’s eyes are drawn to the book. How odd. He wanted to look at Phainon first. He frowns, then, when Phainon begins to shuffle through the pages. That... that makes no sense. Why...?

“As you can see,” Phainon sighs, “all the pages are empty. At first I thought it was just a prank, you know, but... Cyrene isn’t even here to see my reaction, and she wouldn’t do that to me. So, what does that mean, then? Why is there nothing there?”

He puts his fingers on a blank page and almost caresses it. His fingernails look nice. They’re well-kept and healthy.

“I’m sure Professor Anaxa would say that this is a sign for endless possibilities—so many that these pages could never hold them, therefore leaving them blank. That’s a nice thought, isn’t it? Even though he pretends not to care, he actually cares so much. Did you know that he found me once, when I tried to kill myself? He didn’t even tell Lady Hyacine or Miss Castorice. He called me stupid, wasteful and lazy, but he stayed by my side until the bleeding stopped. He even made excuses for me the next day; that I had helped him all night with an experiment, which is why I didn’t show up for classes. I slept in his office for a while, and after that, he would occasionally sleep over in my dorm room.”

Solemnly, Phainon turns a page.

“Or,” he says, “it might mean that there simply is no future at all. That I’ll never go beyond this point, that this is where I end. It wouldn’t be so bad, you know, to end here. Everyone else did, too. Did you know, that after—I collected them all and dragged them away; dug graves for all of them? I carved their names onto sticks and placed them nice and neatly. At some points, I wanted to dig a grave for me too, because dying here with them would’ve been kinder. They can’t despise me for not saving them if I, too, died here.”

He turns another page. The wind has stopped and the sound is too loud in that eerie silence surrounding them.

“Or perhaps,” he says, “it’s a future so insignificant that it’s not even worth remembering. That whatever I do, it’ll amount to nothing and will change nobody’s life for the better. I would never bring anybody happiness, and would never remain a fond memory in someone’s life. Whether I lived or died wouldn’t matter, because nothing I do matters. I save nothing and no

one, and will eventually end in a grave so overgrown nobody even knows it was ever there."

"Your future," Mydei breathes, still unable to look at Phainon's face, "is to deliver us. You will bring the new dawn. You'll become the dawn, Deliverer."

There's a distant sound of chimes.

"*May this world never again need a Deliverer*," he says, musing, as if someone said that to him before. "You know, when we were children, we'd draw cards to determine our future. People would get the knight card, or a princess, or just a hunter—but me, without fail, in every life, in every form, always; I would always draw the Deliverer card. I can't be the Deliverer. How could I be the Deliverer? The Deliverer is a person worthy of love and trust, with no flaws or faults, and the only person that could fulfil Era Nova. So I'll be the Deliverer. I'll be the Deliverer. Look."

Phainon procures a card from who-knows-where and he shows it to Mydei.

"Nothing," he says, putting the card in Mydei's hands, "nothing weighs heavier than this."

Mydei has to steel himself, for the man tells no lie: this card is heavier than many things Mydei has lifted in his life. Looking up, he can finally glance at Phainon's face and he gasps: he is cracked all over. A piece of his neck is missing, his left eye has crumbled away, and his skin looks like marble. This... isn't what black tide corruption does to you, is it? Maybe Chrysos Heirs are different; maybe Phainon is different—

The chimes are getting louder.

"I didn't tell anyone about it," he says, "because by then, it was too late. I tried taking a bath while Castorice was away, but the water burned. I tried cutting it out, but even I dare not bleed myself dry. I had hoped that perhaps I am immune, or near it, and it would just—go away on its own, or at least, not get any worse. I didn't want to worry Hyacine, because what could she do? Two weeks in, and I was sure it'd be fine. Of course, I felt terrible, but

that was a price I was willing to pay. My body burns, and I could feel it dissolve my insides. I didn’t want to die, but dying here isn’t so bad, is it?”

“You can’t stay,” Mydei whispers, still struggling to hold the card.

“I know,” that version of Phainon says, forlorn. “Can’t die before the end, right? I tried really hard, Mydei, I swear. Going home would’ve been nice. But I can’t see them again, right? Never again. In the new world... it doesn’t matter. You came all this way for me, didn’t you? Sorry about that. I could’ve found my own way out of here, if I were stronger, but I guess you know this place better, right? Haha...”

“Come back with me,” Mydei pleads. “Anaxagoras gave me a vial for your soul. With you inside, I can return to the living, and we can return your soul to your body—it’s not too late yet.”

“A vial, huh...” Phainon muses. “Alright. My soul—Phainon’s soul will be in that vial, as long as you take that card out with you. Don’t lose it, yeah? The card for the Deliverer... give it to its rightful owner, will you?”

The sound of chimes echoes directly in his ears now.

As Mydei blinks, Phainon is different—he wears the clothes of Khaos now. He stands amidst the burning fields of Aedes Elysiae. Mydei breathes.

“This, in your heart, will fade, Mydeimos,” he says and he doesn’t understand how he didn’t hear it before. “Losses are a constant on the flame-chase journey, and we never should have loved each other. Love will just make worse, always, in every life, and in every form. I will kill you, and your library is burned, as it has always been. The golden fields of Aedes Elysiae always burn, and we will destroy each other.”

Mydei feels himself getting weaker, indicating he’s waking up. He can see the flames clearly, but Phainon is fading away, and the houses in the distance have never existed. The swing has stopped forever, and nobody will ever sit on it ever again.

“Tell me what future the book holds in your mind, will you? Maybe if it were yours, one book would not be enough to record your future. I think... I just wanted—“

Mydei never hears the end of it, and the flames consume the withered golden fields until nothing is left.

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Mydei wakes with a start, breathing hard. He sits up in a hurry, panting. His heart is beating too fast, and his eyes dart around. He’s in—a room. Not a battlefield. Good. That means he’s not in immediate danger.

“Impressive,” he hears a voice from off the side. “Both that woman and Castorice kept telling me you returning from the dead is not something they made up for fun. I would love to study you later. However, more pressing matters first: did you succeed?”

“Anaxagoras,” he breathes and blinks and the green-haired man.

“You even remember my name. Should I be honoured the savage royalty remembers me?”

Mydei frowns. He’s hardly savage. Hells, he’s hardly *royalty*. Aglaea is more royal than him.

“No,” he responds curtly and pulls out the vial. It is filled with a gentle golden glow. “Yes.”

Anaxagoras gets out of his chair and walks over, snatching the vial out of Mydei’s hand.

“Fascinating, truly fascinating.” His eye sparkles with excitement. “Why, if it weren’t so important, I would love to run some experiments with it. But I guess Phainon has given me enough already.”

“How long was I gone?”

“Shorter than expected,” Anaxagoras says, not looking at him. He holds the vial gently now, cupped in his palm like a fledging bird. “It has been barely more than a day. I sent Hyacine and Castorice off to sleep—they’ll be quite upset you chose to return now. Did you run into any trouble?”

“No, I,” Mydei stops-starts. He hesitates. There had been... something else, besides Phainon, hadn’t there? He can’t remember clearly. He shakes his head.

“Finding him was difficult at first, but I managed just fine. Now, the vial. How do we return the soul inside?”

Anaxagoras gets up and moves over to Phainon. He looks just like before, still as a doll and unmoving. Mydei hates it. Phainon isn’t even all quiet when he sleeps; he should *never* be this still. It’s not alright.

Anaxagoras straddles Phainon’s hips and Mydei frowns—is that a necessary step in the procedure? Anaxagoras holds the vial in his left hand, and he flexes his right for some reason. Suddenly, Mydei has a bad feeling about this.

“Who knows? The wonders of alchemy—you can’t bake a cake without breaking some eggs now, can you?!”

With that, he slightly tosses the vial in the air; and he smashes it on the way down.

“No, what are you doing?!”

As the fist makes contact with the vial and shatters it, a small golden explosion sounds and Anaxagoras gets blasted away against the next-best wall, while Mydei manages to shield his eyes from it. Checking quickly, he can assure that the man had not getting seriously hurt, so Mydei rushes over to Phainon.

His hands find the man’s shoulders, shaking him gently. For a moment, nothing happens, and then his eyelids flutter. Mydei’s heart skips a beat in relief. It worked, it really worked...!

“Deliverer,” he breathes and Phainon’s nose scrunches up. The man blinks and he looks up at Mydei with hazy eyes. His eyes are yellow, like the blazing sun, but after Mydei blinks, and Phainon blinks as well, his eyes are as blue as the sky again. Perhaps he imagined things.

“Mydei...?”

“Damn you, Deliverer,” Mydei cusses, “you got us all worried.”

“Ah... sorry...?”

Mydei smiles and leans down, pressing his forehead against Phainon.

“Don’t ever die before me again, Deliverer. I promised, didn’t I? If you die before me, I’ll kill you myself.”

“You... always did hold all your promises,” Phainon laughs quietly. His voice is weak and something tickles the back of Mydei’s head, but he can’t remember. Maybe it’ll come to him later. Phainon is back, and everything else can wait.

“I do,” he says, “and the two of us have a promise for tomorrow. I’m not letting you go, Deliverer. *My* Deliverer. Don’t ever go somewhere I cannot follow.”

“Okay,” Phainon agrees quietly, “until tomorrow and beyond, then.”

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“Until tomorrow and beyond, then,” he says. “But tomorrow never comes.”

Before him lies Mydeimos, dead and slain, cut swiftly through his tenth thoracic vertebra, just like all the times before. Now, it doesn’t even matter if the prince shares his weakness, for he would only ever needed to have revealed it once, and yet, without fail, that weak-spot is always entrusted to Phainon. Khaslana wonders if Mydeimos ever thought it would get used against him like this.

Before him lies Mydeimos, in a pool of his own blood, and the blood crowns his head in gold. The son of Gorgo will be crowned in blood, as it has always been. There is no other crown for Castrum Kremnos, and there never will be, because tomorrow is a lie. Tomorrow still sits among the distant stars, and Khaslana wonders how much longer it will be until the Deliverer comes.

“You never did say what the book said,” he muses, “and you never returned that card to me, either. Maybe the book never said anything, and you truly were holding the card for the Deliverer.”

Khaslana closes his eyes, and he doesn’t know if it’s in pain or not. He’s not the Deliverer, never has been, never could be, so... why? Why does it hurt thinking about someone agreeing with him about it? He’s just Khaslana, eternal Scourge of Amphoreus. Maybe the true Deliverer will pierce whatever is left of his heart, when they finally arrive.

“May you never remember the pain of death, Mydeimos,” he whispers, brushing golden hair out of his face. “All hail Mydeimos, the greatest conqueror, the mightiest protector, the strongest of them all. They dying lion, eyes blazing, the king with no kingdom.”

Selfishly, he leans down and presses his lips against a cooling forehead.

“May the Son of Gorgo be crowned in flowers.”

And as Khaslana leaves to stop Era Nova; to reset the cycle, to return to the ever-lasting yesterday; a singular blue flower blooms next to the head of the dead king, and its petals will flutter on the west wind once tomorrow comes.

End Notes

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